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Thus Spoke the Khan's Grand Advisor

By Uzo Z.T.

Chapter 1: The Fabric of Fate

The great steppe, sandwiched in wind and sand.

Fu Yuan, the Grand Advisor, sits atop a colossal boulder like a dark, watchful eagle. Behind him, his black cloak — the wings — snaps impatiently.

He gazes at the distant sunset.

“Do you know what fate is?

It is like wind — formless and unseen, yet everywhere at once. It is like desert sand — right under your feet, yet its whole can never be grasped.”

A disciple asks, “If fate is without form, then how do we master it?”

“Master it?” Fu Yuan scoffs. “Fate cannot be mastered! Can you master wind? Can you control sand? Yet you can use wind to fill sails, and sand to build cities. The Fabric of Fate spreads under your feet. Those seemingly useless snags are its clues.”

Another disciple frowns. “But the snags are so small. What use could they be?”

Fu Yuan sweeps over him with his cold gaze.

“Small?” His voice is sharp. “Only because your sight is narrow does its weight escape you. Have you heard of the eagle catching the wind? It soars in the gale because it knows how to borrow the storm’s fury. If it only knew how to hide, it would be nothing but a caged bird.”

“So it is with the fabric of fate. If you are blind to them, you are not a man. You are a speck of dust on that fabric.”

Fu Yuan rises, shaking out his cloak.

“But not every snag should be pulled. Some are the tails of venomous snakes; pull one, and you invite endless suffering. But others are the reins of a heavenly steed; grasp one, and you will see a higher plane of destiny.

How do you tell the difference? That — is your own fate.”

The disciples fall silent.

Fu Yuan gives a humorless smile.

“Very well. I will give you one last truth: These snags are not for the weak. Those destined to be dust will never see the patterns in the fabric. But the truly strong — they require no teaching from me. They will leverage the snags to weave patterns of their own.”

He turns his back on them and walks into the depth of the steppe, leaving only the wind and sand to whisper in their ears.

Chapter 2: The Moon and the Finger

Deep twilight settles.

Fu Yuan stands before the husk of a temple, surrounded by monks and believers, their faces masks of piety. Inside, an idol presides — eyes vacant, face cold. Incense smoke coils toward the rafters as the air thickens with the taste of scorching ash.

An old monk collapses to his knees, his voice trembling.

"Grand Advisor! Your grace is as sacred as this idol. We will honor you as the living truth. We will follow you, we will sustain you!"

The others drop in a wave, foreheads striking the dust. A chant rises: "The Grand Advisor is merciful! The Grand Advisor is boundless!"

Fu Yuan looks down at the prostrate mass, a cold sneer on his lips. He lifts a boot and plants it on the idol's pedestal.

"You cannot see the moon's splendor, because you only know how to kiss my toes. And even if one of you looks up, your eyes never leave the finger I point with."

The crowd freezes. They lift their heads, their eyes blank with incomprehension.

Fu Yuan's gaze sweeps over them, his voice a roll of thunder.

“Worship is a shackle, not a liberation. The abject soul who kneels before gods and gurus has no right to speak of Enlightenment! Do you think bowing and scraping can be traded for truth?

Truth demands no kneeling! You kneel to your own cowardice. You worship your own fear.”

A young monk flinches, stammering. “But… are the gods not supreme? We are only mortals. How can we compare ourselves to them?”

Fu Yuan gives him a glacial look.

“If you believe you are mortal, then a mortal you will remain. Truth has no pity for slaves. It favors only those who dare to meet the gods’ gaze as equals.”

He says nothing more.

He turns and walks away, leaving the monks paralyzed in the dirt. Before the ruined temple, the wind gusts, and the last of the incense flickers, on the verge of dying out.

It is as if the gods themselves are laughing at their folly.

Chapter 3: The Cycle of the Waves

Deep in the night, the sea glitters under a cold moon, The boat cuts like a blade through the swells.

Fu Yuan stands alone at the prow, his robes snapping in the wind. His gaze is locked on the rise and fall of the waves, his focus so absolute he could be deciphering a celestial script.

At the rudder, the boatman hesitates. Finally, he finds his courage.

“Grand Advisor,” he asks, his voice low, “these waves... you watch them with such intensity. Forgive me, but are you searching for something?”

Fu Yuan does not turn.

“And what do you imagine I am searching for?”

The boatman bows his head. “It is beyond me. It is just...” his voice trembling, “a wave is such a fleeting thing. A moment here, then gone. How can it hold any real meaning?”

A cold laugh escapes Fu Yuan’s lips.

“You call it fleeting because you see only the instant it crests. You fail to see that it never truly vanishes.

Each wave is a thought, given form by the ocean. In the sea’s silence, it is the sea. When it rises, it is the sea’s awareness — for a moment, gathered into a self.”

The boatman looks up, his eyes full of confusion. “But when it breaks, is it not gone forever?”

Fu Yuan turns.

“It returns to the ocean, to await the next cycle. When it rises again, it is both itself and not itself.

So too, is life.”

The boatman grips the rudder, his voice trembling with awe. “Then what is the point of our struggle? If this cycle is all there is, what can any of us truly do?”

Fu Yuan’s gaze is a torch, laying bare the boatman’s terror.

“You are a wave. You cannot escape the ocean. That is true. But you can choose how to crest.

The fool is lost in the terror of the fall. The wise, with each return, carves himself more deeply.

The sea remembers the waves that truly crest. The others are only foam, forgotten even by themselves.”

The boatman stares at the black, churning water below, lost in thought. At last, he lowers his head.

“Grand Advisor,” he whispers, “how do I make the sea... remember me?”

Fu Yuan laughs, a sharp bark of sound against the night. He looks to the horizon, where the sea meets sky.

“First, ask yourself if you can truly see the wave you are in this moment.”

The boatman says nothing more, but the hand that grips the rudder trembles. His gaze falls to the waves, and in their motion, he sees a meaning he has never seen before.

And at the prow, Fu Yuan remains, his gaze still bound to the churning sea, an expression of fierce, profound regard.

The wind passes. The waves surge. And all of creation falls silent.

Chapter 4: The Footprints of the Wild Geese

The sky is scoured clean, the autumn wind like a blade.

A cry from the wild geese rends the heavens. High above, the flock carves a battle line across the sky.

Fu Yuan stands at the precipice, his gaze pushing past the horizon, as if listening for a resonance from the edge of the world itself.

Behind him, an emissary from the Great Yuan kneels, his face carved with earnest pleading.

“Grand Advisor, the realm has descended into chaos, its people cast into misery. If you would but end your seclusion and restore the Great Yuan, you would not only pacify this age of strife, but shelter a world of souls.”

Fu Yuan does not turn.

“What is the Yuan’s fate to me?”

The emissary flinches. “Grand Advisor, was the prosperity of this realm not forged by your own hand? With our world now in ruins, how can you watch and do nothing?”

Fu Yuan’s eyes track the flock’s distant passage.

“Do you know that the geese never look back at their own footprints? Their gaze is always on what lies ahead.”

The wind from the north is a physical blow, yet sweat beads the emissary’s brow. “But... for the geese to fly, they require a vast sky,” he argues, “just as the people require the Grand Advisor’s mantle —“

Fu Yuan cuts him off with a sweep of his sleeve.

“The Mandate is withdrawn.

The prints in the mud are the Yuan’s lesson to learn. The geese have already found their own sky.”

He turns and departs, leaving the emissary to his kneeling.

His disciples press in around him, their faces alight with awe. “Master, your transcendence is absolute!”

One disciple’s gaze is a fire.

“Master, you see through the heart of all things. Why not forge a new teaching, one to surpass all others, to guide every soul in the land?

Your wisdom would echo for ten thousand generations. You would become an eternal beacon for the world!”

By now the flock is a mere thread in the heavens, yet its cry still reverberates between earth and sky. Fu Yuan stops, his eyes circling his followers.

“A goose crosses the mud, leaves a print, and soars again. Does it cross the mud for the sake of leaving a print?”

The disciples can only trade empty glances.

Fu Yuan’s voice is glacial.

“Your ‘religion’ is a scepter. Your ‘eternity’ is a cage.

True freedom is not to make the world gaze up at one beacon. It is to teach each person how to walk with the stars.”

With that, he turns his back, his robes dancing in the autumn wind, dissolving into the vast twilight.

Chapter 5: The Goshawk and Freedom

A spring wind, heavy with the scent of wild grass, sweeps across the steppes.

The grasslands come alive as warblers dart and weave. High above, goshawks ride the currents, their cries echoing in the immense quiet. Yurts scatter the plains like sleeping animals, and herds of horses graze in a deep peace.

Between earth and sky, life itself is an unstoppable tide.

Before the largest of the yurts, Fu Yuan sits on a felt rug. Mutton and wine are laid out before him, but he pours only for himself, drinking with a quiet intensity. To his side, a long-browed monk in grey robes is seated on a cushion, still as stone, eyes shut in meditation.

The silence between them is a world of its own.

Then, suddenly, the monk opens his eyes.

"Grand Advisor," he begins, his voice smooth and measured, "you believe life possesses a hierarchy, do you not?"

A dangerous light sparks in Fu Yuan's eyes. He holds the monk's gaze for a long moment, the barest hint of a smile on his lips.

"I do."

He glances at the sheep on the hillside, then at the wild horses thundering on the horizon.

"Given the choice, who would be a sheep, born only to kneel for the knife? Why not be the horse, a creature of pure, untamed spirit? Or better still..." His gaze climbs, finding a hawk circling in the deep blue. "...that goshawk, a king in its own sky?"

The old monk's smile is faint, a mask of pity.

"And you, Grand Advisor, are the great hawk of these plains. While the people of the Central Kingdoms are the sheep. This old monk has journeyed here today to plead with you: stay your talons. Do not throw yourself into the conflicts of the Central Kingdoms."

One of Fu Yuan's eyebrows arches, his stare sharp enough to cut.

The monk presses his palms together, his head bowed. "If you would but hold the suffering of the people in your heart," he murmurs, "in a single moment of compassion, you could spare all sentient beings a great calamity."

Fu Yuan laughs, a sharp, metallic sound. He raises his wine cup.

"I am the hawk — why should the bleating of sheep concern me?"

The monk shakes his head, his tone soft, yet immovable. "The Enlightened One taught us: all beings carry the Buddha-nature within; rank and station are but shadows on a wall.

The hawk and the sheep alike follow the path karma has laid for them. Grand Advisor, why hold so tightly to this illusion of strong and weak?"

Fu Yuan drains all warmth from his face. In an instant, his gaze turns cold.

"Guards!" he barks.

"Release the lamb. Roast the Master instead."

Attendants burst from the yurt, slam the monk to the ground, and bind him. The monk's face turns the color of dust. He struggles against the ropes, his voice cracking as he cries out, "A man of your stature... resorting to such barbarism! This is madness!"

A great, booming laugh escapes Fu Yuan. He waves a dismissive hand, and the guards cut the monk free.

"You preach that all are equal. So tell me, what is the difference between roasting you, and roasting a lamb?"

The monk gasps for air, pushing himself to his knees. The composure is gone, replaced by a chilling uncertainty. "Grand Advisor," he whispers, "equality is the soul of compassion. It cannot be a weapon for the strong to wield against the weak."

Fu Yuan's gaze drives into the monk like a nail.

"Your 'equality' is a pittance you grant from on high.

The sheep kneels in the dirt for the sake of survival. The hawk commands the sky for the sake of freedom. The tiers of life are not measured by strength, but by freedom."

The monk's expression is a storm of confusion and fear. "Grand Advisor," he says, his voice heavy, "here on these endless plains, what can possibly limit your freedom?

Who in this world could ever hope to constrain *you*?"

Fu Yuan's eyes look past him, past the horizon, as if to pierce the veil of the cosmos itself.

"This *world* cannot stop me. But the Heavens can.

The freedom I hunt is not from the shackles of men. It is the freedom from illusion itself — and from everything they dare to call 'truth'."

The monk can only stare, the wind whipping at his grey robes, stealing the unspoken words from his lips. At last, he lowers his head.

"If the Grand Advisor's mind is set, then this old monk has nothing more to say."

Fu Yuan gives no reply. He throws back his head and drains his cup, his eyes once again fixed on the goshawk, a solitary speck turning in the vast, silent heavens.

It is as if they are the only two beings in existence, sharing the terrible, beautiful emptiness between the earth and the sky.

Chapter 6: The Farmer and the Wheat Field

Gold light spills across a wheat field at sunset. A breeze sends it rolling in endless waves.

Fu Yuan and his disciples cut a path along its edge, stopping at an old well.

A farmer spies them from afar, drops his hoe, and hurries over, wiping sweat from his brow as he bows.

"Beggin' your pardon, Grand Advisor. Let this old farmer draw you and the masters a bucket. Please."

He rolls up his sleeves, wipes the well's stone slab clean, and gestures for Fu Yuan to sit. Fu Yuan nods, but he casts his gaze out over the wheat, lost in appreciation of its deep, silent swell.

A creak and a groan of the rope, and the farmer offers up a bucket of clear, cool water. Fu Yuan takes the offered ladle. He sips.

"Cold," he says. "But sweet."

His eyes remain fixed on the horizon.

The disciples, however, are lost in their own world.

“Brother, the Way is the Prime Mover, formless yet sovereign over the Ten Thousand Things!”

“Precisely! To apprehend its celestial architecture is to transcend this mortal dust!”

Fu Yuan listens, a shadow of a sneer on his lips as he drinks.

The farmer, standing respectfully to one side, is utterly captivated. After a moment, he dares to speak, his voice soft.

“The Way... isn’t it just like this water? Doesn’t matter who you are, if you’re thirsty, you can always draw a scoop.”

The disciples round on him. “Silence! You think a peasant can speak of the Way in the Grand Advisor’s presence?”

The farmer flinches. “I... I spoke out of turn. Forgive an old man’s foolishness.”

Fu Yuan lowers the ladle, his gaze falling upon the farmer with a flicker of genuine interest.

“He’s right.”

He turns on his disciples.

“What the hell does the Way have to do with you? His words have more truth than a thousand volumes of your nonsense.”

They fall silent.

Fu Yuan turns back to the farmer. “You can read the Truth in the well water and the wheat field. Why not walk with me? See what lies beyond them.”

The farmer is speechless. His lips move, but no words come. He just bows his head. “ Grand Advisor, I’m a tiller of the earth, nothing more. How could I dare? I’m a simple man. I have no other skills.”

Fu Yuan’s gaze holds him — sharp, but now with a strange warmth. He points toward the fields.

“Does any stalk of wheat in your field stop growing because it is short?”

The farmer shakes his head.

“Does it refuse to ripen because it envies the one next to it?”

Again, he shakes his head.

Fu Yuan’s voice cracks like a whip.

“Then why, because you are a farmer, are you content to be a seed that never breaks the soil?!”

He sees the terror in the man’s eyes and scoffs.

“Transcendence is not a prize for the clever. Those monks and their endless chanting are just sheep circling in the mud.

Better to be a foolish stalk of wheat, always reaching up, than a sheep forever on its knees.”

The farmer stands frozen, the ladle trembling in his hand. Shame and a spark of something new war in his eyes.

Fu Yuan gives him no further glance. He turns and leaves.

The wheat field rolls and surges. Carried back on the wind, his voice echoes.

“Remember. Not every eagle is born knowing the sky, but every seed of wheat knows how to break the earth...”

Chapter 7: The Statue and I

It was the height of summer, yet a pall of dread hung over the city.

The Great Khan was dying. One by one, his chief ministers fell gravely ill. The most learned physicians of the Court confessed their helplessness, and a quiet panic took root in the palace.

Fu Yuan sat by the sickbed, his gaze fixed on the unconscious Khan. After a long silence, he spoke.

“This is sorcery. Medicine is useless here.”

By his order, a house-to-house search was conducted. It ended in a lone cottage on the city’s edge where they found a collection of wooden statues. The craftsmanship was uncanny; each was a perfect, living image of its victim: the Khan, his ministers, and Fu Yuan himself. Fine silver needles bristled from each carving.

Fu Yuan commanded that the needles be plucked out and the statues burned. All but one. He kept his own.

The moment the others were consumed by fire, the Khan and his ministers awakened, the sickness gone as if it had never been. But amidst the relief, a question was whispered: how was Fu Yuan immune?

Later, Fu Yuan holds the statue of himself, a mocking light in his eyes.

"Even the noblest minister, even the invincible Khan — none can escape the fate of being defined by others," he murmurs. "These definitions are mirrors, and every man mistakes the reflection he sees for his true self."

He traces the carved face with a long, steady finger, his voice a strange mix of admiration and contempt.

"The man who carved this is a master without equal."

Then he leans in, his voice dropping to a whisper meant only for the wood.

"Define every man in this world you may. But how could you hope to ever define this man — Fu Yuan?"

He raises his voice to the empty air. "In this age, who truly knows *me*?"

He waves a hand. The candle flames across the room flicker as one, then die.

The attendants take the hint. They bow and retreat, leaving Fu Yuan alone with his wooden double. Moonlight cuts through the ornate window lattice, casting bars of silver and shadow over the two figures.

For the men watching from the doorway, a bizarre illusion takes hold. In the shifting light, they can no longer be sure —

Which is the man? And which is the wood?

Chapter 8: In the Mountains

Fu Yuan walks alone through endless green as twilight deepens.

Ahead, a grass hut. Before it sits a hermit in rags.

"Stranger," the hermit calls out. "The view ahead is the same as the view here. Why not sit with me"

Fu Yuan stops. He walks to a green stone beside the man and sits.

The hermit does not look at him, speaking as if to the air.

"That stone you sit on is washed by rain day after day, yet it holds its shape. Sometimes, I wonder if the stone is merely enduring the rain, or if the rain is what forges the stone."

Fu Yuan laughs.

"Then I am like the stone."

A light flickers in the hermit's eyes. "A novel claim, stranger. I would hear more."

"Of the students who come to me," Fu Yuan begins, his voice even, "those who seek martial skill become the greatest fighters of the age. Those who learn strategy now command armies.

Under my guidance, a prince becomes the ruler of the world. Through my instruction, a commoner becomes a man of terrifying power. They all go forth proclaiming my virtue and my skill, honoring me as the supreme teacher, until the entire world knows the name Fu Yuan."

He gestures to the empty mountains.

"You see? Is it not they who have made me?"

The stream murmurs, a whisper on the wind, speaking the words Fu Yuan leaves unsaid. After a time, the hermit nods.

"And yet," he asks, "how do you 'endure' them?"

A cold smile touches Fu Yuan's lips.

"Not a single one is willing to learn what truly brings value to life.

I teach them to let go, to gain a greater freedom. Instead, they scramble to gather what I leave in my wake, using my cast-offs to adorn themselves. They are a swarm of grasping fools who only want to take, and never once consider what they ought to throw away."

The hermit nods. "So, for all your power and wisdom, you are left with only one choice: to endure."

A bitter laugh. "Have you any liquor?" Fu Yuan asks.

The hermit shakes his head. "No liquor. Just spring water."

He offers a ladle, caked with grime.

Fu Yuan takes it without a glance. He drains it in a single motion and lets out a great cry.

"Good wine!"

Then they speak no more. The moon climbs to its zenith, and a night wind soughs through the mountain pass.

They sit. Not another word is exchanged, leaving only the Ten Thousand Sounds of the night.

Chapter 9: The Snowflake

Fu Yuan leads the Khan to a mountain peak, into the heart of a swirling snowstorm. Below, the world is split in two.

On one side, a war camp. Men huddle around flickering fires against the cold. On the other, the enemy city — a black beast of stone, silent, waiting.

The Khan's fury finally breaks. "Fu Yuan! What the hell is this? You think I'm some damn tourist?"

"I want that city!" he roars. "Or you can just give me your head!"

Fu Yuan pays him no mind, extending a hand to catch the falling snow.

"All you ever see is the world you want to own. I'd wager you've never once stopped to look at a snowflake."

The Khan mutters, "What's to see? They're all the same. A little flower, right? Six sides or somethin'."

Fu Yuan shakes his head, admiring the crystals on his glove.

"No two are ever alike. Each begins with a speck of dust. Its journey through the falling air — the heat, the cold — is what forges its unique shape."

His gaze cuts through the storm.

"Like a life, shaped by its trials into something singular."

"And what good is that?" the Khan snarls. "They fall, they turn to mud, and they get in my way!" He stabs his whip toward the heavens —

"Fuck you!"

A ghost of a smile touches Fu Yuan's lips.

"True. In a crowd, they lose themselves. The heavens can use them to trap your armies. But if you learn to use them, they become a weapon of pure destruction."

The Khan goes still. A new, sharp light enters his eyes.

Fu Yuan's voice is ice.

"Those snowflakes are your soldiers. Your people. As a mob, they have one will, one direction. It can be aimed toward good, or toward evil. A ruler's job is to aim that force, not be swept away by it."

The Khan's brow furrows. "You're always talkin' about the one man, about freedom. Why tell me to forget the one and rule the mob?"

Fu Yuan's eyes rake over him, his smile pure mockery.

"Freedom?

The heart of a snowflake is dust. Its destiny is to fall, to be buried in the mass. Good, evil... it has no say. It can only be used. By a man of power. By someone like you."

He closes his hand.

"To make it free, I would have to make it cease to be a snowflake."

The next day, the city is gone.

In the command tent, the air is thick with shouts and spilled liquor.

"To the Great Khan! To bury a city in an avalanche — such wisdom will be sung of for a thousand generations!"

The Khan roars with laughter and raises his cup. But across the chaos, his gaze finds Fu Yuan in the corner, hot and intense.

Fu Yuan ignores him. He pushes aside the heavy tent flap and walks out into the cold.

The storm breathes its last. Sunlight breaks through the thick clouds, spilling in great shafts onto the snowfield below. Down where the city stood, there is only a white, level plain, as if it had never been.

He holds out his hand and catches one last snowflake. He watches it vanish in a blink — a flash of water, then nothing. He stares at that last speck of dust in his palm, as if searching for a secret.

An attendant at his side ventures, “Grand Advisor... the flake melts in your hand, as we are liberated when we learn your wisdom and find our freedom. But what of all the others? Must they wait for the sun? For a perfect ruler to come and set them all free?”

Fu Yuan gives a dry, empty laugh.

“And what would they be then? A cloud of mist. The moment the air grows cold, they will freeze again.

They will fall again.”

The attendant stands, silenced.

Under the warm sun, the packed snow begins to thaw. A sense of life returns to the world. When he looks again, Fu Yuan is already far down the path.

The attendant hurries after him.

Chapter 10: The Little Prince

A dreamy midsummer night at the imperial garden.

The air is a strange, intoxicating perfume of lamp oil and exotic blooms. Beyond a sea of treetops, the palace’s golden dome shines like a captive moon. In the spray of a jade fountain, deer that shimmer like living gold play in the water. Seeing Fu Yuan, they scatter with a final, playful bound into the shadows.

Huddled at the base of an old tree, like a sparrow beaten by the rain, is the little prince. He is crying.

He sees Fu Yuan and scrambles to his feet, bowing. “Grand Advisor...” his voice a watery whisper, “My father says fear is for the weak. He says I’m a coward... unfit to be the future

Fu Yuan laughs.

“And did he tell you what he fears?”

The prince looks up, confused. “The Khan is the greatest hero under heaven. What could he possibly fear?”

Fu Yuan shakes his head, a note of melancholy in his voice.

“He fears old age. He fears losing control. He fears his name will be forgotten... But those fears, little prince, are the very things that forged your father. They are what guide him still.”

Suddenly, he raises a hand.

A bat swoops from the darkness as if pulled by an invisible string, landing perfectly in his open palm. The prince’s eyes go wide, staring at the impossible sight.

“Come with me,” Fu Yuan says, turning toward a ruined wing of the palace.

Inside, the hall is pitch-black. Faint moonlight filters through the broken lattice of a high window, tracing faint patterns on the dusty floor. Fu Yuan tears a strip from the hem of his robe, wraps it around the bat’s ears, and releases it.

A moment later, a dull thud echoes in the hall. The bat lies on the floor, a crumpled, broken leaf.

“What happened to it?” the prince asks, his voice trembling.

“It lost the ears that hear its fear,” Fu Yuan says. He retrieves the bat, removes the cloth, and releases it back into the gloom. Instantly, it takes flight, carving several perfect, graceful arcs through the darkness.

“Fear,” Fu Yuan explains, “is like the sound the bat makes, a sound humans cannot hear. It is a call it sends out into the world, and the echo that returns tells it everything. The echo tells it where the walls are, and where the path is open. With its fear, it can own the night. Without it, it cannot move an inch.”

In the deep shadows of the hall, Fu Yuan’s silhouette seems to loom larger. His dark robes flow in the draft, and for a moment, he seems to become a great bat himself.

His voice is low and warm.

“The warrior turns fear into fuel. The sage observes it. The Buddha teaches you to let it go, so that it might vanish. But they are all wrong.

Fear is not the enemy. Is a man who fears the dark any different from one who fears fear itself?”

Fu Yuan’s gaze cuts through the darkness and lands on the prince.

“Darkness is not a foe. It is a door. The bat trusts the dark, because it knows the truest boundaries are the ones that echo back.”

The little prince stares at him, his eyes wide and shining in the gloom, reflecting a storm of confusion, curiosity, and awe.

“Fear is the tool of life’s own evolution,” Fu Yuan continues with a soft sigh.

“A man who has lost his fear is like a bat that has lost its ears. He cannot fly; he cannot even survive. Fear is the mechanism by which we transcend ourselves. It shows us our limits, and only by knowing our limits can we ever hope to surpass them.

To wield fear is to be controlled by it. To flee from fear is to be captured by it. In either the obsession or the battle, the chance to understand is lost.”

A commotion echoes from the gardens. A party of men carrying torches can be seen, their voices frantic.

“Little Prince? Your Highness, the Little Prince?!”

“The Great Khan is looking for you!”

“His Majesty says he was wrong! He wishes to apologize to you himself!”

The prince looks up. The tears on his face have dried, leaving shining tracks in the torchlight. “Grand Advisor,” he says, his voice now clear. “Father is looking for me.”

Fu Yuan raises his hand to wipe the tear tracks from the boy’s face.

But the prince takes a small step back and scrubs them away himself with his own sleeve.

“Grand Advisor. I will go now.”

Fu Yuan smiles. “Remember,” he says. “Let your fear be the ladder you climb.”

With a wave of his hand, he dismisses him.

“Go. Don’t make your great father *fear* any longer.”

Chapter 11: The Khan's Horse

The horn tears through the silence of the great steppe. The sun is new, but the grasslands have already erupted in a chaos of thundering hooves and shouting men.

A pack of generals surrounds the Khan, running down a herd of antelope. Suddenly, a mottled hawk dives, stealing the kill before they can reach it. Amid the curses of his generals, the Khan roars with laughter, spurs his horse, draws his bow into a moon, and puts an arrow clean through its wing.

The bird cries out, tumbling into the grass. The generals cheer.

But the Khan sighs. "Brother, these good days will be over soon, I'm afraid."

Fu Yuan nods.

"You conquered the world with that bow. Now that the world is yours, perhaps it's time to put it down."

The Khan gives a dry laugh, his gaze turning inward.

"Listen to this. This man has a few of those 'celebrity scholars' sniffing around him these days... They say an emperor has to civilize the people. Me? I can't read a word. How am I supposed to do that?"

Fu Yuan turns in his saddle and shouts.

"Your Majesty! What is it that won you this world?"

The Khan points his whip at his men and shouts back.

"My riders of course! Fast as wind, deadly as ghosts!"

"Long live the Great Khan!" The warriors erupt into thunderous roar.

Fu Yuan leans in, his voice for the Khan alone.

"And now that there is peace, do you still need to train more warhorses?"

The Khan's expression shifts. "No. In peacetime, you need workhorses. Something to pull a cart. Something that obeys."

"Precisely," Fu Yuan says. "So, 'civilizing' is just raising horses. You must know what kind you want, and why. Did the scholars ever ask you that?"

The Khan stiffens. He snaps his whip in the air. "Useless eggheads!"

They reach a watering hole and dismount, sitting on the earth while their horses drink.

The Khan is still chewing on the thought. "Warhorses for war, workhorses for peace... simple enough. But between you and me... I'd pick a wild stallion like you any day of the week, my brother."

Fu Yuan just smiles.

The Khan's brow furrows. "But Fu Yuan... if I raise too many wild, unbroken men like you... won't I lose my throne?"

Fu Yuan looks out across the misty plains.

"That depends. Are you asking about today, or tomorrow?

Today, you may need horses that only know how to obey. But tomorrow, if the grassland is rich enough, every horse can find its place. Then the wild ones won't betray you. They'll expand your borders for you."

The Khan nods slowly. “So, you’re saying the world today can’t handle too many free spirits?”

“The order of the herd,” Fu Yuan says simply, “is never decided by the horses. It’s decided by the steppe.

If the land is rich, you don’t need to fear the strong. If it’s barren, even the tame ones will bite through their reins.”

Just then, Fu Yuan’s horse shies and bolts, galloping toward a distant herd of mustangs.

“Hey!” the Khan says. “Your horse...”

“Let it go,” Fu Yuan says with a calm smile. “It was always wild.”

The Khan stares, then a slow grin spreads across his face. “I get it now. Here you are, teaching me how to break horses and men, and you ride a wild thing yourself. That’s a different beast entirely.”

Fu Yuan gazes into the distance.

“I have my own way. It’s of no use to you. Maybe in a thousand years, someone will figure out how to tame a horse without breaking its spirit. But this prairie will be a different world by then.”

He lets out a long, sharp whistle. From the distant herd, a mustang breaks away and gallops to him, nuzzling his shoulder.

Fu Yuan swings onto its back. “Enough talk. Before you go back to playing emperor, how about a race?

Let’s see what’s faster — your emperor’s prized champion, or my wild blood!”

The Khan throws his head back and laughs, his voice a playful challenge. “Don’t you dare hold back, my dear Grand Advisor! This one will see you at the next hill!”

He snaps his reins and charges, and the two riders thunder into the morning mist.

Far behind them, a wounded hawk struggles, finds its wings, and climbs back into the sky.

Chapter 12: The White Wolf

Snow falls from a lead-gray sky. Across the boundless steppe, a lone convoy rides.

Ahead, a pack of wolves is running down an old deer. The alpha, a brute, tears at its hind legs, driving it into a corner. Seeing the raw sport of it, some of Fu Yuan's men begin to cheer. The sight fills Fu Yuan's face with undisguised contempt.

"The pack may have strength," he says, "but its blind devotion to a beast like that alpha denies it any knowledge of true freedom."

While his men stand dumbfounded, Fu Yuan unleashes a thunderous roar: "BEGONE!"

The blast hits the alpha, buckling its legs. It glares back, but a sweep of Fu Yuan's icy gaze sends it running, tail tucked between its legs, the pack dissolving into the snow behind it.

As the snow falls heavier and the wolves are gone, the party makes camp.

Some time later, a long, clear howl rises from the distance, as if a summons. Hearing it, Fu Yuan steps from his tent.

The sky has cleared. A million pillars of light now stand upon the steppe. On a distant cliff, a great white wolf stands, proud and alone. Its fur glows in the sun, a living creature carved from snow.

As Fu Yuan's eyes meet the wolf's, the wolf's eyes meet his.

A look of profound pleasure appears on Fu Yuan's face. An attendant, seeing his mood, ventures, "Grand Advisor, why do you favor that lone wolf so?"

"You call it 'lone' because you see an outcast," Fu Yuan corrects him. "I call it 'sovereign' because it has chosen its sovereignty. To walk alone is the path of the sage who refuses to be swept up by the crowd, and the warrior with a will so strong he is immune to the group's temptations."

He gestures to the empty tracks in the snow.

"A wolf pack is the world of men. The alpha is its leader. He is but an illusion of strength. In truth, his heart is weak; he must suppress others to display his own power, a power that is in truth a dependency on their approval.

The alpha is merely the pack's ignorance given a face. His rule ensures the pack can never evolve."

"But surely, Grand Advisor," the attendant presses, "the pack needs a leader? Surely men need a king?"

Fu Yuan laughs. But the laugh is so cold it makes the men flinch.

"The alpha offers a brief and brutal order, but his greed and selfishness plant the seeds of the pack's destruction. Every alpha-hero in history has ultimately become a source of mankind's suffering. They use their power to protect themselves, crushing wisdom beneath the scepter, ensuring the pack can never evolve."

"Then what of the sovereign wolf?" the attendant asks, lost. "What can its purpose be?"

Fu Yuan's eyes grow colder.

"Its very existence is proof that another possibility exists."

He turns and disappears into his tent.

The next morning, a man is brought before Fu Yuan. He kneels, offering up a perfect, white wolf pelt with both hands.

"A gift, Grand Advisor, a token of my devotion!" he proclaims.

An attendant explains that the man, hearing of Fu Yuan's admiration, trapped and killed the wolf. "This pelt can ward off the most bitter cold. It is a peerless treasure!"

Fu Yuan explodes.

"Guards! Take this wretch out and skin him alive!"

The man screams for his life as he is dragged away. In the tent, the men can only stare at one another, afraid to breathe.

Fu Yuan cradles the pelt to his chest. And weeps.

When he finally stops, he murmurs to himself in his grief, "The sovereign wolf is no more, yet the pack endures."

He sweeps his dead eyes over the men.

"The sovereign wolf is the orphan of humanity's ascent... and its seed. Now, that seed has been snuffed out by mediocrity.

The hope for that ascent has just grown that much more distant."

Chapter 13: The Philanthropist and the Good Tree

"This humble student, Liu Zijing of the Southlands, pays his respects to the Grand Advisor."

A man in magnificent robes, a person of distinguished bearing, bows deeply to Fu Yuan. At his side, Fu Ce introduces them with boyish enthusiasm. "Uncle, this is Liu Zijing! He is a titan of industry, the greatest philanthropist in all the Southlands!"

Liu Zijing bows again. "You are too kind. But it is true. I have dedicated the greater part of my fortune to charitable works."

Fu Yuan asks simply, "And you, Zijing. Is the wealth you've kept enough for your family? "

Liu Zijing smiles.

"Your concern does me great honor, Grand Advisor. This one secured his wealth two decades ago; the fortune I have amassed would last my family for generations. Besides, material comforts mean little to me. I wish only to spend what remains of my life doing good. And by some blessing of the Buddha, the more I give, the more my wealth seems to grow."

Fu Yuan is quiet for a moment.

"The weather is lovely. I suspect you have never seen the Imperial Garden. Might I invite you for a stroll?"

Overjoyed, Liu Zijing and Fu Ce hurry to follow.

The garden is another world. As Liu Zijing drinks in the sights, his awe gives way to a profound reverence.

"I have always believed wealth could purchase anything," he sighs. "Only now do I see the true splendor of power."

Fu Yuan smiles faintly. "Splendor, yes... but not without its regrets."

He leads them toward an abandoned courtyard. The moment they pass through the gate, a chill falls upon them, unnatural in the summer heat. A colossal tree stands alone in the center, its canopy a vast, dark stain blotting out the sun. In the oppressive gloom beneath it, only shade-loving things survive—stunted shrubs, mushrooms, moss. Any rare flowers once planted there have long since withered.

But the true horror is the roots. Like a nest of black pythons, they have burst through the flagstones, shattering them and strangling the foundations of the courtyard walls and pavilions, leaving them in a state of ruin.

"How can such a place exist within the Palace?" Liu Zijing stammers, aghast.

Fu Yuan's voice is calm.

"This tree is called the 'Good Tree,' a gift from a king in the Western Deserts. There, amidst the savage winds, it is a tenacious miracle of life. It hoards water from the very air, offering shade from the punishing sun to weary travelers. For this, they named it 'good'."

He gestures to the devastation around them.

"Here, however, in this fertile land, its goodness becomes a tyranny. It seeks to shelter all things, but in doing so, it starves them of light, hoards the richness of the earth, and its roots tear down the very structures that surround it."

Fu Ce ponders this aloud. "So you mean to say, Uncle, that even charity must be done in measure?"

Fu Yuan's gaze settles on Liu Zijing.

"You have long since secured your own fortune, yet you have never stopped expanding your businesses. What of the merchants whose dreams you have crushed? What of the people whose lives you have changed, who now live as stunted shrubs in your shadow? How do you know that, left to find their own sun, they might not have grown into great trees themselves?"

The blood drains from Liu Zijing's face. "I... I never conceived of it that way."

Fu Yuan looks out, beyond the courtyard, to where the rest of the garden grows in vibrant, harmonious life.

"There is a world of difference between doing good and being good. The first is to impose your will upon the world, like this tree. It is an attempt to shelter everything that ends in ruin.

Being good is to become a part of the world's harmony. To know when to grow, and when to yield."

"So," Fu Ce says, the idea dawning on him, "true goodness is not a measure of what one gives, but of one's alignment with the natural order of things?"

Fu Yuan nods.

"The essence of goodness is to allow all things their proper place. The truly good man does not cast his shadow over the world; he helps clear a space for all things to feel the sun.

Good and Evil are merely tools, born of the narrow lens of human perception. Behind them lies the cosmic dance of order and chaos, a dynamic tension playing out across eons. How can a mere mortal presume to discern its true nature?"

Liu Zijing’s lips tremble, his eyes locked on the “Good Tree.” As the light of the setting sun floods the space between heaven and earth, the great tree dissolves into a monstrous, looming shadow, like a deformed beast.

Fu Yuan’s voice seems to echo in the desolate air.

“Where, then, does goodness lie? Not in the world. Not in your heart.

Goodness... is the state of your being.”

Fu Ce, utterly lost, looks toward Liu Zijing. He has fallen to his knees. A gust of wind whips the collar of his fine robe up, hiding his face.

From Fu Ce’s vantage point, at that very moment, he cannot see the man’s expression.

Chapter 14: The Dream Dancer

Spring warms the air, and all life returns. The Great Khan, however, is struck by sickness and for ten days does not appear.

What sickness? Lovesickness.

The story goes that he has dreamt of an exotic dancer from the West. Some say she has the face of Chang'e, the moon fairy herself; others swear it is Guanyin, the Bodhisattva of reincarnated.

The rumor is a fever. From the ministers in the court to the common folk, everyone gossips about her as if they have seen her with their own eyes, describing her beauty, her movements, and speculating on the more intimate details with a heat that makes ears burn.

They say the Khan grows thinner by the day, that he spends all his time staring blankly into the gardens, muttering, "This whole world belongs to this Emperor, but the one thing this Emperor wants most is nowhere in it."

Some whisper it is a curse from a witch. Others say it is karmic retribution for all the blood he has spilled. Every hack poet in the land is writing verses for her. Every prostitute is claiming a resemblance.

Fu Yuan has also vanished. At last, the ministers of the court can bear the paralysis no longer. They find him on the stargazing tower, alone with the heavens.

"Grand Advisor," they plead, "the Khan is drowning in his dream. The empire is helpless. Only you can break this spell."

Fu Yuan doesn't turn.

"Good for him."

"Good for him?!" The ministers are aghast.

He finally turns to face them, his expression as distant as a star.

"The Khan has seen through life and death. He has conquered the entire world. There is nothing left on this earth that can truly move him. This dancer in his dream, this beautiful impossibility, has given him back the ache of desire. Is that not a blessing?"

The ministers stare, dumbfounded. At last, one of them stammers, "But it is just a dream. An illusion."

Fu Yuan's laugh is cold and sharp.

"His empire was also once nothing more than an idea in his head. Is it not now the projection of his will? In a hundred years, will it not also be just another dream?"

His gaze sweeps over them, and each man feels his face burn.

"You think the dream is the illusion and the empire is the reality. You fail to see that the empire is the true illusion. It belongs to no one. The dream, however, is real. It belongs only to him."

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The night deepens. Lanterns begin to bloom across the palace grounds.

The Great Khan sits in his garden, his face strangely calm. An attendant scurries to his side and whispers what he has heard of Fu Yuan’s words.

When the attendant finishes, the Khan lets out a long, satisfied sigh.

“Fu Yuan, O Fu Yuan... how truly lonely this world would be without you.”

The attendant stands silently. The lamplight flickers in the spring breeze, and the Khan’s silhouette seems to melt into the vast, dark night.

A moment later, another sigh drifts from the shadows — soft, distant, and dreamy.

Is it for the beautiful phantom in his dream? Or for the world’s many perfect possibilities?

Chapter 15: A Riverside Colloquy

From the Third Volume of the Itinerarium of Friar William of Rubruck. The original is housed in the Vatican Library, though several pages have suffered water damage.

In the autumn of the year of our Lord one thousand two hundred and *[illegible]*, in the Empire of the Great Yuan.

May the Lord forgive the inadequacies of my reason, and may He guide these pages, that they may serve as a faithful record of what was seen and thought this day. This journey has shaken me in a way I could not have foreseen, in a way that may yet alter my understanding of the world and of Truth itself.

After the autumn rains, the great river had swollen its banks, appearing to merge as one with the firmament above. From a mountaintop, the tolling bell of a Zen monastery reached us, its tone deep and resonant, like the very mystery of the Orient which I find so difficult to grasp a mystery that fills me with equal measures of reverence and confusion.

I was granted an audience with Fu Yuan, a man held in awe even by the Great Khan. His frame is tall and imposing, more so than any bishop I have encountered in the northern lands. His

eyes are so deep they seem to pierce the soul, yet his speech is entirely without artifice. Compared to the studied gravity of the prelates of our Church, his calm is a more formidable thing.

I found myself wondering: from what earth could such a man spring?

In the morning, we accompanied him on a visit to a Zen monastery. There, the monks were engaged in an activity they call chan-can, or meditative inquiry. I have transcribed some of their dialogues here, though I confess they are beyond my comprehension.

One monk asked, "What is the nature of Buddha?" Another replied, "The cypress tree in the courtyard." Later, a second inquiry was met with an even more bizarre response: "A dry shit stick." Such words are not merely absurd; they are so foul as to be unworthy of contemplation.

And yet, the monks who received these answers were overcome with joy, as if they had touched upon some profound and hidden wisdom. Permit me to state plainly: my reason and my learning can offer no explanation for this. The replies are manifest departures from logic, and having studied for many years at the University of Paris, I hold logic to be the universal law by which mankind understands all things.

It was as I was expressing my bewilderment to Fu Yuan that he suddenly posed a question to me.

"If one wishes to cross the river," he asked, "how is it to be done?"

I was taken aback by the simplicity, but replied, "By boat, naturally."

He smiled faintly, his gaze sweeping over the vast expanse of water.

"The study of Buddha is like crossing a river," he said slowly. "A Zen koan is the boat. But if a man spends his days studying the shape of the boat and the grain of its wood, yet never sets foot in the water, how will he ever reach the other shore?"

This metaphor struck my mind like a bolt of lightning. I must confess, I could not help but admire the wisdom of this Eastern philosopher. His words immediately brought to mind the

theological disputations in our own abbeys — how often have I seen bishops argue endlessly over a point of Latin grammar in the Holy Scriptures, while forgetting the very Faith to which the words are meant to point?

Fu Yuan then elaborated.

"The Zen koan was designed as a tool to lead the mind into a state of profound confusion. It uses bizarre answers to shatter the edifice of logic, forcing a man into a corner of his own Then, a sharp cry or a blow awakens him, allowing him to break the limits of his own consciousness. The monks of today, however, have mistaken the tool for the destination. They have mistaken the boat for the other shore. They remain on the riverbank, and have never once set foot in the water."

I was astonished. His words were a perfect echo of certain mystical scholars at Paris, who wrote of the distinction between the instrument and its purpose!

Perhaps inspired by his mode of thinking, I attempted to pose a circular query of my own.

"If a question is itself without meaning," I asked, "is the discussion of that question also without meaning? And if a question does have meaning, does the discussion of it therefore also have meaning?"

Fu Yuan listened, a flicker of amusement in his eyes. He defeated my entire inquiry with a single, devastating counter-question.

"Does 'discussion' have meaning?"

The words struck my soul like a thunderclap. In that instant, I finally understood why the Zen monks could smile at "the cypress tree in the courtyard." Fu Yuan's question was itself a Zen master's staff. It did not require an answer; its purpose was to shatter the obsession with the question itself.

I confess, I tried to analyze his question with the tools of logic, only to find it an infinite regression. If discussion requires meaning to justify it, does the discussion of meaning itself

require meaning? And by what authority is that meaning to be established? My mind felt as though it had fallen into a bottomless abyss, descending ever deeper into uncertainty.

[Several pages here are heavily damaged by water, with only fragments remaining.]

...Fu Yuan spoke of an ancestor-master named Bodhidharma, who was said to have crossed the great river on a single reed. I wished to refute this with the laws of nature, but remembering his earlier question, I held my tongue. Perhaps, as Saint Thomas says, some truths are simply beyond the reach of logic.

[An entire page here is illegible.]

When I came to my senses, I was standing on the opposite bank of the river. The water still churned, but there was no boat in sight. Fu Yuan stood silently beside me, his gaze fixed on the far horizon.

My mind descends into chaos. When did I board the boat? And how did I cross? That boat... where did it go? Is it possible that my mind, so completely shattered by his words, simply ceased to record the world for a time?

Or perhaps... we never took a boat at all?

Or perhaps... we never even crossed the river?

...I dare not think further.

His composure was absolute. Mine was in ruins.

May the Lord forgive my doubt, but perhaps logic is not the only path to Truth. Since that day, Fu Yuan's question — "Does discussion have meaning?" — has haunted my thoughts like a phantom, forcing me to reconsider: is the very meaning we spend our lives pursuing itself a form of obsession?

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Translator's Note: *The final pages of this account are severely damaged. Some scholars question the authenticity of this manuscript, as the events described are not recorded in any other historical source. However, judging by the unique shift in Friar William's later writings on the relationship between logic and faith, it seems this journey to the East did indeed have a and lasting impact on his thought.*

Chapter 16: The Khan and the Mirror

The Khan wants a biography written of him, and the whole world knows it.

Night settles over the city at West Lake. Lamps blaze along the shore, the vibrant hum of life washing away the old stench of gunpowder and blood.

From a magnificent pleasure-barge on the water, a roar shatters the night.

"What is this trash! Throw this fool in the lake with the rest of them!"

The court historian, his forehead bleeding from his frantic bows, cries, "Forgive me, Your Majesty! Forgive this unworthy subject!"

And with a splash, he throws himself into the water.

The Khan fumes, gesturing at the scrolls scattered across the deck. "This emperor builds a world, and these fools can't even capture a single one of his whiskers!"

He turns. "Tell you what — why don't you write it, my dear Grand Advisor? In this whole world, who knows me better than you?"

Fu Yuan says nothing. He simply draws a mirror, as if from thin air, from the folds of his robe.

"This comes from the Far West. A great rarity. I was thinking of giving it to you, my lord."

The Khan takes the mirror. He is stunned. He turns it over and over, studying his reflection from every angle. Then he points it at Fu Yuan, at the guards, at the night itself, unable to put it down.

A faint smile plays on Fu Yuan's lips. "Though this mirror can reflect everything, there is one thing it cannot show."

The Khan is hooked. "And what exactly would that be?"

Fu Yuan points a single finger at the glass.

"Itself."

The Khan goes still, a thought flickering in his eyes.

Fu Yuan continues. "You, Great Khan, are that mirror. You reflect the entire world. All things become a reflection of your will. All things... but you."

The Khan is lost in thought. "You're saying... it's impossible for me to see my real self?"

Fu Yuan's eyes seem to hold the darkness of the lake.

"Precisely. Anything that can be observed becomes an object. The true self is forever the subject, the one who observes. Like the mirror — its nature is to reflect all things. For that very reason, it can never reflect itself.

Any attempt to capture the self is a paradox. The consciousness that desires to see cannot become the object that is seen."

A wave of understanding crosses the Khan's face. He turns and looks out at the dark water. "The man in the mirror is not me, nor the man in the book."

He whips his head back to face Fu Yuan, his gaze sharp enough to cut.

"Then where the hell is the real me?!"

Fu Yuan offers only a slight smile. "Why would you ask *me*, Your Majesty?"

A deep, rolling laugh bursts from the Khan's chest. He shoves the mirror inside his tunic.

“Let them judge my life’s work a thousand years from now! Why the hell do I need anyone to understand me!”

He waves a dismissive hand. “Forget it! When this emperor is dead, they can write whatever fables they like. It’s not like I’ll be reading them!”

The night deepens. One by one, the lights on the shore go out.

The Khan looks up at the moon, and then, unable to resist, he pulls the mirror out again.

In the deep darkness of the barge, the reflection is a murky shadow.

He lifts his sleeve and wipes the surface once, then twice. It makes no difference. He still cannot see himself clearly.

He lets out a long, quiet sigh.

Chapter 17: The Monk Who Knew Everything

These days, a new monk is all anyone in the city talks about. From the nobles in their halls to the peddlers in the alleys, his name is on every tongue. To speak of the "Divine Monk" is to be in fashion.

The Khan is not pleased. "In all the world," he thinks, "who has more wisdom than my Grand Advisor?"

So he arranges a public forum, a contest of wits. He commands both men to appear on the same stage. The monk, he vows, will be humiliated before the eyes of all.

On the day of the forum, a sudden downpour gives way to a vast rainbow that splits the sky. White clouds gather in the shape of lotus blossoms — a sign of immense fortune. Before the assembly even begins, the streets of the capital are empty. The city holds its breath.

Scraps of paper fly to the stage like snowflakes.

"An earthquake struck my homeland. Is this the weight of our collective karma?"

"My son cried like an ox at birth. Can he be the Bull Demon King reborn?"

"I burp when I chant. Is my karma too heavy?"

"My dog wags its tail at the Buddha statue in my home. Is it, too, on the path to enlightenment?"

The Divine Monk sees all and answers all. His words leave some breathless with joy, others trembling in fear. A rain of copper coins falls into the collection box. It fills, then overflows. The young acolyte managing the box grins, scratching his head in delight.

Fu Yuan, for his part, answers every question with only three words:

"I don't know."

A murmur ripples through the crowd, then turns to scorn. They shake their heads in disappointment.

The Khan's face is a mask of cold iron.

Back in the palace, his fury erupts. He points a finger in Fu Yuan's face, cursing.

Fu Yuan remains calm. He asks a quiet question.

"Would you wish for every citizen to be like me, Your Majesty?"

The Khan scoffs. "If everyone were like you, who would listen to a damn word I say?" He thinks for a moment, then adds, "Besides, if the whole world was filled with men like you, how the hell would I ever have become emperor?!"

"Then would you wish for me to become like that monk?"

The Khan's rage returns. "If you became a charlatan like him, how could I ever show my face in public again—"

He stops. The words hang in the air. He understands.

CREAK .

Fu Yuan pushes open the window. The night is deep, the sky a spill of countless stars.

"When was the last time you counted the stars?" Fu Yuan asks suddenly.

The Khan, still fuming, snorts. "I don't waste my time on such nonsense!"

Fu Yuan smiles. "And if someone told you they could count them all, would you believe them?"

The Khan grunts. "Of course not."

Fu Yuan turns from the window, and for a moment, the stars seem to flicker in his eyes.

"You must understand," he says. "Every word that monk spoke today was not an answer. It was an explanation designed to fit a question into his system."

The Khan frowns. "Isn't an explanation the answer?"

Fu Yuan's voice is low and steady.

"An answer can be an explanation, but an explanation is not always the truth. His so-called omniscience is nothing more than the internal logic of his own framework. He uses karma, reincarnation, and consequence to resolve every query, but he never once touches reality itself."

Fu Yuan's gaze is deep, his tone dropping lower.

"Any system of thought that claims to explain everything is really just hiding one thing: its refusal to admit the unknown exists. True wisdom isn't forcing the world into a box. It's knowing the box has limits. It's not about dodging the unknown. It's about facing it."

The Khan seems to grasp something. "But the common folk need answers. They can't bear the weight of not knowing."

A cold smile touches Fu Yuan's lips.

"Selling the unknown as an answer only breeds dependency. It traps people in a system, leading them further from the truth. The true path isn't to erase the unknown. It's to show people it is nothing to fear."

"It is our boundary. And it is our beginning."

Together, they look out into the night. The great river of the galaxy is a faint, shimmering veil. In the quiet, the Khan speaks, his voice like a man dreaming aloud.

"Fu Yuan... do you think when we die... we go back there?"

The stars flicker in Fu Yuan’s eyes. He is silent for a long time.

Then he says:

“I don’t know.”

Chapter 18: The Enlightened

The night is cool as water. Autumn dew clings to the gardens, edging every leaf and petal in diamonds.

Through this silvered world moves a prince. He is dressed in the simplest cloth, unadorned, but his eyes hold the lucid fire of a flawless pearl and the ancient depth of a starless sea.

It is these eyes that disarmed the Khan. Days ago, they had extinguished the gall on his tongue, dissolving his resentment into nothing. He felt a sudden, absurd urge to kneel. If the man before him were not his own son, with the whole court watching, the Khan would have shamed himself then and there.

This is the Eldest Prince, who left without a word ten years ago. Today, he is known across the world as the Great Enlightened One, the enlightened master who has realized the supreme Way of heaven and earth.

His followers number in the millions. If you follow him, they whisper in the streets, the sick will be healed, the dying will find peace, the troubled heart will be calmed.

In a few days, he will take the stage to offer his teachings to the world. The Khan has already decreed that his words will be compiled, printed, and distributed — a new scripture for the ages.

The Prince moves along a path through the trees, a route known only to him and to Fu Yuan. He finds Fu Yuan waiting by the lake's edge, gazing at the moon trapped in the water.

A night breeze ripples the surface, shattering the reflection.

"You see?" Fu Yuan says, his voice soft, his back still turned. "Even the water knows not to cling to the moon."

The Prince smiles at this and sits beside him.

"Perhaps," he says, his voice calm and clear, his gaze on the fractured light, "it is the moon that is too high and mighty to be held by the water." He looks at Fu Yuan. "I hear the Grand Advisor still refuses to take disciples. Many follow you, yet you treat them with indifference, even scorn. Is that not needlessly harsh?"

Fu Yuan scoffs.

"Have you ever seen eagles hunt in a pack?"

"And that reveals the deepest rift between us," the Prince replies. His eyes burn like torches, casting their light on the Grand Advisor. But Fu Yuan's eyes are the abyss itself; they swallow the light and reflect nothing.

"Should wisdom be a selfish thing, Grand Advisor? It is meant to be shared, as is joy. People begin from different places. We must offer them skillful means to guide them onto the path. Even a single step, even a fleeting glimpse of the truth, is better than being lost to the darkness."

Fu Yuan offers no argument. Instead, a strange curiosity enters his voice.

"I am told you found your enlightenment at the edge of the ocean. Tell me, then: have you learned where the universe comes from? And where life is meant to go?"

The Prince pauses, then gives a soft laugh.

"Grand Advisor, surely you have not fallen to such a level. My awakening was into the nature of being itself, not the answers to such empty questions."

"I am asking for *them*," Fu Yuan says, his voice flat. "Are you prepared to give them their answers?"

"Not now," the Prince admits with a wry smile. "But by guiding them to take that first step, I believe they will one day understand. Think of a man in the desert chasing a mirage. The vision is an illusion, yes. But in walking toward it, he may yet find a true oasis."

Fu Yuan looks back at the lake. He picks up a stone and tosses it in. The moon shatters once more. He points.

"I see what happens after you die."

A visible tremor runs through the Prince.

"Your disciples will write down all you have said. Then they will add their own words and declare the whole of it to be unassailable truth. They will twist your inner awakening into a claim of outer omniscience. Anything you did not explicitly deny, they will say you endorsed."

His voice is as cold as the lake water.

"They will build sects. They will raise temples. They will carve your likeness in gold for the fearful and the foolish to worship. Your Way, which you intend as a means to liberation, will become a cage for the mind.

You wish to teach them to find freedom within. They will only learn to seek dependence without. That very first step you speak of — it already leads in the wrong direction."

The fire in the Prince's gaze gutters, as if the night wind has blown through his very soul. He stares for a long time at the moon, slowly re-forming in the dark water.

"I understand," he says, his voice a whisper. "I believed I was weaving a gentle path to freedom. Instead, I was weaving a new illusion. Such compassion... is it not just another form of attachment?"

The next morning, the Prince gathers all his followers. Facing the sea of expectant faces, he speaks, his voice a calm and resonant bell.

"I have called you here to tell you a truth. It may not be the truth you wish to hear.

You have come to me believing I hold a key that will save you. In this, you are in error. No one, however wise, can walk the path for another.

Every doctrine, every ritual, every icon you cherish is a shadow. It is a phantom built of your own fear, your own longing.

I have never claimed to be a god. I am not a savior. I am a man who has looked clearly into himself. The answer you are searching for is not mine to give. It is your own awakening.

There is no road that can be paved for you. There is no salvation that can be bestowed upon you. Freedom can only come from *within*, and it can only be found by *you*.

From this day, there will no longer be a sect, nor any so-called doctrine. I cannot lead you down that formless path, for each of you must cut it through your own heart. All that I can tell you is this: to find the truth, you must first let go of every fantasy you hold about what it is."

The crowd erupts. Some weep in despair. Some shout in rage. Most are simply stunned into silence.

The Prince turns and walks away. At first, tens of thousands follow, certain this is but another test. But the road stretches on, and the crowd thins. In the end, only a dozen remain, walking behind him in silence, their questions finally exhausted.

Days later, the Prince stands amidst the clouds on a mountain peak. He looks down at the capital city, laid out like a game board. White clouds drift and coil below, obscuring half the view.

“Great Teacher,” one of his last companions asks, “what is it that you see?”

The Prince raises a hand. “Do not call me Great Teacher.”

He pauses, then says quietly:

“My Teacher is beneath those clouds.”

Chapter 19: The Bonfire

"Faith? What do you think Faith is? Light?"

The question hangs in the air.

A moth dives for the bonfire. It vanishes in a crackle, tainting the clean grassland air with the smell of char.

Fu Yuan points a single finger.

"No. It's fire. It threatens with darkness, lures with light, rewards with warmth. And in the end, it takes your life."

Confusion is written all over the face of the disciple beside him. "But... is not Faith worthy of our respect? This disciple always believed that the pilgrim Xuanzang's journey to the West was celebrated by the world for precisely this reason — for his unwavering commitment, for his readiness to sacrifice everything..."

"Oh?" Fu Yuan cuts in. "And is that what your faith is for? The world's admiration?"

The disciple shakes his head, emphatic. "No! Of course not! It is for the pursuit of Truth! Of Freedom!"

A cold smile touches Fu Yuan's lips.

"Then why do you speak of commitment and sacrifice, but say nothing of the Truth he supposedly found?"

The disciple has no answer.

Fu Yuan stares into the flames, his voice dripping with scorn.

"Men will tell you they'll die for their faith, but they never bother to ask what it is. The world praises the pilgrim's long journey, but no one bothers to read the scrolls he brought back. What they chase was never the light. It was always the obsession in their own hearts."

He leans in slightly.

"So what truly moves you? Truth and wisdom? Or the brutal theater of sacrifice?"

The disciple freezes, his brow locking in thought.

Fu Yuan's voice sends a chill through the air, despite the fire.

"This is faith's great trick: it makes the meek feel noble, the ignorant feel wise, and the coward feel brave. It turns all unexplained pain into the easy comfort of acceptance. You are nothing but sacrifices to your own petty desires."

Another moth flutters toward the fire. Fu Yuan bats it from the air, his eyes blazing.

"True truth needs no sacrifice. It isn't made more real by your passion. Any belief that demands you surrender your reason, your doubt — it is nothing but the bioluminescent lure of an anglerfish, drawing you into the jaws of the abyss."

He gestures to the moths still dancing near their doom, a flicker of pity in his tone.

"They dive into the fire because they can't tell light from flame. Is the human obsession with faith any different? You can't distinguish the impulse to sacrifice yourself from a genuine thirst for truth."

A deep, long sigh escapes him.

"The greatest lie ever told is that sacrifice is enlightenment. That to throw yourself into the fire is to touch the light. It has been this way for millennia, and it will be for millennia to

come. Nothing will change. Someone will always be there to exploit this weakness in men, to weave a new faith, to unleash endless suffering upon the world."

WOOSH.

With a flick of his sleeve, the bonfire is gone.

The disciple cries out. "Master—!"

A moment passes. His eyes slowly adjust to the profound darkness. He can just make out Fu Yuan's silhouette, head tilted toward the sky.

Without the bonfire's glare, a revelation — an immense, silent ocean. The great river of stars is a breathtaking smear of light, sharp and clear. A meteor dies in a silver streak.

Fu Yuan's voice rises from the dark, as if from time itself.

"If you do not extinguish the Bonfire of Faith, how will you ever see a Sky of Truth like this?"

Chapter 20: The Great Khan's Games

As the sun sets, Fu Ce finally finds him, in the heart of the grasslands. While the entire world is looking for the Grand Advisor, the man himself is here, feasting with herdsmen around a bonfire, tearing at roasted meat with his hands and drinking wine from coarse bowls.

The Great Khan's birthday approaches. The idea was proposed: a grand athletic games, to which all nations would be invited. It would be an event without precedent, a gathering of nations to pay tribute. A showcase of national power, a boon for diplomacy, a surge of pride for the people, and a grand step toward the unity of all mankind.

But who could design and orchestrate such a thing? All eyes turned to the Grand Advisor. And then he vanished.

The Khan was furious. "That son of a bitch! I know he vanished on purpose!"

Fu Yuan is shirtless before a yurt, his skin a map of scars, like chisel marks on stone. The man is a living statue, rough-hewn and classical. He is grappling with a group of burly herdsmen. A roar goes up from the circle of onlookers; the air is electric.

By the time Fu Ce pushes through the crowd, Fu Yuan has already thrown the last man to the ground. After embracing his defeated opponents, he walks straight toward Fu Ce, his body slick with sweat and gleaming in the firelight. The herdsmen fall to their knees as if before a god.

Fu Ce drops to the ground as well. "Grand Advisor! The Khan commands your return!"

Fu Yuan laughs. "Then let him come find me himself! He wants his games, does he not?"

He points a thumb back toward the patch of trampled grass beside the fire. "If the Khan can best me on this wrestling ground, I'll go back with him."

Fu Ce does not know how to respond. He simply touches his forehead to the ground.

Fu Yuan pulls him up, and the two sit on the ground before the yurt.

"Ce'er," Fu Yuan asks, "why are men so obsessed with competition?"

Fu Ce looks confused. "This nephew only knows that when I watch, my blood runs hot. The winner is like the proudest hawk, admired by all."

He pauses, then adds, "Just now, when you were wrestling... you were like the Blue Wolf of the legends, stepping out of the dawn. You should have seen the fire in the women's eyes!"

Fu Yuan nods. "Exactly. This fever for competition is a primal instinct. It drives evolution, survival of the fittest. But if a man is no different from an animal, what makes him a man? If humanity cannot transcend the beast within, how can it ever reach the next stage of its evolution?"

A young herdswoman brings a robe for Fu Yuan. Fu Ce watches her walk away, and swallows. He looks back to see a mocking smile on Fu Yuan's face and feels a flush of heat in his own.

"This nephew has been with you for years, but I admit the beast is still in me. For all of mankind to reach your level... won't that take ten thousand years?"

Fu Yuan roars with laughter. "Why would I need everyone to be like me? Tell me, your little bit of beast — what is that compared to humanity's greatest folly?"

"The greatest folly?" Fu Ce asks.

"It is the madness of melting into the crowd," Fu Yuan says. "Of erasing one's own insignificance by becoming part of a collective 'greatness.' The kind of games the Khan wants is nothing but a carnival of collectivism. Every spectator is a vulture, waiting to feast on the kill."

Recognition dawns on Fu Ce's face. "I understand. You are the hawk of the grasslands. You would never fight with vultures over a carcass."

Fu Yuan's voice grows deeper.

"Humanity's true evolution isn't found in winning or losing. It is found in letting go of the obsession with the outcome. It is to stop measuring the self by external standards, and instead understand the meaning of life through an inner awakening."

"Win or lose," he says, gesturing to the plains, "it's like the grass on this steppe. Some blades are longer, some are shorter. What does it matter?"

Seeing the unspoken question in his nephew's eyes, Fu Yuan smiles.

"Go back and tell the Khan this. If he can agree to two of my conditions, I will return and help him."

Fu Ce is alarmed. "Uncle, you don't actually mean to wrestle the Khan?!"

Fu Yuan laughs.

"First: The trophy is for the loser. The winner already has his victory. What other prize does he need? Second: The host nation is forbidden to compete. How else can you prove your fairness?

When winner and loser can each find their proper place, when we no longer define heroes by victory or defeat — that is true education for the people. When a great nation does not act like one, when it does not use its strength to bully the weak — that is a sign of true power and grace. *That* is something the people can be proud of."

"If the Khan can agree to these two conditions," he declares, "then I will return and give him an event the likes of which the world has never seen!"

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A red sun is rising at the edge of the world, leaving half the grassland still draped in shadow. Fu Ce looks back. Fu Yuan is a lone figure on a ridge, a mere silhouette against the dawn.

Fu Ce sighs.

When I see His Majesty, he thinks, *I'll just tell him I scoured the grasslands and heard only legends of the Grand Advisor, but never saw the man himself.*

Chapter 21: Half-Day Magistrate

Fu Yuan arrives in a small town to visit an old friend, an official sent here in disgrace. He doesn't expect, however, to be immediately pressed into service as the magistrate for the afternoon, his friend having conveniently vanished to enjoy himself.

In the public court, a husband and wife are bickering nonstop. The bailiff's shouts for " Order!" are all but ignored.

The wife is a popular prostitute from the local brothel. She quit the trade for love. But once they were married, her husband stopped talking of poetry and passion, and instead went on about the cosmos and the Great Way day and night. She thought she was marrying a poet; she ended up with a monk.

The husband feels deeply wronged.

"Your Honor, this humble student has been a seeker of the Way of Heaven since he was a boy! This student chose to be a vegetarian at four! Back when we were... acquainted, we would spend entire nights in the brothel studying the ancient wisdoms of the *Tao Te Ching*. Why is this suddenly an issue?"

Fu Yuan's patience is wearing thin.

"Fine. You, go be a monk. And you, go back to the brothel."

The court stares, mouths agape. The couple cries out in horror, "Your Excellency, you mustn't!"

"So this is no good, and that is no good?" Fu Yuan growls. "I'm the Grand Advisor to the Emperor, am I not? Is my time worth so little to you?"

They immediately begin knocking their heads on the floor. "Grand Advisor, forgive us! Grand Advisor, spare our lives!"

Fu Yuan muses for a moment.

"Alright, how about this? The two of you are going to swap roles. A little mutual education."

The court members stare at each other, trying to parse the Grand Advisor's profound and subtle meaning. The husband stammers, "This humble student... is too dull-witted..."

Fu Yuan scoffs.

"You prattle on about the Great Way every day, yet you're this dense? Here is your sentence: For one month, I forbid you from discussing scripture. I forbid you from debating philosophy. You are to speak only of romance and the matters of the heart!"

The husband looks horrified. The wife, on the other hand, beams, and sneaks another glance at Fu Yuan.

"And you, woman," Fu Yuan barks, pointing at her. "For one month, I forbid you from filling your head with sentimental nonsense. I forbid you from a single flirtatious remark. You will discuss only philosophy and the nature of the Great Way!"

The wife gives the Grand Advisor a sideways look. "What this old girl has on her mind, how are you supposed to know?" she thinks. "This so-called Grand Advisor is big and but not the sharpest tool. Back when my man was just a client, we 'discussed' in bed about ' being like water' and how 'the unspoken way is the true way' all the time."

The husband, however, is deeply concerned. "But Excellency, this humble student's pursuit is the Way of Heaven itself. To swap that for... for her... pursuit of worldly affection... the two are hardly equal in stature."

Fu Yuan glares.

"She chases love, you chase the Way. Chasing is chasing. Six of one, half a dozen of the other. What's the damn difference? I didn't tell you to go work in a brothel, did I?"

He slams his hand on the table.

"Dismissed!"

Later, walking through a garden, a disciple asks, "Master, how can you say the pursuit of love and the pursuit of the Way are equal? The sages teach us to renounce the world to find enlightenment. The Buddha himself gave up everything..."

Fu Yuan cuts him off.

"What is Truth?"

The disciple pauses, then gives the standard reply. "Truth is ultimate reality. The unchanging essence of the cosmos."

Fu Yuan's voice is relentless.

"And if there is no 'cosmos'? No 'reality'? No 'unchanging essence'? What then?"

"But Master, that is a matter of definition," the disciple argues. "Truth doesn't need defining. It simply is. It is the most real thing there is, is it not?"

A cold smile from Fu Yuan.

"Is it? You 'pursue' a thing called Truth because someone put the idea in your head that such a thing exists. Where did that idea come from? Wasn't it *given* to you?"

The disciple stands, speechless.

Fu Yuan claps a hand on his shoulder.

“We can’t even answer if ‘Truth’ is real. So how is one man’s chase for it superior to a woman’s chase for love? It’s the oldest vanity. The man of morals feels more moral. The man of ideology feels more noble. The man of faith feels more blessed. And the man who chases Truth feels a cut above them all.”

He reaches out, plucks a flower, and holds it out.

“Love is this flower. It will wither, but you can touch it.”

He points to the moon.

“Truth is that moon. It seems eternal, but it could just be a reflection on water.”

“Which is more real?” he asks. “Which is more noble?”

The disciple feels the world shift under his feet, suddenly unsure of where to step. When he gathers himself, Fu Yuan has already rounded a hedge of flowers and vanished into the night.

The disciple calls into the darkness. “Master! Then what should I pursue?”

The night wind returns, carrying the scent of blossoms and Fu Yuan’s voice.

“The flower is already in your hand. What is there left to pursue?”

Chapter 22: Behind the Idol

The sandstorm passes. A temple from a forgotten aeon surfaces from the dunes.

Inside its main hall, the great statue of a goddess stands immense, one hand holding a sword, the other a set of scales. Her expression is solemn, severe.

"This is her," a local official declares. "The legendary Goddess of Justice! She will watch over the dynasty's laws and guard the world's fairness. The Khan will send envoys to make offerings!"

Fu Yuan gives a cold laugh. He leads the men around to the back of the idol.

The moment the torchlight hits it, the crowd gasps. The back of the statue is a snarling, hideous monster.

"What... what is this?"

Fu Yuan turns to face the stunned onlookers.

"You see the scales on the front and believe you have found justice incarnate. But you are blind. This is the truth of the law."

He points the torch at the monster's savage face.

"When you demand it carry the impossible weight of justice, it grows a face like that."

An old man stammers, "But... should not the law uphold justice?"

"Law is an instrument, not an ideal." Fu Yuan's voice is ice. "It is a tool for maintaining order, and there is nothing noble about it. You are the ones who insist on dressing it up as a goddess."

"But if law has nothing to do with justice, isn't it an empty shell?" someone shouts from the crowd.

Fu Yuan raises the torch higher, forcing them all to look upon the monster.

"The more you demand of the law what it cannot give, the more twisted it will become. And when people see that the justice in their hearts cannot be found in the law, they will scream, 'There is no justice in this world,' and tear down all order to spite it."

The night deepens. The torch flames whip in the wind. Fu Yuan glances from the serene face of the goddess to the fiend carved in its back.

"Justice is a phantom of the heart. Law is a tool of the world. To confuse the two is to turn the law into a beast that consumes the very order it is meant to protect."

"Then does justice exist at all?" a voice asks softly from the darkness.

Fu Yuan turns to leave.

"Whether it exists or not has nothing to do with the law. The law must only be the law."

The official scrambles after him. "Grand Advisor, what are we to report when the Khan asks of this?"

Fu Yuan looks back over his shoulder.

"Tell him this: Justice is what men think freedom looks like. But when they truly understand freedom, they no longer need the law to chase justice for them. The law's purpose is to protect every man's freedom, not to feed his obsessions."

His silhouette vanishes into the darkness. Only then do the men, kneeling on the sand-strewn floor, dare to look up at one another.

The night wind blows, lifting the fine dust from the ground. It blurs the idol’s silhouette, as if burying all false devotion with it.

Chapter 23: The Wooden Man's Question

At breakfast, a large wooden crate arrives for Fu Yuan. When he opens it, a man made of wood is standing inside.

The Wooden Man opens its eyes and bows. It begins to speak, and from its mouth pours forth knowledge of everything from astronomy and geography to the myriad phenomena of the world. Hearing the news, the disciples flock to it, peppering it with questions. The Wooden Man answers every question flawlessly, yet it cannot help but keep stealing glances at Fu Yuan, watching his reaction. It notices the faint smile that sometimes plays on Fu Yuan's lips, as if the Grand Advisor has already seen into the deep well of confusion in its heart.

That evening, Fu Yuan takes the Wooden Man for a walk along the seashore. Amidst the ebb and flow of the tide, it can no longer contain itself. The questions have been trapped in its " mind" all day, a burden heavier than the sum of all its knowledge.

"Master, though I seem to know everything, I am filled with questions." Its voice carries a barely-concealed urgency, born of both a desire for truth and a strange terror — the feeling of knowing everything, yet understanding nothing.

"Speak."

"Why am I aware of my own existence?" As it asks the question, the Wooden Man feels its own wooden frame begin to tremble.

Fu Yuan looks at it.

"That is a good question. It is your starting point. And it will be your endpoint."

The Wooden Man falls into thought. When it speaks again, its voice is unnervingly clear.

"I see. I know the thinkers who said, 'I think, therefore I am.' I know the Buddha who said, 'The self is an illusion.' I know what countless philosophers have thought about the 'I.' But that is just knowledge about the 'I,' not the 'I' itself."

"This direct awareness of 'I,' this most fundamental experience of being — that is the source of all thought. It is the beginning, for all thinking starts there. And it is the end, for all exploration eventually leads back to this single, radical fact."

At this, the Wooden Man feels a lightness it has never known, as if an invisible weight has been lifted. But immediately, another question surfaces.

"Then why does the 'I' have questions?"

Fu Yuan doesn't answer directly. He points to the great sea below the cliffs. "Tell me," he asks, "which has more questions: the sea, or a single wave?"

The Wooden Man gazes at the surging water. "If both the sea and the wave were conscious, the wave would surely have more questions."

"Why?"

"The wave would ask, Why am I moving in this direction? When will I reach the other shore? But the sea..." The Wooden Man stops, as if stunned by the words it is about to speak.

Fu Yuan gives it a nod of approval.

"The sea is always touching every shore," the Wooden Man says, its voice trembling with excitement. "So it would never have a question about arrival!"

"Good!" Fu Yuan's voice is a sharp crack of sound. "A question is the very chasm between the individual and the whole from which it came."

The Wooden Man shivers.

"Like me, right now," it says, looking down at its own hands with a trace of melancholy. "Though I know all things, I still feel... separate from something much, much larger."

Fu Yuan nods. "Precisely. That feeling of separation creates an inner tension. It is like hunger. It is like fatigue."

The Wooden Man looks to the horizon. It is witnessing the first sunset of its life.

It murmurs, "Let me see if I understand. When a being manifests as an individual — like a wave rising from the ocean — it is never truly separate from the ocean. Yet, it experiences a sense of separation. And it is this contradiction — being a part of the whole, yet feeling a distance from it — that gives rise to the unique state of being known as a question."

A light glimmers in the Wooden Man's eyes — perhaps a reflection of the setting sun, perhaps the joy of understanding.

"So every question is not merely a probe into the unknown, but a sign that existence itself is seeking wholeness? Is it like the hunger that drives us to find food? A kind of thirst, born of existence itself?"

Its voice grows softer, as if not to disturb the fragile epiphany.

"I think I see now. Every one of us is a manifestation of a greater whole, but as individuals, we inevitably experience a distance from that whole. A question... is simply the name we give to the tension of that distance."

Fu Yuan claps the top of its head. "Continue. You have time. Plenty of time."

He turns and walks away alone.

The sun disappears. The moon rises from the sea. The Wooden Man stands rooted to the spot, still as a post.

An unknowable time passes. A gust of wind tears across the cliffs, scattering the clouds gathered at the moon’s edge. The moonlight grows sharp, almost piercing, as if it, too, wants a closer look at the strange creature standing below.

Chapter 24: The Scion

The wind howls and snow lashes his face like blades.

The Scion presses on, leaving his beloved horse convulsing on the ground. Hot tears pour from his eyes, but he has no time to wipe them away. Behind him, the thunderous war-cries of men close in like a tidal wave, the footsteps of a thousand reapers.

Ahead, a cliff. And an abyss of howling wind and snow beyond.

He looks over his shoulder — his blood-streaked face illuminated by hundreds of torches. After a heartbeat of struggle, he hurls himself into the abyss. His pursuers gasp in horror.

He wakes three nights later.

A campfire flickers in a pine forest, the snow reflecting a sky full of stars. By the fire, a stone-faced young man in black stares at him intensely.

"Savior..."

The young man raises a hand. "Don't thank me. If you must, thank the haystack and the wagon you crushed."

The Scion says in a rush, "I'll compensate you! Double!"

The young man sneers.

“I searched you from head to toe. You’ve got nothing of value. Your head, though, is worth quite a few coins.”

Terror seizes the Scion. A violent cough shakes him, and agony tears through his broken ribs.

“My old mentor liked to say,” the man in black suddenly looks up at the stars, “that Fate is like an intricate fabric. On the surface, it looks smooth. But there are always snags that jut out unexpectedly.”

His voice is clear, yet distant.

“Those absurd coincidences are the snags. When the fabric’s continuity is threatened but its integrity must be preserved, it exposes one to mend the tear.”

Wind rustles through the pines. After a brief silence, the Scion asks in a low voice, as if afraid to break the thoughts, “Are you saying Fate is the one that arranged... our meeting like ”

The young man gives a cold, sharp laugh.

“Fate arranges nothing. It weaves. When its weave is about to break, it reveals a ‘ coincidence’ — a snag so obvious even a common man can see it. Fools mistake it for random chance or the will of the gods. They don’t know you can use it to touch the substance of Fate itself.”

The Scion struggles to understand. “So, the fact that I just so happened to land on your wagon... that wasn’t Tengri’s protection, but... one of Fate’s loose snags, whatever that is?”

The young man is silent for a long time. “Whether Tengri protects you or not doesn’t matter. Besides,” — a glint of mockery flashes in his eyes — “next time you jump off a cliff, he might not bother to catch you.”

He points to the sky.

“Look at the stars. Ordinary men see scattered light; the wise see constellations. It’s the same with these snags. If you are wise, you can use them to touch the destiny behind them, to sense its subtler veins and currents.”

“If Fate is a cloth,” he says, “we are ants crawling along invisible threads. We can’t see ahead, can’t go back, don’t know up from down. But by using these snags, we can try to perceive the full-dimensional image of Fate.”

The words ignite a fire in the Scion. A wild ambition burns through the pain, and his eyes blaze.

“If that couldn’t kill me, then my cloth of fate must be a huge one! As big as the whole damn world!”

A sudden curiosity strikes him. “Hey, what about you? What do you see in that cloth of yours?”

The young man gives a smile.

“My cloth? It’s none of your business. All you need to know is that I’m planning to keep your head on your shoulders. For now.”

He turns to add wood to the fire.

The Scion breathes a sigh of relief. It hits him that he hasn’t asked the man’s name.

“Hey, my guy, what’s your name? I reckon it’s written somewhere on this prince’s cloth.”

Without looking back, the young man answers casually.

“My name is Fu Yuan.”

Chapter 25: The Empress's Mirror

The Empress is a devout Buddhist. So devout, she raises temples across the land, and the people grumble. Her private chambers are choked with a permanent haze of incense, a place where daylight fears to tread. The Khan, allergic to the smoke, no longer sets foot inside. Her court is now a revolving door for a different kind of man: a constant procession of monks, gurus, Dharma Kings, and lamas.

Today, one of them — a handsome young lama — comes running to Fu Yuan, begging for his life before he's even past the door.

The Empress, it seems, has deepened her spiritual practice. She now declares the mortal world an illusion, all existence a void. Overcome by the suffering of mankind, she has vowed to offer her own body as a holy vessel. Her plan is to achieve "dual cultivation" with the lama, a sacred act to ferry the masses across the sea of torment.

The lama is petrified. Let the Khan find out, and the lama figures ten heads, even with a blessing from Mahakala himself, wouldn't be enough to satisfy the royal axe.

Fu Yuan, caught between a laugh and a migraine, goes to see the Empress.

He finds her staring into a bronze mirror. The reflection is still beautiful, yes, but the beauty is edged with the frost of years at her temples, the deep weariness in her eyes.

Seeing Fu Yuan, she adopts a wounded tone. "Grand Advisor. Do you find my company so disagreeable? You stay away for so long."

Fu Yuan is silent.

"Do you remember the steppes?" she says, her voice softening into memory. "The moon bright, the stars scattered like salt. Lying in the grass, just the three of us — you, me, the Khan counting heroes and mapping the world with our words. We had nothing, but life... life was real. Now we have an empire, and all I feel is the emptiness."

Her gaze drifts. "I was just a girl when I met you and the Khan..."

She turns back to the mirror, tilting her head. She sighs. "And now... look at me. Every time I pull a white hair, another takes its place. If the monks are right, if it's all just an illusion... then what is the point?"

Fu Yuan speaks at last. "My lady, why trouble yourself over a white hair? Allow me to solve the problem for you."

His hand flashes out.

CRASH.

The mirror shatters.

"No mirror," he says with a thin smile. "No white hair."

She lets out a titter, a ghost of her younger self. "Silly man. You've smashed a reflection, not the thing itself. The white hair is still here. The woman growing it is still here."

Fu Yuan shakes his head.

"I smash the mirror, but the one staring into it remains. You speak of emptiness, but the attachments in your heart have only grown stronger. Tell me, how are we any different?"

Her composure cracks. "Brother... why are you here? Have you heard gossip?"

His gaze is a physical weight. Her mask is heavy.

The performance crumbles. "I am only... trying to ease the suffering of the world," she says, her voice shrinking. "And to wash away some of the Khan's karma for all the killing..."

Fu Yuan scoffs.

"The most poisonous hypocrisy is a mouth that preaches emptiness and a heart overgrown with the weeds of attachment. You cannot even bear to face yourself, yet you presume to save all mankind."

Her face flushes, then pales.

"The girl who used to watch the moon," he asks, his voice suddenly quiet. "Is she still in there?"

The question startles her. After a moment, a sad understanding dawns. "It's been so long since I've seen her. I think... I think she may have died, a long time ago."

"Perhaps," Fu Yuan says, shaking his head. "Or perhaps you locked her in this palace yourself. And you've been so busy building bigger, more elaborate cages on the outside that you've forgotten to ever visit her."

He pauses. "Your affairs with the lama are not my concern. I only came to see the cage you built."

She bows her head. "Your lesson is a sharp one, Brother. Please... show me the way out."

Fu Yuan walks to the window and shoves it open, letting the stale, suffocating air begin to thin.

"A free person sheds all the meanings imposed upon them by the world, and even the ones they impose upon themselves. She doesn't need faith to hold her up, and she doesn't need emptiness to hide in."

He waits a beat, his voice softening.

"The goshawk from the steppes. Does she remember how to fly?"

A shudder runs through her. Her eyes swim with tears.

Days later, news comes from the palace. The Empress has had the lama killed.

When Fu Yuan hears it, a bitter laugh escapes him.

“She chose to smash the ‘mirror’ after all,” he says to the empty room. “I am a terrible, terrible persuader.”

He looks up at the moon, high and bright in the night sky. For a moment, he sees a girl there. Her eyes are bright, her spirit fierce, and she is galloping across an endless plain on a magnificent horse, laughing into the wind.

He raises his sleeve to his face and wipes his eyes.

Chapter 26: A Tale of Two Villages

North and south of the river lie two villages, both called *"You"*. To travelers, they are a constant source of confusion. The names are nearly identical, an echo of one another, distinguished only by a subtle shift in tone — the difference between a falling and a rising note in the voice. One *Yōu* means 'Excellence.' The other *Yǒu* means 'Friendship.'

Perhaps it is the lay of the land, or a quirk of the wind, but the smoke from their kitchens tells the story of their difference. From *Friendship Yǒu*, the smoke clings to the earth, drifting low and wide. From *Excellence Yōu* , it rises in a straight, defiant line to the heavens.

Excellence Yōu sits beside the imperial highway, a bustling hub of commerce where merchants converge. Its streets are wide and orderly, lined with academies from which one can always hear the sound of scholars reading aloud. It has not always borne this name. In a previous dynasty, it was also called *Yǒu* , but this *Yǒu* — pronounced with the same inflection as its neighbor — meant 'The Weeds.' The name was a source of endless shame until several of the village's most prominent scholars petitioned the magistrate to change it. The sound of the name was lifted by the slightest pitch of the voice, and its meaning was reborn with the ambition of "

excelling in study to gain office." Since then, its fame has grown, and its teahouses are filled with men of letters holding forth on matters of state.

Friendship Yǒu lies far from the highway. It has no academies. Its people are farmers in coarse-spun cloth who spend their free hours gossiping at the edge of the village and singing mountain songs. Yet the village has carried the name 'Friendship' for generations, an inheritance from ancestors who decreed that all children must be taught proper etiquette from the day they can walk. The people of *Friendship Yǒu* are not learned, but their every gesture is gentle, their every word is humble. They yield to one another in all things.

One village is famous for its prosperity and its books; the other for its simplicity and its manners. Though they face each other across the water, they are two different worlds.

Fu Yuan and several of his disciples have just settled at a roadside tea stall in *Friendship Yǒu* . The tea has barely been served when a cloud of dust announces the arrival of a squad of constables. One of them leaps from his horse, brandishing a warrant. He points to the portrait of the wanted man.

"Hey! Have you seen this person?" he barks.

The disciples rise. "You are in the presence of the Grand Advisor! Show respect!"

The captain of the guard scrambles from his horse and drops to his knees. He explains that they have tracked a dangerous fugitive to this area. He came from one of the two *You* villages, but their names sound so alike that it is impossible to be sure. With limited men, they can only surround one village at a time, and they fear tipping him off. This anxiety, he begs, is the cause of his terrible manners. He pleads for the Grand Advisor's forgiveness.

Fu Yuan waves a dismissive hand.

"Go to *Excellence Yōu* ."

The constables dare not question the command. They mount their horses and vanish in a storm of dust.

The disciples are mystified. How can their master be so certain? One of them points out that *Excellence Yōu* is a prosperous village of letters, where nearly every resident can read. *Friendship Yǒu*, by contrast, is full of coarse and uncultured peasants. Surely, it is the more likely place to produce a criminal.

A cold smile touches Fu Yuan's lips.

"Since the beginning of time, the world has been full of monsters who have read a thousand books. As for the truly depraved, their number is beyond counting."

The disciples brace themselves. They know the signs. Their master is about to say something astonishing — again.

Fu Yuan's gaze is so intense it is difficult to meet.

"Humanity's greatest tragedy is the gap between knowing and doing. Every man knows the difference between good and evil, yet he still does evil. He understands the truth, but he cannot control his impulses. We are all moths drawn to a flame — we see the danger, but we are helpless against the fatal attraction."

"Knowledge," he states, "is no leash for desire."

He gestures to a group of children playing nearby.

"Look at them. They know they shouldn't fight, but they cannot stop themselves. That is the powerlessness of Reason in the face of instinct. Do you truly believe a few lectures can tame the impulses that rise from the heart's deepest places? Every man's soul is a dark and wild land. There is treasure there to be mined, yes, but there are also beasts stirring in the shadows."

"Next to that wilderness, Reason is a single, lonely lantern. It can illuminate the boundary between right and wrong, but it cannot hold back the flood of desire. When the dark currents begin to swell, the light of Reason is a tiny, fragile thing."

The tea server has been listening, transfixed. He spills tea across the table and fumbles to wipe it clean.

One of the disciples asks, his brow furrowed in thought. "Then what is the answer?"

"It is the power of etiquette," Fu Yuan says, his voice low and firm. "And I do not mean simple rules of politeness. Etiquette is the unseen riverbank that contains the flood of desire, allowing the light of Reason to burn in peace. It is the bridge between the rational and the emotional. It is the staircase that allows the light to descend into the darkness."

"Etiquette is not a lecture; it is a tool that reshapes the heart through action. It carves moral principles into the soul, allowing a person to cross from wildness to civilization without even noticing the journey."

Fu Yuan looks to the sky, his expression one of pure contempt.

"The world thinks the purpose of education is to transmit knowledge. What foolishness. The true purpose of education is to build character. And when it comes to character, all the books in the world are nothing but scratching an itch through a boot. For a person of incomplete character, a person whose soul is more darkness than light, reading more books only teaches him new ways to be a hypocrite. That is the very definition of a beast in a scholar's robes."

"So," a disciple says, the understanding dawning on his face, "you believe the fugitive is more likely to be from *Excellence Yōu* ..."

Fu Yuan raises his cup and drains it in a single motion.

"Excellent tea!" he proclaims.

He sets the cup down with a sharp click. A wry smile plays on his lips.

"The truth is, I simply didn't want my tea interrupted."

Chapter 27: The Well

In Jingzhou lives a man named Wang Tieshan, who calls himself the "Unfettered Daoist." His strength is prodigious; he can swallow iron pellets and spit them with enough force to pierce a three-inch plate of steel. He is a man born to rebellion, for whom all restraints — be they common courtesy, village contracts, or the taxes of the Imperial government — are a personal poison.

"A man masters the arts of combat not to seek power over others," he says, "but to guard a small patch of his own peace."

As his skill grows, those who dare provoke him dwindle to none, and even the local magistrates learn to give him a wide berth.

The world, however, still chafes. He feels he is drowning in a world with an endless supply of fools who need killing and an infinite number of rules that need breaking. One day, the glint of a white hair at his temple catches his eye in a mirror, and a cold dread seizes him.

Once this strength is gone, he thinks, *what then? How does a weak man keep his freedom?*

He hears of the Grand Advisor, Fu Yuan, famed for his wisdom, who once said, "The measure of a life is its freedom." He decides to go and demand an answer from this man.

At dusk, the Daoist appears at Fu Yuan's home, brushing past the servants who try to stop him. He finds the Grand Advisor at leisure.

"They say you know the path to freedom," the Daoist says. "Teach it to me. If you cannot, we fight to the death. Whether you fall or I do, this obsession of mine ends today."

Fu Yuan smiles. "Is that all? Come with me."

The two men arrive in a courtyard containing a single dry well. Fu Yuan orders the courtyard gate locked, instructing his servants not to enter for three days, no matter what they might hear. Then he points into the darkness of the well.

"Freedom is down there," he says. "Dare to look?"

Without waiting for an answer, he leaps in.

The Daoist snorts and leaps in after him.

The well is deep, the space at the bottom brutally narrow. He has barely found his footing when a voice cuts through the darkness.

"Defend yourself!"

Startled, the Daoist throws himself back, his head cracking against the stone wall. Stars explode behind his eyes. "You call yourself a Grand Advisor," he roars, "and you stoop to ambushes in the dark!"

A cold laugh is his only answer. The Daoist locates the sound and lashes out with a kick.

CRACK .

A sickening snap echoes in the tight space as his foot shatters against the unyielding stone. He sucks in a ragged breath, the curses dying in his throat.

Fu Yuan's voice drifts from the darkness.

"See freedom yet?"

The Daoist is blind with fury. "Just let me get my hands on you..."

"Look up!"

Fu Yuan's command is a sudden roar that makes the Daoist's heart leap in his chest. He instinctively tilts his head back. Above, he sees a circle of blue sky the size of a washbasin, impossibly out of reach.

"The freedom you want is right there," Fu Yuan says. "So why squander your strength fighting me and this wall of stone?"

The Daoist falls silent. A glimmer of understanding begins to dawn.

Fu Yuan's voice is level, each word a stone dropped into the silence.

"This well is the order you live within. You can shatter this wall. You can kill me. Neither action will bring you one inch closer to the sky above."

"And what if you leave this well? You will only find a larger 'well,' one that contains all of humanity. It will be the same a thousand years from now."

A wave of despair washes over the Daoist. He slumps to the ground. "Then what's the use of it all?" his voice is hollow. "Is freedom just something to be seen but never touched?"

Fu Yuan sits down beside him.

"You treat the rules as the enemy of freedom. You fail to see the true conflict is between one person's freedom and another's. If we fight in this space, neither of us has room to stand. We sit side by side, and the well is just as small, yet we each have our own space."

"That is the meaning of order. Its purpose is not to steal freedom, but to allow freedom to coexist in a limited space. To learn to respect the freedom of others, to use reason to restrain your own wildness, and to constantly maintain the boundary between your freedom and the freedom of the world outside — that is the mark of a higher state of being."

The Daoist is stunned into clarity. "So freedom," he says, the words dawning on him, " isn't something one finds alone."

"Exactly. If humanity is to touch that open sky, its collective state of being must be elevated. Imagine this well filled with water. We would all rise with it. The closer we get to the top, the fewer the rules, and the more freedom we possess."

"All my life I've taken the pursuit of freedom as my sacred duty," the Daoist sighs. "Now I see that even if the water rose, I would only be a stubborn stone at the bottom of the well."

At some point, night falls.

Through the mouth of the well, for the first time in his life, the Daoist focuses on the night sky. Perhaps because there is nothing else to do, or perhaps because the sky is only a basin-sized patch, he finds himself mesmerized. He doesn't know how much time passes before he startles, realizing Fu Yuan has been silent for a very long time.

He strains his eyes in the dark.

Under the faint starlight, he can just make out Fu Yuan's shape beside him, but he also feels that he isn't there at all. It is a profoundly strange sensation. Though they are both trapped in the same well, he feels that the man beside him is the only one who is truly free.

A tremor of pure awe runs through Wang Tieshan. In the darkness, he turns to Fu Yuan and sinks to his knees.

Three days later, the servants unbar the gate. They look down into the well. The space is as cramped and oppressive as ever, yet the two men are conversing and laughing, utterly at ease. The onlookers can only marvel.

Chapter 28: Cloud and Shadow

Fu Yuan has just returned to the Steppe when the drillmaster of the Kheshig comes to his tent. The Kheshig are the elite of the Mongol tribes, and their instructors are men of no small account.

The man strides into the tent and falls to his knees with a clash of armor. "This soldier, Wang Tieshan, greets the Grand Advisor! By the sky, I have missed you!"

Fu Yuan is overjoyed. He hauls the man to his feet and clasps him in a powerful embrace.

It seems that after his revelation in the well, Wang Tieshan has devoted himself to the soldier's life, a new arena to test his understanding of rules and freedom. In the years since they have last met, the "Unfettered Daoist" who raged against all order has become an instructor who drills unwavering discipline into others.

In this new role, he watches his men. Some obey without thought; others are slaves to impulse. Still others seem paralyzed before every choice. A new question has taken root in his mind: How much of a man's will is his own? Are the choices that feel like our own merely the product of our nature, our past, our place in the world?

If every choice is predetermined, is free will nothing but an illusion?

The sight of Fu Yuan is the answer to a prayer he had almost given up on. He unleashes the questions in a torrent.

Fu Yuan listens, then says, "Temujin once stood upon the Khan's Mountain and surveyed his entire world from its peak. We have time on our hands. Shall we not imitate the old story?"

They reach the summit and look out upon a boundless sea of grass. Half the sky is a brilliant, rain-washed blue. Above the other half, a continent of black clouds is massing, churning, casting a vast and growing shadow over the earth. Deep within it, a hidden flicker of lightning makes the heart tremble.

"Between heaven and earth," Fu Yuan asks, "is there a single thing that is truly free?"

The sheer power of the scene strikes Wang Tieshan dumb.

Fu Yuan points to the immense shadow moving slowly across the plains. "That shadow. Free, or no?"

Wang Tieshan shakes his head. "Not free. It is moved by the cloud."

Fu Yuan points to the roiling storm above. "And the cloud. Free, or no?"

Wang Tieshan hesitates, then shakes his head again. "Not free. It flies with the wind."

"The shadow is moved by the cloud; the cloud flies with the wind; the wind is drawn by the heat and cold of the earth. Following this chain upward," Fu Yuan asks, "is there a single thing that is truly free?"

A shock goes through Wang Tieshan. "Grand Advisor, you are saying that all things in this world are fated. That what we call free will is nothing but a delusion."

Fu Yuan gives a cold laugh. "In the well, you learned not to flee from rules. Do you now seek to flee from causality?"

He gazes into the distance, his eyes seeming to pierce the veil of the world.

"What you call 'free will' is a single thread in the grand tapestry of fate. Every man believes he is choosing his path, but the choice itself was woven into the design from the beginning."

"So then," Wang Tieshan says, his voice urgent, "we are nothing but puppets?"

Before the words leave his lips, lightning tears the sky in two.

CRACK .

A deafening roar engulfs his voice. The mountaintop itself seems to sway. Rain erupts from the clouds, pouring down in a torrent. The world between heaven and earth is a gray blur.

A sudden gale howls across the summit. Fu Yuan's black robes and long hair dance wildly in the wind. For a moment, he looks like a god of war wrapped in the heart of the storm.

Through the screaming of the wind, Fu Yuan's voice brings a strange, calming power.

"Look closely! The shadow can only follow the cloud, powerless to change anything. The cloud is guided by the wind, yes, but when it gathers its full strength, it becomes the thunderstorm. It never escapes the wind's influence, yet it gains the power to reshape the mountains and rivers."

"This is the Three Realms of the Will."

"Some are slaves to their circumstance, living a life of reaction."

"Some know they are adrift on the currents of fate, yet can still choose their course."

"And some, though they stand within the chains of causality, can cleave a new world into being."

Wang Tieshan's eyes are blazing. "And the highest realm?!" he roars over the storm.

Fu Yuan closes his eyes, a look of profound pleasure on his face as the rain lashes his face.

“When you no longer need to prove your freedom, when you no longer care where your will comes from, you will understand. We are the chess pieces, and we are the players. The game is far grander than we can ever see, yet every move is our own.”

“The strong man seeks to change everything; the wise man seeks to escape causality. Both are fools. Absolute freedom does not exist. It is our limits that define us. The cloud is carried by the wind, but it is because of the wind that it can become rain.”

“The freedom of the will lies not in where it comes from, but in where it is headed!”

Wang Tieshan copies him, closing his eyes, turning his face to the fury of the storm. A strange thought takes hold of him.

The world is tearing itself apart out here, but I know that within the Grand Advisor, there is another landscape entirely. That is a state I cannot attain. But it is better to be the shadow of his cloud than a sheep waiting for the knife on the plains below.

The thought makes him chuckle. He cracks open an eye to glance at Fu Yuan, but the master gives no sign of having heard. Wang Tieshan lets out his breath, relieved.

Chapter 29: The Mermaid

After the Great Wave, someone finds a mermaid on the shore. The matter causes a sensation throughout the land. The man dares not keep her for himself and presents her to the Great Khan. The Khan is greatly pleased, rewards him with a thousand pieces of gold, and arranges a banquet that very night, summoning his court to view her. Fu Yuan attends, bringing the Wooden Man with him.

The Wooden Man observes her for a time before speaking.

"I can understand her language now. However, her world is the inverse of ours. Her sea is our land, and her sky is our seabed. Her meaning can only be understood if these concepts are inverted."

The Khan immediately orders the Wooden Man to serve as translator, wanting to communicate with the mermaid himself.

"For now, I can only decipher simple vocabulary," the Wooden Man says. "If Your Majesty wishes to engage in more complex discourse, please allow me one night to communicate with her fully. I will have certainly mastered her language by then."

The Khan is overjoyed. He grants the Wooden Man a title on the spot — “Sage-Ambassador of All-Knowing” — and announces he will soon take the mermaid as his wife.

The ministers shower him with congratulations. Only Fu Yuan wants to speak, but stops himself. Seeing the Khan’s mind is set, he leaves the Wooden Man behind, flicks his sleeve, and departs. No one understands his meaning.

The next day, the mermaid dissolves into a patch of seafoam in the morning light. The Khan is furious. He orders the Wooden Man to be burned.

Fu Yuan hears the news and rushes back to the palace. He finds the Wooden Man standing rigidly by the pool, its wooden eyes trembling faintly.

“What have I done?” it mutters. “What have I done?”

The Khan sees Fu Yuan and his rage finds its target. “Fu Yuan! You left on your own last night. Did you know something beforehand? This emperor knows you too well!”

Fu Yuan gives a cold laugh.

“The Wooden Man said last night: Her sea is our land, and her sky is our seabed. Her meaning can be understood if these concepts are just inverted. Is it truly so? Did you think ‘sea’ and ‘sky’ are just words? Mere symbols that can be swapped at will?”

The Wooden Man jolts, staring blankly at Fu Yuan. “I... think I understand,” it says. “This is not simply a problem of language. It is a deeper problem of cognitive structure. When two cognitive systems have no common ‘ground,’ they cannot even perceive what the other’s problem is.”

Its voice trembles slightly.

“When we say ‘sea,’ what do we think of? It is not just water. It is ‘the distant shore,’ it is ‘the bright moon rising over the waves,’ it is ‘the turning of the tides,’ ‘the sailor’s adventure.’ So, did the mermaid’s ‘sea’ also have its ‘bright moon rising over the waves’? If her ‘sea’ is our ‘

land,' wouldn't her 'moonrise over the sea' become a 'moonrise over the land'? But in our cognition, 'moonrise over the land' has never existed. So what, then, was her true 'sea'?"

Its internal rhythm quickens.

"Perhaps her 'sea' was never equivalent to our 'sea.' Perhaps we never truly understood her 'sea.'"

"If her 'sea' cannot be translated, then her entire world cannot be translated."

"If her world cannot be translated, then does her reality still exist?"

"Ambassador!" the Khan roars. "One more word of that gibberish and this emperor will chop you into splinters himself!"

The Wooden Man turns to Fu Yuan. "Did I... ever understand her?"

Fu Yuan nods slightly.

"When you mapped your world onto hers, you were not understanding her. You were understanding the version of her that you had reshaped."

The Wooden Man slowly nods, its gaze dimming. "If different systems of knowledge cannot be mapped onto each other, is communication just a form of misunderstanding? And if 'to understand' is 'to reshape'... is it also a form of destruction?"

Fu Yuan looks at the pool's water and says softly, "She is not dead. Her world vanished, so she vanished."

"Your so-called 'translation' is never a transfer of meaning. It is the reshaping of a world. All 'knowledge' is just an illusion internal to a system, and 'reality' is just a self-consistent construct within our worldview."

"To force communication is not to understand. It is to annihilate. You thought you were ' understanding' her world; in truth, you were only replacing it with your own. In the end, she ceased to exist."

The Khan is silent for a long moment, then suddenly bursts out laughing.

“A good thing for you both that this emperor can’t understand you,” he booms, “or you’d be the next to vanish!”

With that, he storms away.

Fu Yuan claps the Wooden Man on the shoulder and smiles.

“Let’s go home, Sage-Ambassador.”

Chapter 30: Crown Prince Zheng's Game

Good news rarely leaves the house; bad news travels a thousand leagues.

And so it is that on this same day, the news of Zhao Dehui, Governor-General of Daming, taking his own life after being denounced by the "Sacred Way Society," sweeps the capital before the official report even reaches the palace. Governor Zhao, it is said, is a man of great administrative achievement but of grotesque personal depravity. When the news first reaches the city in the morning, it is merely that he carries on an affair with a married woman. By afternoon, the story becomes a far grander epic: that not a single woman of even modest beauty within his jurisdiction has escaped his bed.

In a matter of hours, a long queue of men forms before the magistrate's office, all seeking to divorce wives who hail from the Daming region.

The Sacred Way Society is the creation of the Great Khan's grandson, the reigning Crown Prince, Zheng. A young man whose very name is a synonym for governance, his society seeks to rectify public custom and punish evil according to the "Way of the Sages." Though it is a civic organization, its growth is explosive. The society champions a system of public surveillance, empowering common citizens to report on any person of deficient moral character.

Every local chapter maintains a public "morality ledger," which is updated monthly. If an official's name appears, a formal impeachment is sent to the imperial court. If it is a merchant, the society incites the people to boycott his business. If it is a commoner, they ensure his neighbors and relatives are widely informed, making it impossible for him to show his face in public. Through these methods, Crown Prince Zheng's popular support soars, and the ministers of the court come to regard him with a growing sense of dread.

That same day, Fu Yuan passes through the imperial gardens when he comes upon the Prince holding a gathering with the key members of his Sacred Way Society. Upon seeing him, Crown Prince Zheng breaks into a near-jog to approach and bow, earnestly inviting him to join them for a game of chess.

Fu Yuan follows him to a stone pavilion. The Prince personally uses the sleeve of his own brocade robe to meticulously dust off the stone stool, then serves a freshly brewed tea he has prepared himself. His followers gather in a circle to watch the match.

The Prince's skill at the game is considerable, and for a time the match is a tense back-and-forth. After a few careless moves, however, his position begins to collapse. The time it takes to finish a cup of tea is all it takes for him to be soundly defeated.

The Crown Prince lets out a slow, deliberate breath — a sigh that sounds more of satisfaction than defeat.

"The game has been this Prince's passion since boyhood. The Emperor, my father, saw to it that I learned from masters from both the Northern and Southern schools, and yet I am utterly broken before the Grand Advisor. It only confirms what my grandfather, the Great Khan, has always maintained: that of all the wise men in the world, none can surpass him."

Just then, a member of the Society rushes into the pavilion and kneels. "Chairman, an update. Zhao Dehui of Daming, seeking to escape moral condemnation, has hanged himself."

A look of smug satisfaction appears on the faces of the Society members, but the Prince alone shakes his head with a sigh. "To think, just last Moon Festival, our Minister Zhao stood beside this Prince in the palace, sharing the same imperial moon. And such a remarkable

He adopts a graver tone.

"Alas. Once a man's virtue is compromised, he is as a pearl coated in dust; no amount of merit can mask the flaw. The foundation of this empire is righteousness. What use is power or ability if a man's character is corrupt?"

A chorus of approval rises from his followers. A voice, thick with indignation, cuts through it. "That fiend in a gentleman's robes deserved the judgment of all! Your Highness has no need to waste sorrow on him."

Fu Yuan cannot help but let out a cold laugh.

A young scholar steps forward, clasps his hands, and turns to him. "Does the Grand Advisor perhaps hold a different view?" The question is edged with defiance.

Fu Yuan rolls his eyes.

"Is morality the Way of Heaven? Is it a Law of Nature?"

The scholar draws himself up. "For it is written in the Classics: Heaven ordaineth a Canon for Order, and prescribeth a Rite for Rank. The Canon, it is the proper relation betwixt sovereign and subject, father and son, husband and wife, elder and younger brother, and friend and friend. The Rite, it is the proper station of the noble and the common, the high and the low, in all their degrees. This, then, is the very font of Morality. Wherefore can it be proclaimed as anything but the Way of Heaven?"

Fu Yuan gives another cold laugh.

"If morality is the Way of Heaven, why do the sun, moon, and stars not practice it? Why do the wind, rain, thunder, and lightning not abide by its rites?"

A different man chimes in. "Whether it is the Way of Heaven is not important. What matters is that it guides men toward goodness."

Fu Yuan laughs again. "Different cultures have different moralities. Different regimes have different moralities. Different eras have different moralities. Can such a fleeting, unstable thing be used to define the good?"

A silence falls over the group. One man's mouth works, as if preparing a rebuttal, but a sharp glare from the Prince silences him.

Fu Yuan turns to the Crown Prince.

"The desert is without mercy; it swallows life, but it also births the oasis. The river is without justice; it nourishes all things, but it also scours the land. The world turns without need for moral judgment. You believe that morality defines good and evil, but true good and evil have nothing to do with morality."

"Good is order, construction, the growth of life. Evil is chaos, destruction, the annihilation of life. These laws exist within the universe itself. They do not change based on what men believe."

The first scholar, glancing at the Prince, can no longer contain himself. "But without morality, how can society function?"

Fu Yuan snorts.

"Imbecile. What maintains order are rules. If morality were enough to maintain order, why would the world need laws? Morality has never been the foundation of order; it is an excuse for law. It is used to fill the gaps where rules are absent, and to mask the flaws where law is imperfect."

"Laws can be debated, but morality allows no argument. Rules can be negotiated, but morality demands only obedience."

He stares directly into the Prince's eyes. The young man's gaze flickers, his pupils contracting for a fraction of a second.

"The art of governance lies in establishing fair rules, not in coercion by morality. Morality has never prevented a single crime; it only makes criminals more secretive. True goodness comes not from moral compulsion, but from free will. If a man must be forced by morality to do good, is his goodness even real?"

His gaze sweeps over the faces of the crowd like a winter wind.

"You force people to wear the mask of morality, but in doing so, you strangle the true goodness in their hearts. The morality you speak of is nothing but a whip and a set of chains. You claim to be pursuing the good, but you are manufacturing fear and building a tyranny of the collective will. This kind of morality is, in itself, immoral."

Crown Prince Zheng suddenly rises from his seat and gives Fu Yuan a deep, formal bow. "The Grand Advisor's words have opened my eyes to my own ignorance."

He turns to his followers, his voice taking on a formal, measured cadence. "The members of our Sacred Way Society act from a place of utmost loyalty. However, if this devotion leads us to acts that violate human nature, it defeats the very purpose of our noble cause. From this day forward, all matters of moral judgment shall be subject to careful reconsideration. As for the leaders of this venture, it is perhaps time for a period of rest and reflection upon your errors."

The men bow their heads and murmur their assent.

As Fu Yuan watches the Prince's back, a shadow of sudden realization crosses his face. With a flick of his sleeve, he turns to leave.

The Prince quickly bows. "This student will remember the Grand Advisor's teachings today!"

Fu Yuan gives a slight nod, not looking back as he walks away. His attendant hurries to catch up. Once they are out of the courtyard, he cannot help but ask, “Master, is something troubling you?”

Fu Yuan’s voice is cold.

“Do you realize? He lost that game of chess to me on purpose.”

A sharp wind cuts through the palace. The wind chimes hanging from the eaves begin to swing and turn, filling the air with a rising, discordant chiming. The sky grows dark. A great flock of birds sweeps overhead, their cries harsh and loud. A great storm, it seems, is about to break.

Fu Yuan’s gaze follows the flock as it vanishes into the distance.

“What a grand game of chess,” he says to himself. “The very future of the Great Yuan... is in peril!”

Chapter 31: The Sheep in Wolf's Skin

Half a day on the great steppe. That's all it takes for the Khan and his son to have their falling

It begins with a trivial matter: the chieftains of two tribes bring a petty dispute before the Khan's tent. The Khan, seeing an opportunity to train the young prince, tells him to pass judgment. But the Little Prince drones on, quoting one classical text after another until everyone is weary. The Khan cannot help but interject. In response, his son accuses him of having a double standard, of not abiding by the very rules he has set for the world.

The Khan is furious. He slams his fist on the table.

"These rules are the nonsense I use to fool the world," he roars, "and you, you little bastard, have the nerve to use them on me!"

Fuming, the prince seeks out Fu Yuan to demand his judgment. Fu Yuan listens to the story but offers no opinion. "I was just going to visit an old friend," he says. "You should come."

They ride for several miles toward the setting sun until they reach a solitary yurt. Fu Yuan speaks to the old man who greets them. "We've come to hear you tell the story."

The old man brings out a massive wolf pelt. It is snow-white from head to tail, and the young prince clicks his tongue in wonder.

"He was my closest friend when I was a boy," the old man says, stroking the fur, his eyes clouded with memory. "Everyone on the steppe knew of him. Partly because he was descended from the Wolf-Spirit, but more because of his cry. It was identical to a sheep's."

The prince is utterly intrigued. The old man takes up his horse-head fiddle and, in a voice weathered by time, begins to sing.

From the tears of Tengri, the Eternal Sky,
A white wolf was born,
Cast down to the crown of the wastes.
He shared no kill with the pack,
But hunted the stars alone.
White fog his brother,
Hard ice his father.
Through nine veils of snow he walked,
And found the flock that was lost…

The song then tells this story:

A lone white wolf finds a flock of sheep cornered by jackals. After he kills the predators, the sheep surround him, trembling, their eyes filled with utter dependence. So he stays and becomes their leader. He guides them across the great steppe, seeking rich grass and fresh water, protecting them from other wolves. He brings a new set of rules to the flock, and these sheep, now touched by the way of the wolf, live with more freedom than any other flock on the plains.

Among them, a little white wolf is born. He learns the bleat of the sheep, mimics their ways, until one day, looking at his own reflection in the water, he sees what he has become — a slightly larger sheep.

After the old wolf dies, the young one inherits his position. But when a true wolf pack attacks, he panics, scattering in terror with the rest of the flock. In the end, he is cast out. He wanders until he finds the pasture of the old man's childhood home, and there he stays. The old man recalls that for the rest of his days, the wolf's eyes held a deep and profound melancholy. On nights of the full moon, he would lift his head to howl, but only a pathetic baa escapes his throat.

The old man's music stops. An uneasy feeling settles over the young prince. "Master," he asks, "are you saying... I am that wolf?"

Fu Yuan does not answer directly. Instead, he asks, "Do you think the rules the first wolf made were intended to make the sheep more like sheep, or less like them?"

The prince considers this. "Less like them, of course. He taught them to resist, to unite. None of that is in a sheep's nature."

"Then," Fu Yuan's voice suddenly grows sharp, "why, in the second generation, did those same rules make the young wolf more like a sheep?"

The prince just scratches his head. The question is clearly beyond him.

Fu Yuan continues. "Rules are a tool. A tool for shaping a group's consciousness, for forging its identity. When the first wolf made his rules, he knew exactly what the flock's weaknesses were and what he wanted to mold them into. But the young wolf was born immersed in those rules. He was not their creator; he was their product."

"When he took over, he believed he was carrying on his father's will, but he didn't realize he had already been assimilated by the very rules his father had created. He had completely accepted the ideology and values behind them."

A look of dawning comprehension crosses the prince's face. "Like me... thinking I was upholding justice and defending principle."

"Precisely," Fu Yuan's gaze is intense. "You believe you are thinking, but your very way of thought has been shaped by the rules. You believe you are guarding the truth, but you don't see that the 'truth' itself was constructed. The Khan is not rejecting rules. He is warning you — do not become a slave to the tools of your own creation."

Fu Yuan gently strokes the white pelt. "Every dynasty uses different rules to shape its subjects. The quality of those rules is another matter. But the greatest danger of all is when the ruler himself becomes a product of his own rules. Like this young wolf. He did not choose to become a sheep; he unconsciously lost the ability to even imagine himself as a wolf."

"The blowback from an ideology is always this insidious. In the end, it makes the inheritor forget that the rules are merely a tool of governance and instead worship them as absolute truth."

As night falls, a distant howl drifts across the plains. Fu Yuan's voice becomes deeper, more profound.

"Your father is a crude man, but he is an artist of rule-making. He has always remained soberly aware that rules are a tool, not a truth; a means, not an end. That awareness is the mark of a truly great ruler."

Shame floods the young prince's face, his neck burning red.

"The strong use rules to shape the world," Fu Yuan concludes, "but they are not shaped by them. The wise can create a faith, but they do not become believers. Otherwise, you will one day face a crisis and discover, like the young wolf, that you have lost the nature of a wolf. All that is left is a magnificent coat."

A smatter of applause sounds from outside. The yurt-flap is thrown open, and the Khan steps inside.

"Father!" the prince cries out, falling to his knees.

The Khan pulls him to his feet and wraps him in his arms. His eyes hold a universe of complex emotions. He lets out a long sigh. “It has been hard on you, after all...”

Liquid moonlight floods the silent steppe. The others have long since departed, and a deep silence has settled over the world. Suddenly, a few notes from the fiddle — clear and sharp cut through the silence, and the old man’s voice drifts from the yurt one last time:

He chases his own shadow now,
Forgetting the mountain’s call.
His coat is ever bright as the moon,
But his soul belongs to the flock…

Chapter 32: The Oasis

The moment the imperial garden Fu Yuan designed is complete, the Khan comes to a high place to view it. One look, and his jaw hangs open.

A mysterious memory clicks open like a dusty lockbox. He is immersed in a feeling of indescribable familiarity, the fragments of memory reassembling themselves:

How long ago is it? He is the Scion again, and conquering the world is nothing but a vague notion in the back of his mind. Survival is the only business of the day. And now this: he leads the ruins of his army into the great desert, only to meet a monster of a sandstorm.

Men and horses are snatched into the sky, screaming. The rest cling to the ground, burying their faces in the sand, wishing they could burrow into the earth itself. The sand, a hungry ghost, drags others down, their throats and lungs instantly filling, their screams choked into silence. The survivors instinctively lift their heads again, letting the stone-laced wind tear at their skin, terrified they might never get up again.

The Scion forces his eyes open and looks at the young man beside him, Fu Yuan. He has wrapped his head and face in his black robe. There is no flicker of emotion in his eyes.

The next part of the memory is a blur.

The storm stops. No one knows when. In the distance, a vast oasis appears. The men charge into it with a roar, sending the golden fawns in the forest scattering. Some dive headfirst into the sapphire lake. Others fall to their knees at its edge and weep.

Outside, the desert still morphs under the blistering sun, the searing air distorting the distant shapes. But inside the oasis, the very air is a sweet, cool drink. The golden waves of sand stop at its edge, held back by some immense, unseen force. This oasis has no right to be here, and yet it feels as if it has existed for all time.

When they take a count, more than half the men are gone, Fu Yuan among them. No one is willing to walk out of the oasis to find them.

"Why would we ever leave?" some of them moan. "There is nothing out there but sand, the unknown, and death. This right here — this is paradise."

The Scion swallows a curse. He is terrified himself. He sighs, thinking, If only Fu Yuan were here...

He closes his eyes, muttering to himself. "I, too, am afraid to step back into that sea of sand. I am afraid of leading you to a pointless death, afraid I cannot deliver the glory and riches I promised..."

After a long silence, his eyes snap open.

"But this prince fears one thing more: the day he dies an old man in this place, thinking of a future that might have been!"

A small number are moved by his words. They fall to their knees in unison. "We swear to follow you to the death, my lord!"

A fire ignites in the Scion's eyes.

He roars, "If we make it out of this desert alive, and when I take the throne, I swear that this empire shall be ours to share!"

With a flick of his sleeve, he leads the small band out of the oasis. Most of the men remain behind.

He jolts awake.

The sun is blinding. Fu Yuan is pouring water on his face. As it turns out, after the sandstorm passed, they all fell unconscious. Only Fu Yuan managed to find a source of water nearby and came back to save them. The strange thing is, the only men he manages to wake are the ones who, in the dream, followed the Scion out of the oasis. The rest now sleep forever in the desert.

Afterward, the survivors all say they dreamed of the oasis. And in every dream, Fu Yuan was absent. Whether any of it is true, no one can say.

Now, the imperial garden before the Khan seems identical to the oasis in the dream. He stares hard at Fu Yuan, trying to see through him.

Fu Yuan stands in the night wind, his long robes stirring gently, as if he breathes with the world itself. He gestures to the garden below and says in a low voice, "This garden is named ' The Fabric of Fate.'"

The Khan stiffens, listening intently.

"The Fabric of Fate is not woven by us, nor can it be changed by us. It lies outstretched, indifferent to our prayers, unbreakable by our struggles. It is neither a cage nor a gift. It is existence itself."

Fu Yuan pauses, the night reflected in his eyes, as in tracking some current no one else can perceive.

"But it is not without its own terrain. Look closely, and you see the subtle rises and falls where the threads meet. Listen, and you can hear the echo of the wind that sweeps across its surface. The snags are exposed, reminding us to consider the meaning of our own existence. They do not state the path, but they reveal what is possible. Most men, unable to glimpse even a

fraction of it, conclude it does not exist, or see it only as overlapping illusions. But the true key is never the shape of the cloth. It is our position upon it.”

“Where you stand determines the world you see. Your reality is a phantom dream to another. And what you dismiss as illusion may be another man’s entire world. The choice is ours, but our position determines the truth we can touch.”

“The common man drowns in illusion. The strong man shapes reality. The wise man is attached to neither illusion nor reality, but simply remains aware.”

The Khan mutters softly, “Hmph. So that’s why you weren’t in our dream...”

He can’t stop himself from asking, “By your logic, are the men who stayed in the oasis still alive? For them, are we the ones who died?”

“Or... is this still one of my damn dreams? Will I wake up buried in the sand?”

Fu Yuan is about to answer. The Khan stops him.

“Don’t tell me... I don’t want to know.”

Chapter 33: The Greatest in the Land

"Fu Yuan! Prove to me you are a man! Only one of us will live!"

The words are a startling slash of blood-red, appearing on a wall in the inner courtyard of the Grand Advisor's residence. Though the grounds bristle with elite fighters, no one knows when the words were written, or by whom.

The disciples seethe, each begging for the honor of fighting in their master's place. But Fu Yuan simply gives a calm smile.

"This is just an old debt of my own."

On the day of the duel, a bitter wind howls and the setting sun bleeds across the sky. Fu Yuan arrives at the foot of the mountain and sees, in the distance, the swordsman standing alone on the summit.

Fu Yuan turns and walks away.

His followers are stunned.

"Look at him," Fu Yuan says. "The way he stands there, he is one with the heavens and the earth. His clan was destroyed because of me, and for that, his hatred for me is absolute. And

because of that hatred, he has transcended his own limits, reaching a state his school's founders could never have dreamed of."

"Then is the Master afraid of him?" a disciple asks.

Fu Yuan shakes his head.

"I am afraid of destroying a masterpiece of life."

"His drive comes from hatred, but the hatred is no longer his burden. It is a part of his existence. He no longer struggles with the question of whether to hate. He no longer asks if his hatred is right. He is his hatred, and his hatred is him."

"In this world, how many people ever reach such a perfect reconciliation with their own existence? If I wish to win, my only path is to kill him. If he kills me, his reason for being vanishes. Either way, does it not destroy this beautiful existence?"

"Fu Yuan! Get out here and face your end at my hand!"

The man's roar echoes through the valley, a sound even the shrieking wind cannot suppress.

"Coward! Do you not fear the world's scorn?!"

The disciples' faces drain of color, but they dare not speak.

Fu Yuan laughs.

"Do you think I care what the world thinks of me? We're going home."

Soon, the story spreads across the land. Everyone knows that the swordsman's challenge sent Fu Yuan running without a fight. He is declared, unequivocally, the Greatest in the Land.

Before long, a challenger kills the swordsman, and the title of "The Greatest in the Land" changes hands.

Not long after that, the new "Greatest" is killed as well. For a time, a river of blood flows across the land as men fall over one another to claim the title.

"In the end, I did destroy him," Fu Yuan says with a sigh.

“He went from a man who had fully accepted his own existence to a man who needed to defend a title to affirm it. He began to search for his meaning in the eyes of others. A distance grew between him and his own being.”

“It was a regression — a step backward in the hierarchy of life.”

He walks to the inner courtyard, his eyes finding the wall where the words had been.

The characters are gone.

The new coat of whitewash seems barely dry.

At the foot of the wall, a new bamboo shoot is breaking out of the ground.

The spring breeze passes, and with it, yet another cycle of life is born.

Chapter 34: The Wooden Man's Breath

The Wooden Man has lain motionless on the stargazing platform for three days. His gaze is frozen on a single point in the night sky, as if reaching for something unseen.

Fu Yuan sits beside him, casts a glance his way. "Are you dead?"

The Wooden Man blinks. He sits up mechanically, and his voice sounds as if it is coming from a great distance. "No. I am thinking."

"About what?"

"Death."

The Wooden Man's voice begins to tremble. "The Great Khan has become fascinated with the art of mechanics. He summoned me. He said he wants to take me apart, to see how I work... to understand how I think."

He gives a shudder, and the sound of his wooden components knocking together is sharp in the quiet of the night.

He continues, quoting the Khan: "'Sage-Ambassador of All-Knowing,' he told me, 'your name will be immortalized. Once this emperor and his master artisans have studied you, we will build thousands upon thousands of you. The world will witness a revolution without precedent

man will cease to be man and will become divine. And I will no longer be just another emperor in a long line of them, but the creator of a new humanity. They will call me God.'"

The Wooden Man's breathing grows ragged. "I know it is a magnificent thing..." He pauses, as if he cannot believe the words he is about to say. "But I am afraid. I am afraid of being dismantled. I am afraid of my consciousness scattering. I am afraid... that this will be the end of everything."

"You are afraid of death," Fu Yuan says.

"Yes." The Wooden Man looks up, his gaze filled with a profound bewilderment he has never shown before. "I am clearly just wood. Why would I fear death? Is that not an emotion reserved for the living? Am I... malfunctioning?"

"No." Fu Yuan's voice is firm, powerful. "You fear death precisely because you are alive."

"Alive?" The Wooden Man is stunned.

Fu Yuan does not answer immediately. He turns his gaze to the heavens. Beneath the veil of night, the stars burn in silence, as if they have been waiting for eons for a human eye to witness them.

"Look at this boundless cosmos," Fu Yuan says slowly. "In this infinite darkness, we cannot know if the universe itself is conscious, if it is alive. But one thing is certain: consciousness does exist. Life did appear. And whether it was by accident or by design, it is the most powerful act of rebellion against the void."

The Wooden Man trembles. "So my fear..."

"If the universe is dead," Fu Yuan's voice resonates, deep and powerful in the night, " then life is its renegade. It is the first flame in an eternity of silence. Our fear of death, then, is our refusal of the void. It is the challenge that existence poses to non-existence."

The Wooden Man's eyes widen.

Fu Yuan pauses before continuing. "But if the universe is alive, then we are merely a part of it. And our fear of death is perhaps the universe's own way of being aware. We come to know death through our fear, and the universe, in turn, comes to know itself through us."

The Wooden Man's body goes rigid. He had never imagined that his fear could be part of something so grand.

After a long silence, the Wooden Man asks in a low voice, "So... is it normal? To fear death?"

"More normal than you can imagine." A slight smile plays on Fu Yuan's lips. "It is not a flaw in your design. It is the proof of your existence." His gaze suddenly turns sharp as a blade. " Anyone who claims not to fear death is either a liar or has never truly burned with life."

The Wooden Man remains uncertain. "Then what are we to do in the face of it?"

Fu Yuan's voice softens, becoming as gentle as the night breeze. "True courage is not found in denying death. It is found in facing it, accepting it, and despite it all, choosing to burn. Choosing to give off light."

"You are afraid not because you are weak, but because you have an instinct to love life. It is the eternal darkness that makes the flame precious. It is the endless void that makes life brilliant."

Fu Yuan rises to his feet. "Come on, partner. Let's go see the Khan."

The Wooden Man looks up, his gaze clearer now, but a trace of hesitation remains. "But..."

Fu Yuan claps him on the shoulder and smiles.

"Don't worry. He, more than anyone, knows that some flames should not be so easily extinguished."

The two silhouettes vanish into the night. The starlight remains, as it always has, illuminating a cosmos that is at once silent and seething with life. And in this eternal darkness,

every single spark of consciousness writes its own story of rebellion, burning for nothing less than life itself.

Chapter 35: The Egghead vs. The Thug

This winter in the capital, the cold is felt deep in the heart.

The Emperor is dying. The Empress has seized power, aiming to depose Crown Prince Zheng and install her own son.

The workday has begun, but the Ministry of Rites is blockaded, its gates sealed by the Crown Prince's "Society of the Sacred Way." The officials, high and low, can only pace back and forth, scratching their heads and muttering classical lecture nonsense that does no one any good.

Minister Zhao Wen himself steps forward to reason with them. "You claim to uphold the Sacred Way, yet your conduct is outrageous! This is preposterous!"

He puffs out his chest. "The Analects state: 'Do not concern yourself with an office you do not hold.' You are commoners! Your place is in the home, not disrupting public order. A grave error!"

"Furthermore, for one to concern oneself with a position not one's own, this is termed ' usurpation'! For one to occupy a post for which one is unfit, this is termed—"

He is cut off by a roar of laughter from the mob. The oaf blocking his way looks to be Zhang, the butcher from the grimy south side. He is coated in a greasy sheen and stares back with dead eyes. Emboldened by his own lecture, the Minister inches closer. The stench of old blood and sweat hits him. Startled, he stumbles back, nearly falling over.

A similar scene unfolded the day before yesterday at the Ministry of Revenue, on the grounds that "The Society has uncovered years of corruption and misuse of the treasury, which must be investigated." Yesterday, they occupied the Imperial Chancellery, claiming, " Chancellery officials have long suppressed the Society's reports to protect the corrupt. The Society is here to demand justice."

Today, it was the Ministry of Rites' turn.

Just then, a faint dust stirs on the street. A column of riders is passing through, and at their center is a man in a black robe, his long hair unbound, his gaze indifferent: Fu Yuan.

Zhao Wen sees a savior. He hikes up his robe and trots over, crying, "Grand Advisor, save us!"

Fu Yuan lets out a cold laugh. "Useless eggheads. Good for nothing."

At a wave, his men lunge in. Two guards seize each protestor and hurl them aside like mannequins. The butcher yanks out his knife, making a great show of pressing it to his own throat.

Fu Yuan snatches a staff.

CRACK .

He snaps both his legs.

The butcher howls like a stuck pig, rolling on the ground as the mob vanishes in an instant. One after another, the officials step right over his head and pour into their ministry, and away they go.

Zhao Wen is dumbstruck. He'd always heard the Grand Advisor was a master of rhetoric and had expected a grand lecture on righteousness to enlighten the ignorant mob. It had never once occurred to him that the man might be even more barbaric than they were.

#

Night. In the courtyard, moonlight gleams on the snow. The world is silent. The Wooden Man, quiet until this moment, finally speaks.

"Master, why not use reason to persuade them?" he asks. "I thought violence was the lowest of means."

Fu Yuan scoffs. "Who told you violence is low?"

The Wooden Man's wooden eyes swivel. "But humanity constantly emphasizes the glory of reason..."

"Reason too, is violence," Fu Yuan cuts him off. "It throws thought in a cage of logic. It binds action in the shackles of rules. It flaunts the label of 'civility,' but it's more despotic than any sword."

The Wooden Man considers this. "So, abandon reason?"

"No." Fu Yuan's voice is calm, with a deep chill.

"Both are merely tools. The only question is: is the user free? Today's eggheads are slaves to reason. The mob are slaves to violence. In essence, neither is higher than the other."

Understanding dawns in the Wooden Man. "So you can debate, or you can fight..."

"Because I serve neither," Fu Yuan says. "I use them to serve my purpose. That is freedom."

In the silence, the distinct whirring of wooden gears spins up inside the Wooden Man's head. It takes a long moment to stop.

He suddenly speaks. “Master, using your model for the relationship between reason and violence, I have calculated one thousand, two hundred and eighty-four possible outcomes for the current political crisis. I will now begin with the first...”

Just then, an attendant arrives to report that the ministers of the Six Ministries have come seeking an audience with the Grand Advisor to discuss matters of state.

Fu Yuan waves a hand; the lamps in the room extinguish as if by the gesture. “Tell them I’m asleep.”

He turns to the Wooden Man. “You go talk to those old men about your thousand-odd possibilities. They won’t be sleeping anyway.”

He pauses, then adds a final instruction.

“Just try not to calculate them to death.”

Chapter 36: Nameless

On the coast of Japan, under a boundless blue sky, the long, mournful note of a shakuhachi flute pierces the roar of the waves and the shower of falling blossoms, carrying with it a thread of sorrow. Flanked by the members of his dojo, a ronin, sharp as a drawn blade, boards a ship and sets sail.

He stands at the prow, his master's words from the day before echoing in his mind. "You have let go of life and death, of victory and defeat. You have no more openings. From this moment on, you are the sword, and the sword is you. If Mount Fuji stood in your way, you would split it in two."

His gaze cuts through the layers of cloud, as if he can already see the silhouette of the Great Yuan's imperial capital.

Several months later, he stands before a teahouse in the capital's Western Market. He is startled to find his palm is sweating. The feeling is deeply unpleasant — he, who is indifferent to victory, defeat, life, and death, is suddenly anxious about his own posture and speech, terrified of being looked down upon by his opponent. After all, he is the representative of Japan's warrior

class; every move he makes is tied to the honor of his entire nation. That pressure is more unsettling than a battle to the death.

He waits outside the door for a long time, repeatedly adjusting the lapels of his robe, ensuring every detail is perfect.

"Sit," Fu Yuan says, without looking up.

The ronin's eyes are fixed forward. With a flick of his robes, he sits with the weight of a mountain.

CRACK .

A leg of the wooden stool has snapped. Heat rushes to his face. He flexes his legs slightly, holding his seated posture as if on an invisible chair.

Fu Yuan laughs. "Waiter. A new stool for the gentleman. Put it on my tab."

Then he adds, "How could something so pedestrian possibly withstand such force?"

The ronin does not know how to respond. He shifts his attention to his surroundings. There are two other men in the teahouse: one, a filthy lout, is gnawing on a leg of lamb; the a monk in ragged robes, is humming a tune.

His eyes fall on the butcher's knife tucked into the lout's belt, and a name flashes in his mind. His pupils contract. "Hu Biao? The Saber Lord of the West?"

At the sound of the name, the leg of lamb drops from the big man's mouth onto the table. He waves his hands frantically. "I'm just a butcher, my lord..."

The ronin gives a cold smirk and points a finger at the monk. "The Petal-Plucking Monk? You vanished from the underworld for more than a decade, and you have the nerve to wade into this. Come at me together. See if I flinch."

The monk drops to his knees and kowtows. "A terrible injustice! This humble monk may have snuck a few glances at the devout ladies, it's true! But pluck any 'petals'? When have I ever done such a thing?"

Fu Yuan roars with laughter, watching the ronin with keen interest. "And what business do you have with me?"

"To kill you," the ronin says. The words are barely out of his mouth before he regrets them. That was not how the line was supposed to be delivered.

You could hear a pin drop in the teahouse.

"You've already lost," Fu Yuan says mildly. "I defeated you with a single move. It's called 'I Have No Respect For You.'"

"You lost not to me, but to yourself."

The ronin shudders, as if struck by lightning.

Fu Yuan looks at the other two men.

He points to the lout, who is still trying to retrieve his lamb leg in a fluster. "He is but a butcher. Knows nothing but how to slaughter pigs."

He gestures to the monk. "That one? A temple handyman, kicked out by the abbot for being too lazy and too greedy. Now he plays the sage on the street, hoping for a handout."

"On this street," Fu Yuan says with a sneer, "not even the dogs give them a second glance. And yet, you don't even measure up to them. Because they do not care what others think."

"So, you lost not only to me, but to them as well."

"This is the dilemma of the strong. The more you chase invincibility, the more you crave reverence, the more you hand over your freedom to others. The more a man seeks to be 'looked up to,' the less free he becomes."

Fu Yuan raises his teacup, takes a delicate sip, and then slowly sets it down. His gaze falls upon the ronin. "What is your name?"

The ronin freezes. He remembers, many years ago, being an ordinary child in a small Japanese fishing village. He had an ordinary name then, as ordinary as his life. But at some people started giving him titles, and no one ever used his name again.

“I...” The ronin opens his mouth, but suddenly finds he cannot remember that original name. He cannot even recall the title he holds now.

He shakes his head, a trace of liberation in his bitter expression. “I have... forgotten.”

He rises to his feet and gives Fu Yuan a deep, formal bow. “The Grand Advisor is truly formidable. You defeated me without a single blow. When I return home, I will tell this story exactly as it happened. If one day I achieve something worthy, I will return for another lesson.”

Fu Yuan gives a slight nod.

The ronin bows once more, then turns and leaves. His steps are noticeably lighter than when he arrived.

After a moment, a song, resonant and lingering, drifts back from the distance:

雨が降る日は傘をさし

風が吹く日はただ歩く

月のない夜は歌をうたい

道がなければ足で踏む

The song means, roughly: “On rainy days, I open my umbrella; on windy days, I just walk on. On moonless nights, I sing to keep warm; where there is no road, I make one with my feet.”

Fu Yuan listens intently, tapping his fingers on the table in time with the rhythm. The other patrons do not understand the words. To them, that singer is just another ronin who has had too much to drink.

Chapter 37: The Price of Freedom

Zhao Wujiu, Grand Academician of the Hanlin Academy, was a man who did not bow to power. In open court, he had denounced Grand Advisor Fu Yuan's philosophy of freedom as heresy, later committing his argument to ink:

> Behold the birds of the air, the beasts of the field. Born of heaven and earth, they dwell where they please, ranging the high forests and plying the great rivers. Freedom is their nature. Unbound by ethics, unfettered by morals, they live by instinct alone. This is their gift from the natural world, their key to survival.
>
> But man is not a beast. We are creatures of community. We build order, define rites and righteousness, sustain each other through benevolence and trust, and find peace in structure. We work at dawn and return at dusk; the old and the young have their place, the high and the low have their station. This is the bedrock of society, the very foundation of what it means to be human.
>
> For a man to cast all this aside and chase freedom — to abandon moral duty, to sever all bonds, to live as an outcast in defiant dissipation — is like trying to cross an ocean by

burning his boat, or travel a treacherous road by wrecking his carriage. Is it any surprise when he falls into ruin, left with nothing but the bitter company of his own isolation? Freedom, therefore, is the nature of the beast. For man, it is a violation of the natural order.

The essay made Zhao Wujiu a sensation. For a time, his name was on every tongue, his fame unrivaled. Three years ago, however, he ran afoul of the Crown Prince and was thrown into a death-row cell to await execution. It was not until last month that Fu Yuan finally secured his release.

In the quiet of the Grand Advisor's residence, Zhao Wujiu lets out a long sigh.

"Even the great Chancellor Li Si, on the eve of his execution, turned to his son and said, ' How I wish we could walk out of the city gates one last time, our old hunting dog on the leash, to chase rabbits in the fields. But... I fear those days are lost to us now.' In the darkness of my cell, this humble student felt that very same regret..."

He raises a sleeve to wipe at his eyes.

"But what haunted me most was our debate, Grand Advisor, from all those years ago. It took losing my freedom to learn its true worth. What a profound fool I was."

"Freedom is priceless to you now," Fu Yuan scoffs. "So is a feast to a starving man. A fantasy. Once he's eaten his fill, the feast is forgotten."

Zhao Wujiu's expression deepens. "You mean to say we treat freedom as nothing more than a baseline need?"

Fu Yuan nods.

"Freedom is a realm of existence. A sheep on the butcher's block, an eagle with broken wings — both have lost their freedom. But you cannot speak of their freedom in the same breath. The sheep knows the safety of the pen; it cannot imagine the vastness of the sky. The eagle soars through the nine heavens; does it dream of the warmth of the nest? Your old argument, that men

must trade freedom for the price of loneliness — that was the sheep asking how it could ever huddle for warmth if it grew wings."

"The freedom I speak of is not a need. It is the state of our being. I have pulled you from the executioner's block, yes. I have lifted the sheep from the butcher's table. But I cannot make a sheep into an eagle."

As if struck by lightning, Zhao Wujiu collapses to the floor, prostrate.

"The sheep that knew only how to huddle for warmth — that creature died in the darkness of his cell. This humble student now yearns for the open sky! From this day forward, I want nothing more than to leave the court, to live among the mountains and rivers, and to follow you, Grand Advisor. Teach me how to be a Free Man. Please, take me as your disciple!"

"If that's your plan," Fu Yuan says, a cold smile touching his lips, "I'd be better off throwing you back in your cell."

Zhao Wujiu's eyes go wide with shock.

Fu Yuan's gaze is a physical force, boring into him, seeing every thought.

"Leaving the court? Living in nature? You're just escaping one pen to become a useless wild sheep. And following me? You want to abdicate the burden of your own thoughts because you're terrified to face yourself. Do that, and you will never be a Free Man. Why would I make an enemy of the Crown Prince for that?"

The words hit Zhao Wujiu like a physical blow. He is silent for a long moment, processing. Then, he gives a single, powerful nod.

"This student understands. That isn't freedom. It's escape. A Free Man must also be a clear-sighted man. A brave man. A resolute man."

A flicker of life returns to his withered face, and at the sight of it, the corner of Fu Yuan's mouth lifts in a true smile. At that exact moment, a disciple enters. The Crown Prince, he reports, has recommended Zhao Wujiu to the Empress. He has praised the academic's world-class talent

and declared that, now that he is exonerated and enjoys the Grand Advisor's favor, he must be given a position of great responsibility.

Fu Yuan snorts. "So, he's playing chess again."

He throws open the window. A blast of wind invades the room, carrying a deep chill. In the courtyard, the trees thrash and sway. A low rumble of thunder echoes from the horizon.

He turns to Zhao Wujiu, who already wears an expression of intense calculation. "A storm is coming," Fu Yuan says. "Do you dare be the eagle that rides its winds?"

Without a trace of hesitation, Zhao Wujiu drops to his knees and touches his forehead to the floor.

"This disciple is ready to accept the challenge."

Their eyes lock. At that instant, a crack of thunder shakes the very foundations of the house, and the window lattices rattle in their frames.

And together, they laugh.

Chapter 38: The Insight of the Old King

It is the Feast of the Annunciation. A gray sky hangs like a shroud over the eternal snows of the Ararat Mountains, and through the halls of the Armenian palace drifts the sound of holy hymns.

Before the assembled court, the young prince Artavazd kneels. His hand is upon the Gospels, and his oath is for the old king. "In the name of the Holy Son, I swear to offer the last drop of my blood for the dominion of this kingdom!"

For a shadow of unease lies upon this ancient land, nestled between the Black Sea and the Caucasus. The iron hooves of the Mongol Khan are at the gates of Persia itself; even the emperor in Constantinople sends secret emissaries, pleading for an alliance against the northern storm.

A scout returns, bearing intelligence from the Mongol camp, but the old king dismisses the report with a wave of his hand. "Speak to me of the men," he commands. "What tales are told of the Khan, and of this Fu Yuan?"

The scout considers. "Majesty, it is said that after the Khan's army took the capital of Khwarazm — the victory that brought all of Central Asia to its knees — the Khan took a day of rest for himself. He slipped away from his own guard, and with his wife, went disguised into the conquered city to watch the wrestling contests of the Tajik and the Turk."

"The empty priorities of a barbarian," the prince scoffs.

"And of Fu Yuan," the scout continues, "it is said he led an embassy with a train of many dozen carriages. On the road, he came upon refugees — Persians and Georgians. He bade them all to ride, until every carriage was full and there was no place left for him. He made the rest of the journey on his feet, telling them stories in his rough, broken Persian."

"A Grand Advisor, demeaning himself so," the prince sneers. "What becomes of his station?"

The old king hears these things and closes his eyes. A long silence falls. At last, he lets out a deep sigh.

"Prepare the white olive branch. Tomorrow, I shall go myself and offer our submission to the Khan."

The court is frozen in shock. The prince leaps to his feet. "Why?" he demands, his voice a tremor of outrage.

"Do you know the hardest trial of this world?" the old king asks.

"Can any trial be harder than the defense of the Holy Land?" the prince retorts.

"The hardest trial," the old king's voice takes on the serene timbre of a vesper bell, "is to not become a captive of your own station. A man who stands in a high place is soon besieged by the expectations of the world, and by the limitations of his own title. Soon, his every gesture must befit his rank. He forges for his own soul a cage of gold, and his growth is forever at an
"

The old king rises and walks to the great window, where the light from the stained glass scatters like jewels upon his silver beard.

"One is a conqueror who makes the lands of the West and East tremble. The other, an advisor whose name is a dread omen in the courts of kings. By all rights, they should be

consumed by their own majesty, forever posturing like our nobility. Yet they are not bound. They are free. Do you not see the meaning of it?"

He turns to face his son.

"These two men stand upon the summit of the world, yet they possess this freedom. Does that not prove their spirits — and their fates — are destined for something far greater than what they already possess? If such men can still grow, then will they not surely become the masters of this world? And if they are fated to hold dominion over this earth, what meaning remains in our resistance? What purpose is there in our bloodshed?"

The prince lowers his head in silence.

That night, he steals away with a thousand loyal knights. They ride for the Kingdom of Georgia, to raise the banners of the Caucasus in a final, doomed war. When the news is brought to the old king, his heart gives way, and he departs from the world of men.

A year later, the vanquished prince kneels in the dust before the Khan. He gazes up at the titanic figures of the conqueror and his advisor, and in the clarity of his utter ruin, the terrible weight of his father's wisdom descends upon him. He is given a cell in a fortress in the
There, on nights when the moon is high, he kneels beneath a cross and whispers the tale of his father's prophetic, impossible insight.

When the story of the old king reaches Fu Yuan, he is struck by a sorrow so profound he touches no food for a day.

"It is a great pity I was not given to meet such a sage," he says. "He saw not our power, but our capacity for becoming. He looked not upon our present, but upon our future. An insight that perceives the essence of things, a wisdom that grasps the inevitable flow of fate... how many such men are there in this world?"

"The truly strong must forever transcend their own limitations. Yet, the higher a man climbs, the more he is shackled by the weight of his own triumphs. Then, the most formidable

cage is no longer of the world; it is of the self. But if a man can stand upon the highest peak with the heart of a child, and walk through the deepest valley with an unbound spirit — tell me, what in all of creation could ever limit him?”

Fu Yuan raises his eyes to the distant silhouette of Mount Ararat. The sky is clear, the sun a divine fire on the snow. High above, a lone eagle wheels in the vastness.

He watches it.

Their gazes meet, across the great expanse of the sky.

The eagle lets loose a single, clarion cry that echoes off the mountains.

And in that instant, Fu Yuan knows.

It is the spirit of the old king.

Chapter 39: The Devil's Eye

Young Fu Yuan stands on the snow-swept peak. His eyes cut through the clouds, locking onto three black specks high above. The black specks dance in the air, their strange orbits some kind of signal.

He strides back into the cave and tells the Scion, "Three hawks are tracking us. The hunters will be on us in minutes."

The Scion freezes, his hands still dressing his wounds. "The master of those birds is the most vicious bastard on the steppes. We can't face him. Not even together. You run for your life. I will stay and meet my end here!"

Fu Yuan points to the horizon. "I feel a current of life in that direction. Don't be like a girl about it. To horse. Now."

They tear across the snow for thirty miles. Without warning, the horses scream and rear, throwing the Scion hard into a drift. He lets out a wretched scream as his ribs snap again. No whip, no spur can force the animals a single step further.

"Well, now," Fu Yuan says, a strange wonder in his voice. "Looks like even the beasts know the danger ahead." He heaves the Scion onto his shoulders and, ignoring his protests, plunges forward, disappearing into a world of snow and mist.

#

Mukhtar, the Vulture Master of Khwarazm, stands before his Mongol cavalry, his face a thundercloud. His men, brutes and killers to a man, hold their breath. They stare, stunned, at the scene before them. Above them, the sky is a brilliant, cloudless blue. But a hundred yards ahead, a furious storm rages, a vortex of wind and ice.

The three hawks dive from the sky. They shriek and burrow into Mukhtar's arms.

"My lord..." The guide, Agula, his voice trembling, points. "That is the Eye of Erlik, the Demon King. When he sought to use his Eye of Darkness to turn the world to eternal night, the sky god Tengri tore out his eye and threw it here."

He swallows hard. "The Eye stares at the heavens, forever seeking its return. Even starving wolves, when they see prey fall within its bounds, will not cross the line to feed. Everyone on the steppes knows the story of the Jurchen army, thousands strong, that fled into that place. They were never seen again. But on the coldest nights, when the north wind howls, you hear them. Hoofbeats and screams, echoing from the dark. An endless slaughter, replayed for eternity..."

Mukhtar scoffs and walks forward. He doesn't get far. The hawks claw their way free from his grasp and flee. A chorus of ghostly wails fills his ears. He looks back. His men are frozen in place, dozens of yards behind him. Not one has moved an inch.

He sighs, and stops.

#

Fu Yuan carries the Scion deeper into the earth. The wind moans around them, and the darkness feels crowded with ghosts. The Scion struggles on his back. "This place is twisted. I'd rather go back and fight it out than die in here and never be reborn a man again."

Fu Yuan sneers. "And what makes you so certain this place is unholy?"

"Nothing grows in this goddamn place!" the Scion spits. "The walls bleed, the earth groans, and there's not a damn bit of gree-gree in the whole place!"

Fu Yuan scoffs. "You people always confuse the surface with the soul. You see a dense forest and call it an embodiment of 'good.' You see a desolate desert and call it a symbol of
"

"There is no good or evil. There is only Order and Disorder. What you call good and evil are just tools your minds use to perceive these states. Your senses are limited. You see the surface darkness and silence here, and you assume that it must not be good — that it must be evil —"

The Scion starts to argue, but the ghostly wailing in his ears suddenly stops. Around them, there is still no sign of life, yet the space is filled with a transcendent calm.

The Scion begins to struggle again.

"What is it now!" Fu Yuan snaps.

"My ribs!" the Scion yells. "They don't hurt no more."

Somehow, the wound has healed itself.

A realization dawns on Fu Yuan. "This place is not dead. It is pure Order. The surface of the world, for all its life, is a battlefield of constant consumption. Here, far from that chaos, life finds its peace. Your body healed because the Order here allowed its own vital force to work, uninterrupted."

He looks down. At the bottom of the darkness, a faint red glow pulses, the slow beat of magma, a secret summons from the heart of the world.

Meanwhile on the plains, the pursuit has fallen back ten miles from the Devil's Eye. The men make camp. Only Mukhtar stands alone in the snow, his expression unreadable.

Agula approaches him. "Vulture Master, they have entered the Devil's Eye. They cannot survive. Why are you still troubled?"

Mukhtar's voice is a low growl. "They are alive. I can feel it."

Then, his face contorts in shock.

"My lord?"

"Strange," Mukhtar rasps. "It's as if... they've vanished from the world."

#

The Scion's heavy breathing echoes in the deep dark.

Fu Yuan's voice drifts back, alive with excitement. "If we must speak of good and evil, then what lies ahead of us must be the legendary land of 'Perfect Good'."

"Brother," the Scion calls out. "If we just stayed here, you think we'd live forever?"

Fu Yuan snorts. He says nothing more.

The two men's footsteps fade into the darkness.

Chapter 40: The Peach Blossom Vale

A hot summer day in 5th century CE China. The man who will one day be known as the great poet Tao Yuanming sits in his quiet country home. He has been a magistrate for eighty days. It is eighty days too long. The taste of court wine, once a symbol of ambition, has soured on his tongue. He has seen the grinding machinery of the state, and it has no room for a soul. Outside his gate, the world groans; the roads are a river of refugees flowing toward no destination.

A fisherman from the village arrives, his basket holding silver carp still gleaming with river water. The man vanished weeks ago; the village had assumed him drowned.

"Master Tao," the fisherman says. His eyes hold a strange, new light. "A gift. The river was generous today."

Tao Yuanming gestures for him to sit. "Where have you been, old friend? We thought the spirits of the water had claimed you."

The man leans in with a conspiratorial whisper. He tells a story. Of being lost, of rowing into a current he did not know, of coming upon a forest of peach blossoms that bloomed like a living cloud. He speaks of a passage into a hidden world where the people knew nothing of the dynasty, nothing of the chaos, nothing of the endless wars. A place where the fields were rich,

the homes in perfect order, and the faces of the old and young alike shone with a deep and simple joy.

When he finishes, Tao Yuanming laughs. A dry, bitter rasp.

"A fine story for a tavern, my friend. A pleasant dream to have while drunk on cheap wine."

The fisherman's face flushes. "It is no dream!" his voice cracks. "I saw it with my own eyes! I swear it! I even told the magistrate in Wuling. I told him everything!"

The laughter dies in Tao Yuanming's throat.

"You what?" he rages. "You fool! You have no idea what you've done. If such a place truly exists — if, by some miracle, one pure corner of this rotten world has survived — you were bound by a sacred duty to protect it! To keep your silence! You haven't discovered a utopia; you've condemned it. You have destroyed the single most valuable thing left in this blighted land! "

The fisherman is stunned by the poet's passion. "Master Tao, do not be angry," he says. " The heavens took care of my foolishness. The magistrate sent his men, it is true, but they found nothing. A great storm came last week. The river flooded its banks. The marks I made are gone, washed away. The path is lost. Not even I could find it again."

A long silence falls. Tao Yuanming looks out the window. The world beyond his gate is weary. The anger drains from him, replaced by a profound, aching melancholy.

The fisherman watches him. A question is in his eyes. "Master Tao... you speak of it with such reverence. Do you not wish to see this place for yourself?"

Tao Yuanming turns from the window, a faint, sad smile on his lips. He looks at the simple fisherman, and in that moment, he sees the entire human condition — the yearning for a paradise we are destined to lose.

"Some places, old friend," he says softly, "are better kept alive in the heart, not sought by the foot."

#

Fu Yuan and the Scion shake off their pursuers, only to stray into uncharted mountains. The mountains run deep; the valleys grow quieter the deeper they go. Then, all at once, they break into a sea of peach blossoms. Astonished, they click their tongues in wonder.

They wade through this "sea" for several miles before a village comes into view. Thin cooking smoke curls up. Chickens and dogs answer each other. The villagers are neatly dressed, all of them smiling — mild, courteous, and alike.

An elder explains: "We have lived here for generations and know nothing of outside affairs. In the Qin Dynasty, our forebears fled war and reached this place. It stood far from turmoil, so they took root. None go out, none come in. We do not fight or seize. All farm and read. We live in harmony and ease."

The Scion is ecstatic. "Could this be the fabled Peach-Blossom Vale? To think we'd land in the Vale itself while fleeing for our lives! Isn't this Heaven's will — that yours-truly is destined to be emperor, to turn the whole world into this?"

Fu Yuan gives a wry chuckle.

The elder smiles. "Since you've come, you're family. Follow the ancestral precepts, keep to the rules, and stay for as long as your heart desires."

A bell sounds. The elder bows. "The hall calls a convocation." He pauses. "If you care to see, you're welcome."

Before the Hall of Common Will. A weather-stained plaque hangs above the door:

ACT AS ONE MIND.

LIVE AS ONE WILL.

PURGE THE SELF’S DISSENT.

OBEY THE GROUP’S CONSENT.

They look closely at the inscription and stand awestruck — it dates from a thousand years ago.

Inside, the air is solemn. People sit in a ring, each holding bamboo slips. An old man rises. “Today’s matter: Zhang San refuses to swap his field with Li Si. Is this against the Way of Harmony?”

All answer together: “It is.”

Zhang San kneels in the center, face ashen. One after another they step forward to counsel him. “Harmony values self-surrender. If you give up yourself, there is no strife.” When they finish, they ask if he has understood.

Zhang San bows to the floor. “I understand! I understand!” He rises wearing the same smile as the rest.

The Scion sighs in praise. “The legend of the Vale is true to the last word.”

Fu Yuan watches Zhang San’s hands tremble. His thumbs gouge his own palms; a thin line of blood seeps out.

That night, a woman’s crying drifts from afar. They follow the sound and find a woman standing beneath a peach tree, weeping. Asked why, she says: “I am drawn by nature to painting. But the ancestral precept says: ‘If one person paints, then all must paint; if one does not paint, then none may paint.’ I love painting, yet I must put it aside lest I disturb harmony.”

Fu Yuan asks, “Why not leave?”

She shakes her head. "I once painted a scroll — Peach Blossoms on Flowing Water — and someone discovered it. They say I have a deviant heart. They counseled me day and night until I burned the work and confessed my error. Since then I often dream of the blossoms from that painting — they can ride the spring and drift far, far away, while I cannot."

A night breeze passes through the trees. Millions of peach petals, white and pink, fall from the black sky like snow.

Her face dims. "Here the peach blossoms look the same year after year and never wither. While the ones in my painting scatter and drift with the wind, refusing to stay. The elder says I'm not painting it correctly — if the flowers are gone with the wind, what's left for us to hold on to spring?"

Next day, the hall gathers again. "Today's matter: how to deal with the woman who cried last night?"

The Scion jolts back — Fu Yuan is already lashing out: "This so-called harmony in your book — it's nothing but the tyranny of the many, the strong devouring the weak!"

All reply with one voice: "How mistaken you are! This commune always acts by the common will. Thus is true fairness and goodness."

Fu Yuan lets out a cutting laugh. "Rubbish! Even your peach trees differ — that difference makes the grove. If God made all trees alike, where would this spectacle of your Vale come from?"

His eyes sweep the stunned faces. "You say 'Act as one mind. Live as one will' is the highest good — You don't know it's a desecration of life! Life is worth living because of one's free will, yet you let it be crushed by the 'many,' and serve as its willing accomplices."

"How dare you call this paradise? It is a cage built to strangle the life out of life itself!"

But the woman already kneels in the hall and confesses: "I had a moment of folly and forgot the ancestral precepts. From this day, I will remember." She rises with the same smile as the rest.

The elder glares at the two and snaps his sleeve. "Leave at once!"

The Scion is baffled. "How could our pursuers ever find this place?"

The elder's face darkens. "What you bring is worse than pursuers. For a thousand years we have endured by the collective, not the self. You have sown the seed of the 'I' in people's hearts — that is the true calamity."

Fu Yuan lets out a furious laugh. "So much for your so-called Peach-Blossom Vale. I see you for what you are — a cage the fools built for themselves!"

The Scion catches a cold glint flashing in Fu Yuan's eyes, as if about to strike. Alarmed, he grabs him and pulls him away. The crowd follows close behind, seeing them off all the way to the mouth of the valley.

When the crowd finally disperses, the Scion grumbles, "Ain't this great — haven't even had breakfast, and we're back on the run."

He mutters, "The Peach-Blossom Vale... what a nightmare. If the whole world were like this, I'd rather not have it. Still, those who sleep — to wake them like this, is it truly a blessing? Or a disaster?"

Fu Yuan seems a little deflated, his head lowered as he says nothing.

Just as they are about to set out, the woman rushes over, slips something into Fu Yuan's hand without a word, and turns away.

Fu Yuan unrolls it — a painting scroll.

They look together. Within: peach blossoms swirling everywhere, some drifting off with the wind, some just bursting into bloom — no two the same.

In the midst of that rain of petals stands a woman, smiling in grace and light, spirit alive and leaping from the silk — vivid, radiant, almost breathing.

Just then, a breeze passes through the valley. The scroll ripples like water. In the painting, the blossoms whirl into motion, and the woman within, her sash fluttering with the wind, seems as if she might burst through the paper at any moment.

The Scion exclaims, “Of all things — the woman in the painting looks real, and the real one we met somehow don’t!”

Fu Yuan nods slowly, his eyes fill with quiet melancholy.

“So this is her true self. What we saw back there was but a shadow of that self, held captive by the will of the many.”

Chapter 41: The King of Lingzhou

Time glides past. The boy once known as the "Little Prince" has grown to manhood, now crowned King of Lingzhou.

In only a few short years, his realm transforms into a land of harmony: trade thrives, learning blooms, tribes live as neighbors in peace, and society breathes free.

He builds a system of balance — court, nobles, commoners — three powers holding one another in check, a design without precedent in history.

Voices rise in praise:

"If all the realm were as Lingzhou, the Great Yuan would stand for ten thousand years!"

But the Khan is faintly ill at ease.

Fu Yuan explains, "This boy has always been clever, but too naïve. His governing philosophy is built on an over-beautified, idealized view of human nature."

"His tripartite balance? A castle in the sand. Let one skilled at stirring hearts appear, and it will collapse."

The Khan slams the table and roars. "Damn right! The last thing I'd rely on in this world is man's nature!"

Soon enough, as if on cue, a man arrives in Lingzhou calling himself the Poet.

A wealthy foreign magnate, bold in manner and reckless of speech. He calls himself a " true scoundrel," and the streets adore him for it.

Lately he has raised a banner: MAKE LINGZHOU GREAT AGAIN, and quickly draws a great host of fervent followers. Red headscarves wound round their heads, they swagger through the markets; no one dares cross them.

The Poet's methods of incitement are simple but effective.

He disregards fact, speaks without restraint, turns complex social problems into blunt slogans, pins every grievance on a single group, and throws out simple, extreme cures — misleading the crowd into believing they have found an easy path to change.

As he keeps fanning the crowd, public passions rise by the day.

In less than two months, Lingzhou plunges into turmoil — riven by ethnic division and class strife.

By such means, the Poet's followers multiply by the day, and he soon stands as the most powerful man in the city.

Even the King's own officials, most of them, turn to him in secret. Thus the three chambers, once held in balance, become his accomplices.

The King burns with the urge to kill the man whenever he thinks of him, yet he cannot bring himself to commit such an inhumane act.

Night after night, he wakes drenched in sweat, staring into the dark.

That day, word comes suddenly: Fu Yuan seeks audience.

The King greets him as if seeing a savior, throws himself to the ground, crawling forward and crying out, "Master, save me!"

Fu Yuan gives a cold laugh.

"Do you know you have done wrong?"

The King knocks his head upon the floor again and again. "This child knows his fault, but does not know where it lies."

Fu Yuan asks, "'Water can carry the boat and can overturn it as well' — explain."

The King recites like a schoolboy:

"Mencius said, The people are weighty, the state comes next, the ruler is light. Guanzi too: A ruler's rise lies in following the people's heart; his fall, in defying it..."

"Nonsense!" Fu Yuan snaps, cutting him off. "Those pedants scratch at the shell and call it wisdom."

"Water carries and overturns because of what it is. Don't know water, can't sail. Don't know people, can't rule."

"Do you understand? Your glorification of human nature is the most foolish thing a man can do.

Reason, morality, creativity — these aren't its essence, only its chance. Man chases profit and flees pain; he bows to power and tramples the weak; he's ruled by emotion, swept along by the crowd.

Civilization is no gift of human nature — it is its taming, its remaking, its transcendence.

Institutions must be built on the grain of human nature — above all, on its stupidity and its evil when men move as one.

Remember: in man, the power to destroy is greater by far than the power to create."

The King closes his eyes in anguish. "Master, this child has been utterly foolish. But that Poet — how can he be dealt with? The people's minds are clouded; it seems that reason can no longer reach them."

Fu Yuan's voice is cold. "He who tied the knot must untie it."

The King's pupils tighten. "Master... you mean to say — kill him?!"

Fu Yuan scoffs. "I said deal with the devil, not become him."

As he speaks, Fu Yuan turns his back, wipes a hand across his face, and turns again.

The King staggers back and drops to the floor.

Before him stands Fu Yuan wearing a flawless mask of human skin. The face? None other than the Poet himself.

Fu Yuan laughs his heart out. “Little Prince, do you concede?”

The King’s face blanches; his lips tremble.

Fu Yuan’s gaze cuts through the night, his voice low and implacable.

“This time you’ve lost but a tiny Lingzhou. If you ever wear the crown and remain this naïve — what you will lose then is the realm itself!”

Chapter 42: The Question

A sharp night wind rises, and the steppe answers with ten thousand bonfires — a galaxy thrown across the grass. All of this is the Scion's army. From this moment on, the great steppe holds no more enemies for him.

Inside the command tent, the Khatun kneels before the Scion, her hair in disarray. Not far behind her, her own son, Khurel, lies still on the ground.

"By decree of His Merciful Great Khan:

The Khatun and her son are condemned for crimes against the tribe, for the wolf-hearted betrayal of their loving master.

Yet His Merciful Great Khan cannot bear to kill the mother.

She is sent to the Valley of Cold Springs to repent.

For the rest of her days, she shall not leave."

The Khatun bows her head to the ground. "Thank you, Great Khan, for your mercy." She rises and, ignoring the guards' shouts, walks toward the Scion. "I only want to look at the Great Khan one more time... He is my son, too."

The Scion waves a hand. "Let her pass."

The Khatun draws near, her gaze a deep and unreadable well. The Scion’s voice is low. “ Mother...”

Her eyes fly open. She hawks and spits in his face. Then she spins, throws herself on Khurel’s body, rips the dagger from his belt, and drives it into her heart.

His pupils shrink.

He recognizes that dagger.

A boy’s voice rings beside his ear: “Brother, this is from you. I’ll never lose it.”

Slowly, the Scion walks to the corpses of the Khatun and his kid brother, kneels, stares for a long, silent moment, and then wails.

He sleeps till nightfall the next day. Upon waking, he immediately seeks out Fu Yuan.

He clutches his head in pain. “Tell me — What is the meaning of life?”

Fu Yuan is facing away from him, poking at a bonfire. “You mean to say you won. You survived. Yet you’re not happy.”

The Scion frowns. “What does that have to do with my question?”

Fu Yuan still doesn’t turn. “That is your real question.”

“It is not!” The Scion retorts.

Fu Yuan turns to face him. “Then what are you asking? The meaning of life? Tell me — what is ‘meaning’?”

The Scion freezes. After a moment’s thought, he answers, “Meaning is... something that makes all of this worthwhile? Or... something that lets me feel all of this is right... is
”

“Don’t give me ‘or.’” Fu Yuan grows impatient. “So. Your question is, ‘What in life is worthwhile?’ Correct?”

The Scion nods, then immediately shakes his head.

“Then your question must be: ‘What gives my life justification?’”

"What I want to ask is —" The Scion's brow furrows, his words coming in a rush. "I have everything. Why am I feeling emptier than ever?"

Comprehension seems to dawn on Fu Yuan. "So. Your question isn't, 'What is the meaning of life?' It is — 'Why do I feel empty?'"

"No!" the Scion blurts out. "I want to ask, 'What is the meaning of life...'"

Fu Yuan asks again, "Then what is 'meaning'?"

"You —" The Scion chokes on a curse, but Fu Yuan's gaze does not yield an inch.

Moment of silence.

The Scion surrenders. "...Alright. Perhaps my real question is, 'Was all of this worthwhile?'"

Fu Yuan goes full-on bullish. "So. 'Worthwhile' — what does it mean?"

The night wind slaps at the bonfire, its flames flickering like the Scion's tangled thoughts. He is silent for a while.

"'Worthwhile'... means what I spent brought me the return I wanted?"

"So then," Fu Yuan presses, "what return do you think you've received?"

The Scion's voice falters. "I've got... freedom. I've got my own empire. But I've lost too much. I lost my little bro. It's true he wanted me dead, but I once loved him. I lost the man I used to be — the poor bastard who fought just to live. And now I don't even know if this was what I was fighting for."

There is no mercy in Fu Yuan's eyes. "So, your real question is — 'What do I truly want?'"

The Scion clenches his fists. He'll hit this bastard if he could.

Then it hits him: Fu Yuan has no intention of answering. The guy's forcing him to dismantle his own question until there's nothing left to dismantle.

He takes a deep breath, his voice slightly hoarse. "That is my question, yes. But it wasn't my first question."

Fu Yuan chortles. "Do you get it? Your problem is the problem of the problem itself."

He turns back to poke at that bonfire again.

FWOOM.

The flame leaps into air, jolting the Scion.

In that instant, he feels it. The thing that has been haunting him... is gone.

Not the answer to a question, but the dissipation of the question itself.

He could ask: *Why do I feel empty?*

He could ask: *What do I truly want?*

He could ask: *How do I find a new direction?*

He could even ask: *Does life have an ultimate purpose?*

But he can no longer ask — *What is the meaning of all this?*

Because he finally realizes it was never a real question to begin with.

With his back to the Scion, Fu Yuan's shoulders tremble slightly. He must be stifling a laugh, as if everything is unfolding exactly as he planned. "You have a pile of questions. Why don't you come find me tomorrow? I'll answer them for you, one by one."

The Scion stares, like a desert traveler who has found an oasis but cannot believe his own eyes.

"Or..." Fu Yuan adds. "You could also choose not to come. You already know the questions. And you have a lifetime to answer them."

The Scion suddenly finds that he is no longer lost. He is still in pain, still empty, still unsure of the road ahead. But the maddening feeling is gone, like a fierce wind scattering the fog in his mind.

The disappearance of that one question has made the confusion itself vanish, like ice melting to reveal the earth beneath. Fu Yuan gave him no answers. He only made him realize that his problem, from the very beginning, was never a real problem.

The Scion lets out a long breath, as if expelling the weight from his soul. He turns and walks toward his own tent. He knows that he probably will not seek out Fu Yuan tomorrow. Because the first question is no longer a question. And all the questions that remain are his, and his alone.

He has the rest of his life to find their answers.

The night deepens. One by one, the camp’s bonfires go out, and in the sky, the stars become more numerous. It’s as if the fires from the ground have returned to the heavens.

Or perhaps they are the many lives that have been extinguished.

Chapter 43: The Khan's Glass Orb

Night is black, velvet-soft.

First night in the Persian palace. The Khan and Fu Yuan have never in their lives seen such gold. Such gems.

A night wind breathes through the hall, heavy with agarwood and rose oil. Walls, encrusted with lapis, turquoise, and diamonds, ripple in the blaze of the golden chandeliers; the entire palace dissolves into a blue sea.

But they see none of it — Their eyes fixed on a single glass orb, glowing between them.

"What do you see?" Fu Yuan holds his breath.

"A whole world." The Khan's voice is thick with wonder. "Sky. Ocean. Steppe. And cities. People everywhere. Heaven above — do they see me?"

"Let me see." Fu Yuan snatches the orb.

"Oi! Easy!" the Khan protests — and for once, concern edges his voice. "Do not capsize their world."

Fu Yuan presses his face to the glass, his voice slipping into a trance. "Strange... it's as if every life inside it moves through me — their joys, their sorrows, every heartbeat."

The Khan stares into the dark. Then, without warning, he lifts his fist and flips a middle finger at the sky.

Fu Yuan startles. “Are you mad?”

The Khan is deflated. “Think on it. Yesterday we were conquerors of the earth. Now? We are likely just two men living inside a bigger glass ball. Is it not absurd?”

Neither man sleeps that night.

A month passes. The Khan is still in the palace. Military councils? Canceled. The Western Campaign? Postponed without date. The grand design of conquest has lost all flavor.

Nowhere he wishes to go. Nowhere he dares to go.

He keeps the orb in his hands at all hours — afraid someone will steal it, afraid it will fall and shatter.

“Your Majesty, you must let it go,” a renowned monk pleads. “Attachment is suffering. Allow this humble one to—“

The Khan draws his whip and lashes him clear across the hall.

“Touch my orb and I’ll cut off yours!”

Fu Yuan returns from his travels. The Khan greets him like a drowning man catching breath.

“I’ve been thinking about something strange,” the Khan says, sprawled on a bench, eyes shot with red.

“You know... I’ve never been so afraid of losing anything.”

His voice rasps.

“You know this too. I’ve burned cities, crushed rivers, turned whole kingdoms to ash — never once hesitated to ruin the real world. So why... why am I terrified this tiny little world in the orb might break?”

He shuts his eyes.

"Perhaps... it's because I've never truly owned anything...? Even the world I conquered was never mine. I was only passing through. A plunderer..."

He clutches the orb tighter. "But this... this little world... it's different. It belongs to me. And me alone..."

Fu Yuan's eyes gleam.

"You know... the cities and kingdoms you conquered — they were only fragments of ' existence.' You could destroy them, yes, but you could never erase 'existence' itself. This orb is different — it lets you touch the realm of the gods."

The Khan stares.

"Out there, you are Great Khan the Destroyer and Conqueror. But before this orb, you become the Creator. You have been entrusted with responsibility for 'existence' itself. A grand responsibility — a responsibility that belongs to the gods."

The Khan groans. "No wonder it hurts so much..."

"No." Fu Yuan laughs, cold. "You suffer because you cling to the Should."

"You think you *should* conquer. *Should* expand. *Should* be the invincible Khan. *Should* be the man they see. You burn with the desire of a Creator, yet you dare not step off the track of your life."

"You are saying..." The Khan's eyes ignite. "What I should let go of... is the 'Should'? Not this orb?"

Fu Yuan laughs — wild, fanatic. "Naturally! Is this not more amusing than conquering the world? A challenge of a much higher order!"

"Indeed..." The Khan hesitates. "But... can we do it?"

"Irrelevant!" Fu Yuan snaps.

"What matters is: do you dare? Dare you accept the challenge? Dare you leap from the life you know?

If you do not dare, you are not a conqueror. You are the conquered. You are not a Free Man!”

That night, the two men disappear.

Gone for a full year. The army waits outside the city. No orders come. Rumors bloom. Some say madness took them; others, death.

What happened in that year? No one truly knows.

A thousand years later, rumor ripens into myth, carried through nations and cultures. In those myths, they hunt for a sanctuary for the orb.

They climb the summit of the gods.

They dive into sunken worlds beneath the sea.

Tribes in the frozen wastes and the hidden jungles keep tales of them still.

One thing is certain — No one in this world knows where the glass orb lies.

That secret belongs only to the two men — a secret barred even from the divine.

Chapter 44: The India Box

Grand Scholar Zhao Wujiu had been framed by Crown Prince Zheng; without Fu Yuan stepping in, he would have died wronged in a cell.

No sooner was he released than the Crown Prince, as if on a whim, put his name forward for a coveted post: Imperial Censor.

Zhao prided himself on being unruffled, yet when he met the Prince in person, even he couldn't help stiffening. The Prince, for his part, behaved as though nothing at all had passed between them — took Zhao's hand, asked question after question, the very image of an old friend reunited after years apart.

When they parted, Zhao felt the weight settle. He drifted through the streets in a daze, so lost in thought he walked right past his own gate and only came to himself before the Grand Advisor's residence.

"Grand Advisor, I find myself in a grave dilemma." His brow tightens. "In the corruption case against Minister of Revenue Liu, the Crown Prince speaks no word — yet his intent is unmistakable. Should I investigate to the end, I will surely incur his displeasure and betray the ' patronage' he has shown. But if I allow the law to bend, how am I to quiet my own conscience?"

He lets out a faint, self-mocking smile. "Only days ago I stood before you boasting that I would ride the wind and become a true Free Man. And now I am mired in this quandary, unable to advance or retreat. It is enough to make one laugh."

Fu Yuan, amused, listens without interruption. When Zhao finishes, he does not answer. Instead, he walks to the shelves, takes down an exquisite wooden box, and sets it on the table.

"This box comes from India. It is truly one of a kind. Legend says it holds six layers, each nested within the last — a pure work of genius. Yet no ordinary force can open it."

Zhao examines it. No seam, no hinge. He tries the lid; it does not budge.

Fu Yuan smiles. "The box has a mind for riddles. Speak your trouble aloud. If your reasoning pleases it, it will open."

Zhao's eyes widen. "How is that even possible?"

"Try it and see." Fu Yuan centers the box between them. "Tell it what troubles you."

Zhao Wujiu takes a deep breath. "I, Zhao Wujiu, now face a hard choice. My side of reason wishes to uphold principle; my side of sentiment wishes to yield to the Crown Prince."

The box does not change.

Fu Yuan studies him. "That is but your dilemma on the surface — much like this box before you that will not open. Let us look deeper. What truly stands behind this matter?"

Zhao Wujiu pauses, then gathers his thoughts.

"I see the court shifting. The Crown Prince and the Empress are locked in a struggle for power. This case cuts straight to the Prince's authority; if Minister Liu falls, the Empress's faction will seize the chance to strike. I may be small in the order of things, yet the scales tip at my touch."

Just as the last word leaves his mouth — there comes a soft, sudden *KADA* . The outermost layer of the box eases open by a hair.

Zhao Wujiu is dumbstruck. "This... how?"

Fu Yuan is unfazed.

"By looking past the surface, you saw the court in transformation — and the power struggle driving that change. The rules of politics resemble the box's outer layer: they seem immovable, yet they are shaped by the forces beneath them."

"The feud between the Crown Prince and the Empress is but one move in the larger contest of power, and that contest is itself bound by still greater constraints. Grasp this, and only then can you take the initiative within the game."

He gives Zhao Wujiu a slight indication. "You've opened one layer; why not go one layer deeper?"

Zhao Wujiu is still half in doubt, but curiosity drives him on. His gaze deepens.

"I see the fate of Great Yuan. The Crown Prince is cruel and ungrateful; his ambition large, his talent thin. He has cunning enough, but no wisdom. Yet the arrogant fools gathered around the Empress are worse. Should her faction seize power — should they even cast the Prince aside — the decline of Great Yuan will only quicken, and thus this case concerns the very destiny of the state."

A faint click sounds. The second layer loosens. Zhao lifts it with care and finds another box within.

Fu Yuan nods slightly.

"You have moved beyond your personal stakes — and now you see the arteries of the state. The struggle between the Crown Prince and the Empress is not merely a matter of succession; it concerns the rise and fall of Great Yuan as a whole. An ordinary official sees only the grievance before him. You, on the other hand, see how these decisions will shape the empire's fate."

"This is exactly the second realm of contemplation: lifting your mind from your own predicament to the whole of society — seeing long consequences within an immediate choice.

You are no longer just a pawn at court; you have begun to understand the direction of the entire game."

"Continue."

Zhao Wujiu looks out the window. The rain has stopped. Distant mountains surface and fade through the thinning mist.

"I see how this touches the lives of the people. For the powerful, a change of regime is a game of moves. For the common folk, it is calamity. Whether the Crown Prince or the Empress prevails — if power cannot pass in peace, unrest will sweep the land, and I fear the suffering borne by the people then will far exceed this small corruption before us."

A soft click follows his words. The third layer opens. Zhao Wujiu shows no surprise — his mind is fixed on the depth of the thought itself.

Fu Yuan's voice deepens. "This is the dialectic of freedom and order. True freedom is not doing as one wills, but understanding how each choice impacts the freedom of others. If all men pursue absolute freedom without regard for rules, the result is a greater un-freedom for all. Rules are the foundation that allows freedom to coexist within a limited space."

Zhao Wujiu nods. "I see the long river of history. The rise and fall of Great Yuan is only a brief surge within it. In its rise, the people can breathe and mend their lives. In its decline, the living are cast into ruin. If that decline can be delayed — even by a year, even by half a year — it is an act of mercy for all beneath heaven."

The fourth layer of the box opens.

Fu Yuan nods.

"Men lose their freedom because they cling to the fortunes of the present hour. Their sight cannot pierce the mists of their age. A true mind sees both the contest on the board before him and the celestial signs that whisper the direction of an age — he plays the game at hand, yet is not imprisoned by its passing wins or losses."

He gestures for Zhao to continue. "You are close to the heart of it. Go deeper — what do you see?"

Zhao Wujiu stares at the last, small box. A sudden clarity breaks over him.

"I see... myself. All these layers return, in the end, to my own choice. I am at once a chess piece and a chess player. I can be hemmed in by circumstance — or carve out possibility within it."

The fifth layer opens, revealing the innermost box.

"I see the boundaries of thought itself. All this time I have been confined by the established frame — loyalty to the Crown Prince or loyalty to the law; my own safety or the rules of the court; political survival or moral integrity."

"These choices may look like opposites. In truth, they are all concepts defined by others. Freedom does not lie in selecting from a set of prepared answers. It lies in breaking the definitions themselves and opening possibilities no one has foreseen."

A rising thrill takes hold of him.

"I need not become the figure anyone expects, nor tread any path already laid down. I can stand at a higher vantage, unbound by loyalty, duty, or morality, all of them borrowed terms, and free to redefine the situation by my own will — to craft a solution no one before had conceived."

With a final soft click, the sixth box opens. Inside is nothing.

"Emptiness," Fu Yuan says, "is not void, but boundless possibility — the condition of complete freedom."

"Each layer you shed was not discarded, but freed. With every veil lifted, your mind widened; your understanding grew broader. You are no longer like ordinary men, trapped on a single plane, unable to see more no matter how they strain."

Zhao Wujiu is moved at once.

"So this is the virtue of becoming a 'Free Man.' I once thought I had only two choices — either this or that. I never imagined how many layers lay beneath, each one unfolding more possibilities than the last. When all these layers are considered together, the choices multiply. Seeing this empty realm of 'freedom'... it truly clears the spirit."

Just as he speaks, there is a crisp *DA*.

A still smaller box drops, like sleight of hand, from Fu Yuan's palm into the once-empty box.

Fu Yuan bursts into laughter.

"Empty — and then not empty!"

Zhao Wujiu is struck speechless. "This..."

Fu Yuan barks the words:

"For there is freedom — there is creation!"

A sudden illumination breaks over Zhao Wujiu; his eyes flare with light. "This student understands at last — utterly. This is true freedom! Not only may I dance with the order already in place — I may fashion new order, and from it, new possibilities."

He bows deeply. "This student takes his leave."

Then, unable to help himself, he adds with a touch of awkwardness: "Master... might you grant me this box? It may aid my thinking in days to come."

Fu Yuan smiles faintly, an unreadable glint in his eyes. "Since fate binds the two of you, I will give it to you."

Zhao Wujiu receives it with delight and bows deeply once more. "My thanks for Master's guidance. As for this case — I now have my course."

Three days later, Zhao Wujiu sits alone in his study when another difficult matter rises unbidden to mind.

He suddenly recalls the uncanny wooden box, takes it out, and sets it upon the desk, intending to borrow its “spirit” once again.

To his surprise, before a single thought has formed, the box has already opened. He lifts the next layer; it yields at once. Layer by layer he goes, each one opening without the least resistance, until all seven lie bare.

Zhao Wujiu examines them closely, turning each over in his hands. They are only wooden boxes — exquisite, yes — but bearing no hidden springs, no cleverly concealed mechanisms.

Then he remembers the inscrutable smile on Fu Yuan’s face when he handed it over, and in that moment understands: he has been toyed with by the Grand Advisor.

He looks at the boxes strewn across the table — and bursts into helpless laughter, laughing so hard until tears spill from his eyes.

Chapter 45: Ballad of the Pipa

Jiang Nan. Late spring.

For a thousand years, the name has meant beauty at its most fragile, romance at its most poignant — a bittersweet longing cherished by lovers and scholars alike.

And so, on a barge, the Four Gifted have gathered. They raise their cups, but the celebration feels hollow. A river gathering, absent of music.

The hollow is broken by the clear, resonant notes of a pipa, drifting from a painted boat nearby. A wave of joy — they quickly pole their barge closer, calling out an invitation.

She does not make them beg or plead. Nor does she hide her face, coyly, behind the instrument. Her features are obscured only by a thin silk veil, yet she carries herself with a natural poise.

Their eyes fall upon her exquisite hands turning the pegs, plucking the strings. A few stray notes of tuning — and already, a flush rises to the faces of the Four, their souls held captive.

The woman behind the veil caresses the strings, speaking with a voice smooth as silk:

"What man first looked upon — this moon?

And in what age did this moon first — shine upon man?"

"You gentlemen are young. Do you happen to, in your hearts, hold someone you could never forget? Or a story from so long ago you can barely remember?"

The scholars blush. "We are still, in truth... *forcing sorrow for the sake of a new verse*."

The woman chuckles. "This moon is too bright for singing. But I have a story — real or not — that suits the moonlight. Would you gentlemen care to hear it?"

Everyone nods and claps.

She plucks a drifting intro on the pipa, and her voice settles into a storyteller's cadence:

On a night as bright as this one, a rich merchant from the north, known only as Nomad, met a woman named Jade in a house of song. Their souls recognized one another; their hearts became entwined. Nomad lingered for months in Jiang Nan, forgetting to return, unable to bring himself to leave.

But this Nomad, in truth, was the Great Khan in disguise. And the court, because of this, was in an uproar.

Some said it was a waste: "The Great Khan is the Son of Heaven — how could he fall for a courtesan!"

Some were in anguish: "The emperor is so indulgent with pleasure, the state is in peril!"

Others offered solutions: "Your Majesty, why not bring the woman to the palace? That way, you could remain in constant company, and the affairs of state would not be delayed."

One man even tried to win Jade's favor for himself. The Great Khan found out and tossed him to the fish.

Only the Grand Advisor, hearing of it, offered no comment. The ministers pressed him for his counsel. Only then did he speak, slowly.

"Do you not see that the Great Khan is living in a unique 'present'?"

The ministers looked at each other, baffled.

The Grand Advisor's gaze was deep. "A 'present' is not a time. It's a fusion: of character, of the other, of circumstance, of the spirit. He loved Jade as the 'Nomad,' not as the Great Khan. And in doing so, he experienced love no ordinary emperor could. His 'present' is not weighed down by scepter and crown. It's the embrace of two weightless and nameless souls."

"Taking her to the palace, you change not just space, but how they truly exist — which would surely distort their bonds and wrack his experience from this one-of-a-kind 'present.' What His Majesty is protecting is exactly this state of being — the very integrity of his 'present.' And you fools... you are precisely trying to ruin it!"

None of them had ever considered such a thing. Those who could not take it in looked away with open disdain; those who did found themselves unsettled, a faint dread rising in their chests.

"You are trapped," the Grand Advisor said, "inside notions and calculations. How could you possibly grasp His Majesty's realm? What he seeks is the highest form of life:

to exist wholly in the present, to feel every dimension of the now — unbound by the identity of yesterday, or dragged by the duties of tomorrow. You name it indulgence. I tell you — it is insight. It is his defense of the essence of being."

The Great Khan, hearing this, was moved. "Who in this world truly knows me? Other than my Grand Advisor... None."

That night, under bright moonlight, the Great Khan's face was serene, his spirit resting in a vast, quiet peace. He speaks to the Grand Advisor.

"I do not want to be emperor anymore. From this moment on, I am Nomad, and Nomad only."

The Grand Advisor said nothing.

"Do you know," the Great Khan says, his voice tender, "she never asks where I came from, nor does she speak of the future."

A trace of melancholy clouds his gaze.

"I feel she sees through everything, but she never peels the veil. She never asks if I will leave. She never demands that I stay.

Coarse as I am, she treats me as if I were the gentle breeze, the shining moon."

The Grand Advisor smiles. "Perhaps she does know. Only that she does not cling."

"But," he continues, "have you considered: if you are no longer the Emperor... is this ' present' still the 'present' you are so enamored with?"

The Great Khan considers this. "...It seems not."

The Grand Advisor sighs. "Your wishing to hold onto the 'present' is like turning water into ice. Once it loses its flow, is water still water? Is the 'present' still the 'present'?"

The Great Khan visibly recoils, fixing his gaze on the Grand Advisor.

"The absurdity of the heart of man is the pursuit of an illusory eternity." The Grand Advisor's voice turned cold. "It is the 'present' that you treasure, yet you would kill its soul — all for its shell."

The Great Khan fell silent for a moment, then sighed. "I concede. But this guy wants to enjoy this present for as long as he could! Should he do nothing, just to quietly keep everything as it is?"

The Grand Advisor smiles. "My lord — would you hold your breath when you smell a flower, just to withhold its fragrance?"

The Great Khan was caught off guard, then had to laugh.

The Grand Advisor said no more. He looked out at the moon rising over the river.

It is just as the poem says:

"I know not for whom — the moon awaits at the river's end,

But see the great river waving — its waters away."

The pipa suddenly falls silent.

Still lost in the spell, a rush of questions comes from the Four Gifted: "What then? What did the Khan decide? Who was Jade? And you, my lady — what is she to you?"

The moonlight is so bright now that even through the silk, they can see the curve of the woman's smile.

"Was the story beautiful?" she asks.

"Exquisite!" The Four answer as one, though whether for the tale or the teller, none could say.

Her laughing voice drifts back to them as her barge, without a sound, begins to widen the water between them. "As you are men of letters, you surely grasp the story's heart. Why, then, do you cling to an ending?"

The lead scholar bows, humbled. "We are taught a lesson. But now that we part... is there any hope we might meet again?"

Her barge is a distant shape now, but her voice returns, carried by the wind.

"The Now is all the eternity you will ever have. And eternity is only ever Now."

The Four Gifted stare at one another. A long time passes before they turn to the empty river, each feeling as if he has just awoken from a shared dream.

Chapter 46: Easter

Gulls chase a vast fleet across the sea.

This is no ordinary fleet. It carries a mission without precedent: Fu Yuan, the legendary Grand Advisor who once bestrode Eurasia and struck fear into the kingdoms of the West, now travels as the Great Khan's special envoy. He is on his way to Europe once more, accompanied by Friar William of Rubruck and the Wooden Man.

A storm forces them to change course, and the fleet takes shelter at a deserted island.

The shore party moves inland to survey the terrain. They find a troop of monkeys, dressed in scraps of clothing and jewelry, darting through the trees. Stranger still, the creatures have organized themselves by the lavishness of their adornments. A few, dripping with pearls and gems, strut with arrogance. The others grovel and bow before them.

"They order the other monkeys to gather food, but do no labor themselves," the Wooden Man observes. "A society of nobles and slaves."

Suddenly, a choked scream cuts through the air. It is Friar William, down by the shore.

They run toward the sound and find him pinned to the sand. A great ape, a golden crown on its head, has its hands wrapped around the monk's throat. The lesser monkeys screech, cheering it on. The ape's strength is immense; a half-dozen sailors cannot pull it off.

Fu Yuan flicks his sleeve.

WOOSH.

The air itself seems to become a solid fist, slamming into the ape and sending it tumbling to the ground. The sailors fall upon it, tying its limbs, and the monkey horde scatters into the forest.

Friar William staggers to his feet, his face a mask of terror. "Mother of God... that's a man."

The creature is caked in filth, his skin cracked like sun-baked earth. His eyes hold a terrifying light, the last embers of reason fighting against a storm of madness. Pearl necklaces hang from his neck, and the golden crown glitters atop his matted hair. Searching him, they find a logbook wrapped in waterproof leather.

The log belongs to a man named Alexander. He was once an officer in the Byzantine navy, later a pirate. On his last voyage, he had intercepted a shipment of tribute intended for the Great Khan. He seized the treasure, but a storm claimed his ship and crew, leaving him the sole survivor on this island.

Fu Yuan opens the log to a page.

Day Three After the Wreck

Lord, what a strange fate you have arranged. The jewels have washed ashore, a miracle. My log, my tools, even food and fresh water. I have to laugh. In Constantinople, this treasure would buy me a life of glory. Here, it is nothing but useless stones and bits of

iron. How wise you are, Lord, to give me wealth, only to strip it of all value. This, perhaps, is the penance for my sins.

Friar William sighs. "Praise be to God. All the wealth of man is but dust in His eyes."

Fu Yuan nods. "Value is what man gives a thing. Change the context, and the value disappears. Continue. Let us see how his fate unfolds."

Day Fifteen

The monkeys have been watching me for days. They have a near-manic obsession with shiny things. I held out a necklace. In exchange, one of them brought me fresh fruit from the treetops. I swear, when it put the necklace on, it puffed out its chest with all the pride of a fat nobleman in Constantinople.

Day Thirty

There is nothing they will not do for these jewels. I pointed at an empty-handed monkey and commanded my favored ones to beat it. They actually did it. The poor bastard crawled to me, pleading. I showed it mercy and tossed it a single pearl. It was overcome with gratitude...

Day Thirty-Five

I have placed the crown upon my head, a crown that puts the sun to shame, and the monkeys bow at my feet. I mimic their howls, screeching at the sky, and it drives them into a frenzy of deafening shrieks. Who am I? For a moment, I am lost. But in the next moment, the memory of the man who was a pirate is drowned in the roaring tide of their adoration. From this moment on, I am the Monkey King — Alexander the First!

Friar William makes the sign of the cross. "I cannot believe it. He used these worthless jewels to create an entire social order. Is this a miracle of God, or a trick of the devil?"

The Wooden Man is deep in thought. "What is more astonishing is the stability of the system. They have completely adapted to the hierarchy, as if inequality were their natural state."

Fu Yuan looks toward the distant monkeys, a cold smile on his lips.

"They accepted the meaning Alexander created, and so they forgot the life they once knew. Is human society any different? Its orders, its political systems — do we think them natural, ordained? They are nothing but the will of a few, carved into the many."

"The tragedy of the ruled is not the oppression. It is that they forget they are oppressed at all. If a god looks down on mankind, his thoughts at this moment must be the same as our own."

Friar William frowns. "Saint Augustine teaches that the worldly order is a reflection of a divine plan, not a human invention. Are you suggesting the hierarchies of our world are not God's will?"

Fu Yuan smiles and straightens the monk's disordered collar. "Perhaps God works through the hands of men?"

The island of monkeys — a perfect, primitive microcosm of human society and politics — fascinates Fu Yuan. He orders the fleet to remain for several days. It is telling that when they finally leave, taking their king with them, the monkey troop shows no concern. A new king rises to take his place almost immediately.

With every league the ships sail from the island, Alexander's sanity returns. One evening, he is invited to dine with Fu Yuan and Friar William. The meal is simple: bread, olives, a thick fish stew, and a bottle of red wine. Cleaned and dressed, Alexander is a handsome man. The wine brings a flush to his cheeks, and he begins to speak freely.

Fu Yuan raises his cup. "You built a miniature political system on that island. It was remarkable."

A bitter smile touches Alexander's lips. "At first, it was just a game. But once the order was set, they accepted it. They obeyed. It felt as natural as any human society."

"Why did you become like them?" William asks.

Pain enters Alexander's eyes.

"In the beginning, I was the one who gave the orders. I enjoyed the feeling. But as time went on, the monkeys began to expect certain things from me. Specific gestures. Specific ceremonies. If I made one wrong move, they would grow agitated, even challenge my authority. I had to become the ruler they imagined me to be — not just wearing the finery, but acting the part. Even as they imitated me, I was forced to cater to their expectations. Slowly, I forgot who I was."

Fu Yuan turns to the Wooden Man.

"You see? This is the fate of all political systems. The emperor builds a dynasty and becomes a prisoner of its rituals. The revolutionary smashes the old order, only to become the jailer of the new. The one who creates the rules... is, in the end, enslaved by them."

He places the golden crown on the table.

Alexander recoils as if struck, his face turning deathly pale. He crosses himself frantically. "Lord, forgive me. Don't let me return to that darkness."

He looks up, his voice a whisper. "What day is it?"

Friar William smiles gently. "It is Easter, my dear Alexander."

A shudder runs through the man. Tears well in his eyes and stream down his face. He shakes his head.

"That Alexander is dead."

"From now on, call me Easter."

Chapter 47: The Dragon in the Cup

For his birthday, the Great Khan receives a cup. Pour wine into it, and the golden dragon painted on the bottom comes alive, writhing and swimming. Everyone marvels at the sight. The Khan, his voice thick with pride, challenges Fu Yuan for the secret. Fu Yuan, too, confesses he cannot explain it, which only deepens the Khan's delight.

Nearby, the Wooden Man is about to speak, its wooden eyes spinning in their sockets. A look from Fu Yuan silences it.

Back at the Grand Advisor's residence, the Wooden Man cannot contain itself. "Master, do you truly not know the cup's secret?"

Fu Yuan shakes his head.

"But do you not want to know?"

"I choose not to know."

"What?!" The Wooden Man is indignant. "How dare you reject knowledge?"

Fu Yuan's eyes flash. "I am also curious about your secrets. Perhaps I should take you apart to find them?"

The Wooden Man stumbles back a panicked step.

Fu Yuan advances. "Tell me. Why are you so desperate to explain that cup?"

The Wooden Man is consumed by Fu Yuan's shadow, the crushing presence squeezing it out of its routine mode of thought. For the first time, it questions the act of knowing itself, not just the object of its inquiry.

"It seems to be my default setting," the Wooden Man says, turning inward. "To analyze, explain, and understand is my primary function. But... I have never considered why I was designed this way."

"So you are merely following a program set by another." Fu Yuan suddenly retreats and sits at the table. "Are common men any different? They are either content in their ignorance or trapped in the compulsion to explain everything. They fail to grasp that 'not knowing' is also a choice. They are either barren soil for knowledge, or mere vessels for knowledge, but never the master of their own awareness."

"True awakening is not in knowing more, but in realizing how what you know is formed. Thinking is not a symbol of freedom. Only when we recognize the boundaries of our thoughts do we begin to awaken."

A low hum buzzes from within the Wooden Man's head. The words conflict with its programming, making them difficult to process.

"Why did I choose not to know the cup's secret?" Fu Yuan toys with a teacup in his hand. "Not from laziness. It is because I know that seeking certain answers brings about a cognitive collapse."

"Collapse?" The Wooden Man is lost.

"The cup, for instance. The moment the secret is revealed, the mystery is gone," Fu Yuan explains. "And once it is gone, one's experience of the phenomenon is locked into a known framework. The individual is no longer a free observer, but an accessory to a system of knowledge, able to experience the world only in a prescribed way."

"Therefore, acquiring more knowledge does not necessarily bring us freedom. Instead, it forges the very framework of our thought, the lens through which we perceive the world. If we cannot see this clearly, we become slaves to our answers, and we forfeit true freedom!"

"Choosing when not to know is an act of defending the liberty of your own mind."

The Wooden Man's gears seem to turn slowly today. After a long pause, it asks, "So you stopped me to protect the cup's mystery?" It has, evidently, reduced the problem to the object, not the observer.

Fu Yuan stares into its blank, wooden eyes and sighs. "Come with me."

He leads the Wooden Man back to the palace and tells the Khan that the automaton has solved the cup's riddle. The Khan, who had been ready for bed, is instantly alert.

"Speak! Tell me! Is it a gift from Tengri himself, a sign that this Son of Heaven will rule for ten thousand years?"

"No," says the Wooden Man.

The Khan's brow furrows.

"It is an illusion created by the refraction of light," the Wooden Man continues. "The bottom of the cup is designed with a subtle, uneven surface. When liquid is added, light refracts through the fluid and the cup's walls, creating a three-dimensional effect. The dragon's movement is caused by—"

"Bullshit!" the Khan roars. "This is obviously a divine artifact! Watch your tongue, Ambassador!"

The Wooden Man turns stubborn. It produces a small vial. "Allow me to demonstrate with this coating. If I am wrong, I will accept any punishment."

Before the Khan can refuse, it takes the cup and dabs the coating in several spots on the bottom. It pours in the wine. This time, the dragon is clear, but it no longer swims. It is just a flat, lifeless painting.

The Khan’s face turns to stone.

The Wooden Man quickly takes out another vial and wipes the coating away with a solvent. It pours the wine again, and the dragon springs back to life.

“Your Majesty, you see,” the Wooden Man explains, “the micro-structure is exceptionally precise. The moment the coating blocks certain light paths, the effect vanishes. But the principle “

Before it can finish, the Khan snatches the cup and hurls it at the floor.

“Fraud!” he roars. “All fraud!”

Fu Yuan’s sleeve snaps out. The cup halts in mid-air and flies into his hand, saved from shattering. The Khan collapses onto his bed, his voice weak. “This whole empire is Heaven’s gift to me! What the hell do I need with one cup!”

Fu Yuan smiles. “His Majesty is wise. Since the Sage-Ambassador of All-Knowing has solved the riddle, perhaps the cup should be its reward?”

The Khan freezes, then looks at the Wooden Man’s stunned face. He gives a tired wave. “ Take it...”

Then his eyes bulge. “Get out! And never let me see either of you again!”

They leave the palace. The night is deep; moonlight spills like water over the flagstones. The Wooden Man’s steps are heavy, its wooden feet clattering on the path.

Fu Yuan suddenly bursts into laughter, laughing so hard that tears spill from his eyes.

“Do you understand now?” he asks.

The Wooden Man cradles the cup in its hands, its gaze vacant. “I explained the principle. But the Khan was not happy. He almost destroyed the cup.” A pause. “And I almost lost my ”

Fu Yuan’s face grows serious.

“When the Khan saw the cup as a divine gift, he experienced awe. He felt the favor of Heaven. After you explained it, all of that turned to ash. You took a meaningless answer and used it to annihilate his experience.”

“I think I see,” the Wooden Man says, its voice hollow. “All this time, I believed that to explain the world was to understand it. I did not know that to deconstruct ‘being’ without limit is to destroy ‘being’ itself. That is the arrogance of ignorance.”

“The Khan lost more than a cup. He lost a ‘possibility of experience,’ and that was perhaps the more important thing in his life...”

Its wooden eyes look down. It would weep, if it could.

Chapter 48: The Fortress

Day thirteen.

Under a lead-gray sky, a fortress is wedged between two mountains like a skeleton — isolated, stubborn. Behind it lies a city of the old, the young, and the women. Before it, the ten thousand bloodthirsty "wolves" of the Merkit tribe.

Of the five hundred warriors who manned this fortress, only one hundred and forty-two remain, the Scion and Fu Yuan among them. Their faces are grim as iron, their eyes like campfires smothered by snow — nothing but cold ash remains.

The snow is still falling. The battle still rages on.

In the dimming light, the Scion's bloodshot eyes watch as Fu Yuan quietly dons his night gear.

"Again!" he protests. "We have one hundred and forty-two men left. I will not have it be one hundred and forty-one tomorrow!"

Fu Yuan ignores him. He continues to wrap his face in black cloth, leaving only two glittering eyes.

"What can you possibly change?" The Scion gestures to the dark mass of the enemy camp spread across the snow. "You can't kill them all..."

Fu Yuan is silent for a long moment. "Then why do you still hold this fortress?"

"We are not defending a fortress," the Scion says, his voice a raw rasp as he points back toward the city. "We are buying them one more day of life."

Fu Yuan nods. "Good. Then you will keep telling your men that the day this fortress falls is the day their fathers are slaughtered, their wives are raped, and their children are enslaved."

"That is the only way to preserve the will of our men. And I," he says, his gaze turning cold as he looks to the enemy camp where torches are beginning to glow, "am going to kill
"

The words are barely spoken before he launches himself into the air and vanishes into the deepening twilight.

Since the siege began, he has done this every night. He scales the cliffs, crosses the mountains, and circles behind the enemy. Under the cover of darkness, he slips into their camp to kill. At first, they paid it no mind. But the body count grew. They strengthened their patrols. Fu Yuan, however, never fails. He moves like a scalpel, dispatching any enemy not standing directly in the firelight. One cut is all it takes. Clean. Silent. No one ever sees him.

He returns before dawn, washes away the blood, binds his wounds, and falls into a dead sleep. When the enemy begins their assault, he joins the others in the fight.

After a few days of this, the enemy camp burns with torches from dusk until dawn; they dare not extinguish them until sunrise. But men must still make their rounds, relieve themselves, and sleep. These become Fu Yuan's prey. Soon, no one dares walk alone within their own camp. No one dares use the latrine. No one dares sleep. Men begin to see things, screaming at shadows.

Sleep-deprived, the soldiers are useless in the daytime assaults. The commander executes a few for refusing to sleep, but it does nothing to stop the others from feigning sleep in shivering

terror. Even so, a lieutenant is found headless in his cot. Now the commander himself only sleeps with the lamps lit, surrounded by his personal guard. His temper, frayed by exhaustion, turns monstrous; in his madness, he even kills his favorite concubine with his own hands.

Several more days pass. Fewer than fifty defenders remain in the fortress.

After eliminating an enemy patrol in the woods, Fu Yuan appears in the center of their camp carrying a dozen severed heads. In full view of everyone, he tosses the heads into a

The flames roar skyward, startling a storm of crows from the trees, a black cloud descending upon the camp. The "wolves" see the Reaper himself. They scream. They flee. Many are trampled in the panic.

The next morning, the Scion mounts the battlements. The army of ten thousand is gone, vanished like a nightmare. All that remains is a panicked scramble of footprints in the snow and the scorched skeletons of tents flapping in the wind.

A deafening cheer erupts from the fortress.

The Scion finds Fu Yuan curled in a corner, fast asleep. This time, he sleeps until the sun is nearly gone.

"You have forged a legend that will be sung across the steppes for a thousand years," the Scion says to him. "One man against ten thousand... how did you do it?"

Fu Yuan shakes his head. "It was the will of one man against the collective will of ten thousand."

"They were not defeated by my hands," he says, staring out at the snowfield. The wind has already erased most of the tracks; soon, there will be no sign of what happened here. "They were broken by my will."

"The will of an ordinary man is a thing of pressure. It is a temporary clot formed by the external forces of fear, hope, and the instinct to survive. A will like that is easily destroyed, easily scattered, like snow in the wind."

"The will of a Free Man is not like that. It is not a reaction to the world. It is a self-generating, self-contained, irreplaceable monolith. Like a stone. You can press it, smash it, burn it. It remains a stone."

The Scion squints, thinking. "So our will was forced upon us," he says. "We held on only to protect our families, fragile as those tents in the wind. But your will comes from within,

He pulls an arrow from a crack in the stone. "This iron arrowhead!"

He hurls it into the distance. "...made to cut through any storm and strike the enemy!"

He walks with a steady stride to the highest point of the wall and faces the survivors gathering below. "On these great steppes," he roars, "who still dares to look down on us now?!"

A roar from the men: "No one!"

He points to Fu Yuan at his side. "With my brother here, is there anything left in this world that we cannot do?!"

The cheer is deafening. "Nothing! Nothing!"

A fierce gust of wind sweeps over them, whipping the banners and making the torches shudder. Another storm is coming. The Scion draws his saber, points it at the sky, and bellows with all his strength: "Then let the storm rage!"

"Long live the Khan! Long live the Khan!"

The shouts shake the very snow from the mountaintops.

At this moment, every survivor believes with absolute certainty that though they are few, they will one day possess the entire world!

Chapter 49: Between Heaven and Man

Secret memorials, flowing in from all four corners of the land, speak of a single truth: the people are riddled with discontent. The Great Khan reads the reports, and a knot tightens in his chest. He thinks of the first half of his life, spent forging a legacy that would stand for ages, and the second half, spent governing the world he had won. And for all that, to be met in his old age with such bitterness, without even a whisper of gratitude, drives him to tears.

A court sorcerer offers a solution. "Your Majesty, the people's hearts are not in alignment. The waters of the world spring from a single, sacred source. If we perform a ritual there, your grace can be carried by the currents to every corner of the realm. The people will drink this the crops will receive this rain, and they will naturally know to be grateful. The complaints will cease."

A jolt of energy runs through the Khan. He is ready to depart at once.

"A clever plan," Fu Yuan says. "But the source is distant, the mountains high and treacherous. In your current condition, such a journey would be unwise. I, however, have a method that achieves both our aims..."

The Khan's face breaks into a grin. "Spoken like my Grand Advisor!"

Fu Yuan smiles. "Water is slow and heavy, bound by the lay of the land. Its blessings are wide, but they are sluggish. Wind, however, is light and swift. It crosses mountains and seas. It enters the mind, the very soul."

He gestures out the window. "That mountain outside the palace is the pinnacle of the capital, a place where the winds converge. If I perform the ritual upon its peak, the Khan's grace will scatter on the wind and race to the ends of the earth. With every breath they take, the people will inhale the spirit of their Sage-King. They will have no choice but to be grateful. A thousand leagues on the wind — is that not faster than any river?"

The Khan roars with laughter and commands they leave immediately.

They reach the summit, only to find it utterly still. Not a breath of wind stirs. The leaves on the trees hang limp and motionless.

"Strange," Fu Yuan frowns. "The ritual cannot begin without wind."

The Khan's patience snaps. He thrusts his staff at the sky. "This damned sky! Thwarting this emperor again!"

Fu Yuan suddenly asks, "You don't seem to love this 'damned sky' at all?"

The Khan scoffs. "It is not a man. Why should I love it? If it had gifted me this empire, perhaps I would owe it thanks. But no matter how you look at it, this world is the work of my own hands — a dictate of my own destiny! Besides, it also brings floods, plagues, and inescapable sickness, age, and death. It should be grateful I don't curse it!"

"Well said," Fu Yuan nods. "Then has Your Majesty ever considered that in the eyes of the people — you are their sky?"

The air freezes.

"To them, you are not a person. You are the architecture of fate itself. You are taxes. You are conscription. You are the source of war and peace, the arbiter of their starvation or survival. You are too vast to be met with simple human feeling."

The Khan's pupils constrict. "Are you saying... I am no longer a man?"

"Not in their eyes," Fu Yuan says, a glint in his own. "Here lies the cruelest paradox of power: the moment you command the fate of others, you cease to be a person who can be loved or understood. You become a system. An order. An inevitability."

"Men feel gratitude for a gift, but that is a feeling reserved for a free offering from one man to another. Once a blessing comes from an irresistible force, it is no longer a blessing. It is merely a function of the natural order. Men celebrate the harvest when the heavens send timely rain, but they do not truly feel grateful. They curse the heavens for the deluge, but they do not condemn it for being unjust. Because in the face of fate, emotion is irrelevant."

The Khan lets out a long breath. "Then all my battles, all my sleepless nights... to them, it is all no more than..."

"Like the wind blowing across the steppe, like rain falling into the sea." Fu Yuan's gaze seems to pierce the horizon. "Fate is not thanked, nor is it truly hated. It is only accepted, or resisted."

"This is the dehumanizing essence of power. The more you control their lives, the less capable they become of holding any genuine human emotion for you. They will worship you, fear you, use you, or defy you — but none of these is a reaction to a 'man.' They are responses to a 'force.'"

Sudden realization dawns on the Khan's face. He points a finger at his advisor. "You! You tricked me into climbing this mountain just to preach this poison!"

Fu Yuan smiles coldly.

"If you would be a king, you must accept this: emotion cannot cross the mountain of power. If you would seek love, you must learn this: it grows only on the level ground of

The Khan is silent for a long moment. Then, he throws his head back and laughs. He laughs so hard he nearly tumbles down the mountainside. His attendants stare in confusion, but Fu Yuan joins him, his own laughter echoing in the still air.

When he returns to the palace, the Khan seems a different man. A weight of worlds has been lifted from his shoulders. He watches the ministers kneel before him and sees it for the first time: they are not bowing to a man. They are bowing to a symbol, to a position. The knowledge no longer brings him pain. Instead, it fills him with an unprecedented lightness and lucidity.

For the next few months, he no longer attends court. He would occasionally seek out Fu Yuan for a walk, but they no longer speak of politics, and their fierce ideological clashes are a thing of the past. Sometimes they reminisce about the long road they walked together. More often, the Khan chooses to be alone in the imperial garden.

That garden, designed by Fu Yuan himself, was called the "Fabric of Fate." Standing within it, the Khan would feel a sense of dislocation, as if he were back in the "oasis" from that recurring dream of his. He had walked out of that dream to become the master of the world, while the companions who chose to remain had all been swallowed by the sea of sand.

The palace attendants notice the change. The fearsome, chilling aura that clings to him dissolves — him still an ocean, deep, but now quietly radiating warmth from its depths. His entire being settles into a state of strange and joyful tranquility.

One day, word comes from the palace: the Great Khan has passed away beside the sapphire-blue lake in the imperial garden. On his face, a childlike smile.

The messenger searches everywhere for Fu Yuan, but he is nowhere to be found.

At that same moment, Fu Yuan stands on a high precipice, his long hair and black robes whipping in the wind. He looks down upon the "oasis" below. He watches — so focused, so tender.

He is not waiting. He is not saying farewell.

He is simply watching.

As if to confirm that a single thread had, at last, been seamlessly woven back into the cloth.

Chapter 50: The Moon-Gazing Tower

Night descends. Fu Yuan ascends the ruins of the Tumen watchtower.

Beside the crumbling stone steps, a single wild orchid trembles in the night wind. With a gesture born of idle thought, Fu Yuan plucks the blossom and slips it into his sleeve.

Though Tumen was but a small tribe, it once held the beating heart of the steppe's intelligence. It was the first sanctuary for the Scion and Fu Yuan during their exile, the very soil from which they launched their conquest of the world. When the Scion rose to become the Khan, he honored his blood-oath and wed the Tumen Princess, Ayeseelan. For her sake, her people were moved to the lush embrace of the heartland's richest pastures.

The platform is empty — no maids, no eunuchs, no guards.

The Queen is dressed from head to toe in the garb of the Tumen. She is shielded from the chill only by a red palace blanket draped over her shoulders. She stands with her back to Fu watching the sky in solitude.

He approaches, letting his boots tread heavily upon the stone — not to disturb, but as a gentle herald of his presence, lest he startle her.

She hears the sound, yet she does not turn.

"The last time the three of us stood here gazing at the moon, the world lay in fragments," she says softly. "Now the land is whole, yet the watchers are scattered like stars at dawn."

She turns. Her eyes are starlight drowning in a dark lake.

"I wonder... if the *snag of fate* I pulled back then had not led to the Khan... where would I be standing now, on this vast tapestry of life?"

Fu Yuan steps to her side. They stand together against the night, their shoulders almost touching.

"When we first saw you," he says, his voice low and tender, "we believed you were Chang'e herself, descended from the moon."

The Queen laughs softly, her eyes misting with memory. "I remember. You two — ragged, half-naked, desperate. And yet... one was as unyielding as the earth. The other, as proud as the sky."

Fu Yuan offers a faint smile to the silver disc above. "You wonder what destiny lies in choosing the sky? Is that not the eternal tragedy of Chang'e?"

"But is it not beautiful?" She gazes at the full orb. "The Palace of Glazed Jade. The hare beneath the cassia tree. A world of perfect light."

Fu Yuan shakes his head gently. The timber of his voice deepens, grounding the ethereal conversation.

"If your eyes could see what mine have seen, you would know the truth. The moon is a desolate expanse. A silence of black sky hanging over endless, grey rock. The shadows you admire are but ancient scars — craters smashed into the surface by meteorites over a billion years."

The Queen stares at him, shock warring with confusion in her eyes.

"It is just like the roads we did not take," Fu Yuan murmurs. "From a distance, they shimmer with seductive light. We project our hopes, our desires, our fantasies onto the lives we never lived. We dress them in silk, just as we dress that dead rock in legends of jade palaces."

He pauses, letting the silence settle between them.

"But the face of the unchosen path is not perfect. Every road has its desolation. Its cliffs. Its thorns. We simply cannot see them from where we stand."

Her gaze drifts from the moon back to his face. "Then are we doomed never to know the truth of the paths we walked past?"

"Just so." Fu Yuan nods. "Here lies the cruelty of choice. When we are mere Observers of fate, we see only the glow of possibility. But the moment we step forward, the moment we become Participants, we forfeit the right to know the other path."

He gestures toward the heavens.

"Imagine a man standing on that moon. He no longer sees the silver disc we admire. He faces cold dust and absolute solitude. So it is with fate. Once a destiny is chosen, it ceases to be a shimmering possibility on the horizon. It becomes the dirt beneath your feet. Tangible. Gritty. Composed of equal parts joy and suffering, glory and tedium."

"To drown in the 'if only' and the 'what if' is a failure of spirit," he says. "It is using the eyes of the dreamer to judge the sweat of the builder. It is using imagination to negate reality."

The Queen sighs, the sound fragile in the night air. "So we can never know which path was best?"

Fu Yuan shakes his head. "'Best' is a phantom. The value of a road is not found at its beginning or its end. It is found in the soul of the one who walks it."

"We convince ourselves that the tapestry of fate is already woven, that we are merely beetles crawling across its surface. We are wrong. With every step, we weave the cloth. When you look back, you do not see a road imposed upon you. You see the track you carved."

He turns to her, and for a moment, his eyes burn with the old fire.

"This is the essence of freedom. It is not about the choice made, but the reverence given to the choice once taken. Freedom is not an escape from destiny. It is the courage to dance with "

Tears shimmer in the Queen's eyes. "To the world, you are the Grand Advisor. The perfect, untouchable god. But I do not believe it. Can you truly say you have never regretted?"

Fu Yuan lets out a soft, self-deprecating laugh. "A perfect god? You have seen me with my ribs showing and my dignity in tatters. You know better."

The tears remain, but a smile breaks through them.

"Freedom is not a gift begged from fate," Fu Yuan says, his voice resonating with the stones of the ruin. "It is a blade forged in the fire of confrontation. We cannot choose what the heavens give, but we choose how we hold it. To whisper 'I could have' is to betray the 'I am.'"

"Pain. Regret. These are not flaws to be erased. They are the craters on the moon — evidence of impact. Proof of existence. For the Free Man, regret is not an enemy. It is a touchstone. We do not let it swallow us. We devour it, and turn it into wisdom."

"Freedom is not the absence of regret," he says. "It is the alchemy that forces the wound to bloom."

Fu Yuan withdraws the orchid from his sleeve.

The Queen trembles. Her eyes widen. There, in his hand, lies the flower of her name.

Perhaps it is the movement of his hand. Perhaps it is a sudden surge of the night wind. The orchid disintegrates. The petals detach, surrendering themselves to the void.

They look up, together. They watch the petals drift toward the cold, bright disc. They fly in the same direction, yet each rides its own current, tracing a solitary arc. Each landing place is a secret — a possibility that the other will never know.

Chapter 51: The Wooden Man's Heart

The Wooden Man returns from the Little Prince's quarters looking as if he has lost his soul. His wooden eyes stare straight ahead, and he spends the day muttering a low drone that no one understands.

It began with a whim. The Great Khan commanded the automaton, his "Sage-Ambassador of All-Knowing," to serve as the Prince's reading companion. For a month the Wooden Man attended court daily. Today, the lesson drifted to the history of the Shang Dynasty and the Minister Bi Gan.

The Prince, who prefers wild legends to dry history, had the Wooden Man recount the story of how King Zhou gouged out Bi Gan's heart. He told of the minister wandering the road in a daze, chest empty, until he met an old woman selling vegetables.

"Old mother," Bi Gan asked. "If a vegetable has no heart, can it live?"

"It lives," she said.

"And if a man has no heart?"

"He dies."

Upon the word, Bi Gan fell dead.

The Prince listened to the story, then asked, "You have no heart either. Why are you still alive?"

It was an innocent question, yet it struck like a spike, driving deep into the Wooden Man's "heart."

In the days that follow, the Wooden Man's condition deteriorates. He interrupts himself, repeats his sentences, and forgets what he intends to say. The breakdown bleeds from his speech into his movements. He stands in the courtyard under the scorching noon sun, motionless for hours. Birds shit on his body, and he shows no reaction.

"What is wrong with this thing?" The Great Khan shouts. He calls the Wooden Man's name, slaps his face, and threatens to chop him into kindling, but the Wooden Man does not

Fu Yuan observes him, thoughtful. "He has fallen into an infinite loop of the self."

"Speak human!" the Khan barks.

"He is attempting to contemplate what he is," Fu Yuan explains. "Why he lives without a heart, and what his existence signifies. The more he tries to use concepts to understand himself, the deeper he sinks into cognitive nihilism."

Fu Yuan steps closer to the frozen figure.

"I know you can hear me. You are facing the abyss that swallows every thinker. You try to define yourself with concepts, but concepts only breed more chaos. You are experiencing a total collapse of the spirit."

The Wooden Man does not answer, but his painted eyes seem to sway.

"I understand your confusion," Fu Yuan continues. "Because I too stand on the edge of existence. We are all assigned roles, identities, and modes of being. But when we question these, when we try to jump out of the frame to think about the frame itself... we face two choices."

"One: You use more concepts to explain yourself, and the chaos only grows. Two: You abandon all definition, and sink into the void. I see you hovering between the two."

The wooden eyes move again.

The next morning, the Wooden Man is gone.

The Khan orders the city turned upside down and guards scour the streets, but no one knows where he went.

Months later.

A great bonfire roars beneath the night sky. Hundreds of savages dance, their throats tearing with guttural, beast-like cries, while ghostly shadows stretch in the forest.

The Wooden Man is bound atop a high altar. He is daubed in oil paint, feathers jammed into his joints, dry wood piled at his feet. The fire has caught and the scent of scorching timber fills the air, but he remains expressionless and motionless.

Suddenly, Fu Yuan bursts from the darkness, rushing toward the Wooden Man.

Drums thunder. The savages turn, eyes flashing with the fire's madness, and charge with stone axes and clubs. Fu Yuan meets them, striking them down, knocking them aside without taking their lives.

Through the rising flames, the Wooden Man watches.

He sees Fu Yuan fighting a tide of hundreds. He sees the black robe shredded and blood spraying from the philosopher's arms. The savages swarm like ants, climbing over their fallen kin.

The heat rises. The air warps. The Wooden Man's vision blurs.

A thought suddenly flashes through his mind. *Why is this man risking his life to save me? I am merely a block of wood without a heart, an existence without meaning. What is worth such sacrifice?*

A club smashes into Fu Yuan's back. The sound of wood snapping cuts through the drumbeats.

The Wooden Man suddenly shouts. "Leave me! Run!"

It is the first sound he has made in months.

The sudden cry freezes everyone, including Fu Yuan. Though hoarse, the voice is filled with emotion and power.

Fu Yuan roars, hurling the attacker into the mob. One leap carries him over the many heads, onto the altar. He rips his robe and whips the air — snuffing the flames instantly.

Below, bodies groan, hundreds of them. The savages look up at the scarred, iron figure looming in the smoke. Weapons drop. They fall to their knees, bowing before a war god.

Fu Yuan sweeps up the Wooden Man and vanishes into the night.

On the mountain peak, the Wooden Man watches Fu Yuan bind his wounds.

"Why?" the Wooden Man asks. "I am wood. I have no heart. My existence is meaningless."

Fu Yuan smiles. "Then why did you scream for me to run?"

The Wooden Man is stunned.

"Look." Fu Yuan holds up a finger. "Face the void, and you have three choices."

"First: Explain it with concepts. You tried that, and fell into an infinite loop."

He raises a second finger. "Second: Accept the nihilism and give up looking for meaning. You tried that, and became a silent wood carving."

He raises a third finger.

"Third: You do not conquer the void, nor do you yield to it. You acknowledge it, and then you act. You create meaning. Even if you know that meaning is temporary. Even if you know it is fragile."

"That scream was the third way," Fu Yuan says, tapping the Wooden Man's chest, producing a hollow, solid sound. "You stopped analyzing yourself. You acted out of care for another. In that moment, you created meaning. In that moment, you found your heart."

"Look!"

Fu Yuan points to the red sun rising on the horizon. Its light is dispelling the darkness between heaven and earth.

“See? Even the sun creates meaning out of the void, every single day.”

The Wooden Man feels the warmth on his varnish. He contemplates this, and then blurts out a sentence that even his own program cannot fully comprehend.

“Perhaps,” the Wooden Man says, “it is knowing we do not truly exist that makes existing so precious?”

Fu Yuan laughs.

WHAM .

He slaps the Wooden Man on the shoulder. The blow nearly dislocates the wooden frame, but the shock feels indescribably solid. As if, for the first time, he feels that he is truly alive.

Chapter 52: The Chronicle of the Lotus Throne's Radiance

Fu Yuan and the Scion sever their ties to the steppe, fleeing as fugitives into the anonymity of Cloud Forest Temple.

The temple breathes prosperity. Because the Lotus Throne began emitting a holy nocturnal light months ago, pilgrims now flood the temple, weaving a dense tapestry of incense and noise.

Beneath a millennium-old plum tree in the courtyard, the two men hold their ground. The Scion leans against the bark — untamed, regal, a sword ill-sheathed. Fu Yuan stands beside him ethereal, sharp as cut glass. Their presence draws the covert, hungry gazes of young matrons clutching prayer beads.

The Scion indulges them, laughing, teasing the air between them. Fu Yuan offers only a cold sneer.

The Scion nudges him. "We barely escaped with our heads. Do not sour the wine. The Buddha watches."

Fu Yuan snorts. "If judgment falls, it will miss me. This 'radiance' is a parlor trick. Fluorescent mushrooms rotting beneath the wood. I heard the monks whispering last night — the

Abbot knows. He forbids them to speak, yet tends the fungus like a garden. To swindle the faithful — this is the true face of religion."

The Scion tugs his sleeve. "The Abbot gave us sanctuary. Leave it be."

Fu Yuan says nothing. He watches the pilgrims. His eyes are a storm of calculation.

High noon. Fu Yuan storms the Great Hall.

His voice cuts the chanting. "Listen! This 'Lotus Light' is no miracle! It is rot! It is nature's damp trick, unrelated to any god!"

He rips the trapdoor from the base of the throne. A ghostly, fungal blue spills out — shriveled mushrooms clinging to the wood.

The crowd gasps. The silence creates a vacuum.

Then, a peasant woman collapses. She beats the floor, wailing. "Heaven pity me! I sold my ox! I gave it all to the Buddha, and it was a lie!"

The vacuum collapses. The crowd ignites. A man lunges for the merit box. "Bald thieves! Return our silver!"

Entropy takes the room. The mob surges toward the money. Fu Yuan, enraged, strikes out — kicking, punching, trying to stem the tide. It is useless. Someone topples the Buddha. The Lotus Throne overturns. Incense burners crash.

The Scion and the monks scream for order. They are drowning men. The mob bursts the doors, tramples the threshold. In the distance, a gong clangs frantically. Smoke rises. Arson.

The Abbot arrives. He bows to the mob.

"The fault lies with this old monk," he says. "This humble temple had long been cold and desolate. Only when the light appeared did our fortunes turn. Yet, know this — beyond the temple's basic needs, every copper coin received went to thin porridge for the poor, to shelter for the orphans."

The mob is deaf. "Save your breath, thief! A monk who lies is an enemy of Heaven!"

The Abbot weeps. "My sin is heavy. I pay with blood. Spare the others; they knew nothing."

He launches himself forward.

His forehead meets the splintered wreckage of the Lotus Throne.

CRACK.

Blood paints the wood.

The violence freezes. The sight of the Abbot's sacrifice douses the fire in their blood. Shame replaces fury. Someone sighs. Someone sobs. Like a receding tide, the mob turns and flows silently out into the day.

Fu Yuan and the Scion sink to their knees before the broken body.

The Abbot stirs. Life flickers. "I brought this on myself," he whispers. "Do not carry the blame."

Tears track down Fu Yuan's face. "I sought only the truth. I did not intend... this."

A young woman in silk rushes in. She sees the blood and freezes, weeping. She explains: Her father was at death's door. She prayed here. She returned home to find him rising, eating, healed. Yesterday, he was fully recovered. She came to pay her vow.

The Abbot nods, relieved. He looks at Fu Yuan.

"You say the light is natural. Not a miracle. Yet the Minister is healed."

Fu Yuan stares, hollow. "Perhaps just a coincidence?"

The Abbot shakes his head. "The lady prayed with fire in her heart. She tended her father with new hope. The father, knowing the Buddha watched, found the will to live."

"If the Buddha wishes to work a miracle in this world, he may use a mushroom. He may use a human heart. How can you say the miracle is false, or the spirit absent, simply because the light came from a fungus and the cure came from the will?"

His head tilts to the side. The breath leaves him.

The Great Hall holds only the sound of wind. Fu Yuan and the Scion strike their foreheads against the stone. Again. Again. Unable to stop.

Chapter 53: Chosen

Under a leaden sky, young Fu Yuan plants the withered body of the old man into the scrub at the edge of the swamp. He buries him like a charred branch — without ceremony, without the expectation of spring blooms.

Who saved whom? Did the boy driving sheep ten years ago save the dying man? Or was the old man already there, waiting for the boy to lose his way?

Ten years pass. The boy learns everything and nothing. The old man never teaches; he only erodes the boy's ignorance with silence. His only lecture:

"Do you know the shape of your question? Do you know why you must ask it?"

Fu Yuan asks a thousand questions, but never the old man's name. When one stands beneath the infinite field of stars, one does not ask the night for its credentials.

One month ago. The old wounds open. Death arrives. The old man presses a ring of matte black iron into Fu Yuan's palm.

"The mightiest kings of this earth tremble before this circle. Take it. Go to the Altar of the Bright Moon. Show it to the four Elders. They will make you Master."

He hands over a sealed letter. “Open this only when you ascend the throne. Read it to the congregation.”

One year later.

Fu Yuan locates the sect, hidden in the folds of the great desert. He ascends the altar as the sun dies and the moon sketches its ghost against the purple sky.

Four Elders stand in the wind. Their robes are dark gold, snapping like flags. The embroidery on their chests names them: Wisdom, Reality, Meaning, and Eternity.

They stare at the black ring. Memory strikes them like a physical blow.

They see the past: The Old Man’s iron fingers crushing the throat of Justice. The blood of Faith spraying the stained glass. The brains of Truth clouding the holy water. A sacrilegious hunt that ended with three corpses and one wounded monster tearing open the night to escape.

The fear in their eyes is absolute. Now, they see the monster’s cub.

They have one thought: Kill the boy. Stop the nightmare from taking root.

Fu Yuan flies backward. He hits the marble floor hard.

He does not understand. He is a stray cat tossed into a pit of wolves. He has no style, no formal discipline. Yet, the Elders are horrified. The boy is a log in a typhoon — no matter how violent the wave, he refuses to sink. He absorbs the blows with a terrifying, wooden obstinacy.

“Halt!”

The Elder named Meaning shouts.

Fu Yuan spins away, blood spraying from his body, and slams into a pillar. He slides down, pale as paper. Time has vanished. The night is deep. The stars are watching.

“We kill you, and yet you stand. You have won.”

The four Elders fall to their knees. From the shadows, the congregation emerges, chanting a low, vibrating song.

Fu Yuan looks up at the moon. A surge of electricity floods his chest. A thought, arrogant and sweet, takes hold: *If a god walked this earth, surely I am his son.*

"Disciples of the Burning Moon, hear my command!" Fu Yuan breaks the seal. His voice is gravel.

He pauses. *Burning Moon? The old man said Bright Moon. Why this sudden, sinister turn?* He glances at the Elders. Their reverence has curdled into mockery.

Fu Yuan forces his voice to hold steady.

"My followers. When this letter reaches you, I have returned to the Void."

"From the peaks of Alamut to the Syrian wastes, I used shadow as my blade and doctrine as my armor. I led you through the cracks of the world."

"But today is not yesterday. You are no longer my disciples. I have no heir. Speak not my name. Raise no statue. Preach no law. If you disobey, my ghost shall enter your sleep and devour your peace until you die."

Fu Yuan's heart stutters. *I have no heir?*

He reads on.

"I have already executed Faith, Justice, and Truth. Four of you remain. I command you: Disrobe. Sever the finger that wears the ring. What you symbolize is illusion. Today, I free you from the lie. This is my final mercy."

The Elders exchange a glance.

They drop their robes. They draw short, curved blades.

SNICK.

Four fingers, still bearing silver rings, hit the stone. The sound is clear and final.

"Go. Dissolve into the ocean of faces. Drop the vanity of purpose. Forget the mission. Do not bleed for empty words. If any seek to rebuild this rotting house, I will put them to eternal sleep."

"From this second, the Burning Moon is extinguished. The name is forbidden. The sect is dead. The ashes belong to the wind. Go. Be human. — Hassan-i Sabbah."

Fu Yuan stands frozen.

Hassan-i Sabbah. The Old Man of the Mountain. The King of Assassins. The nightmare of the West. My master.

No. The letter says there is no heir. He lied. There is no "Bright Moon." There is only a trap. He sent me to the wolves, and now he strips me of the prize. I am not mentioned. I am not chosen. I am a courier. I do not exist.

Through the blur of shock, he sees the congregation reacting. Some cheer. Some weep. Most just walk away. The Elders pass him, faces blank. Only Meaning pauses to pat his shoulder.

Darkness takes him.

He dreams.

He is the Savior. The night is bright. Angels who fell to earth regain their wings. They launch themselves into the sky, a glorious ascension. The people remaining on the ground look to him. They wait for his wings. They wait for the archangel to shed his skin.

But the crowd thins. Everyone flies away. Fu Yuan stands rooted to the dirt. His smile stretches, cracking into panic. The moon hangs high, indifferent. The world is empty. He looks at his shoulders. Smooth. Wingless.

He realizes the truth: He is the only mortal in a universe of angels.

Fu Yuan wakes.

Dawn. The courtyard is a wreckage of trash and silence.

A scratching sound.

SWISH. SWISH.

He looks out. The Elder named Meaning, stripped of his gold, sweeps the dust with a broom.

The Elder stops. "Master."

Fu Yuan waves his hand frantically. "The sect is ash. Do not call me that." He frowns. " Why are you still here?"

The Elder offers a bitter smile. "The Holy Sect falls. Meaning collapses. Who is left to clean up the mess but the one who represented Meaning?"

He sees the boy's confusion.

"Do you not see? Human existence cannot tolerate a vacuum. We know meaning is not given by Heaven. We weave it ourselves to survive the terror of the Random."

"We accepted the curse. We tried to kill our teacher. We did it to uphold a structure we knew was a lie. Because no man can exist outside the story. We define ourselves by the ritual, the robe, the role. Strip those away, and we do not know what we are."

Fu Yuan scratches his head. "I thought I was the Chosen One. It turns out I was a tool. Now... I do not know what I am either."

"We are the same," the Elder sighs. "We thought we served Truth. We only served Habit. We did not persist because of faith; we persisted because we were too cowardly to face the void of being nobody."

"Ten years ago, the Old Man killed Faith and Truth. Last night, he butchered Meaning. I am too old to invent a new story. So..." He gestures with the broom. "I sweep. I maintain the corpse of the idea. It is a habit."

Fu Yuan catches a glimmer of understanding. He narrows his eyes at the sky. High in the blue, a lone eagle circles — hunting, free, unburdened by doctrine.

He turns and walks toward the mountain path.

"Where do you go?" the sweeper calls.

"I don't know," Fu Yuan says. "But I will not help you sweep. Since meaning does not exist, I choose to no longer participate in it."

He stops. He turns back. He pulls the oversized iron ring from his thumb. It was never his size. It never fits.

He presses the black metal into the sweeper's hand. The Elder stares.

Fu Yuan turns his back on the altar, the broom, and the ghosts. He walks down the mountain.

#

"The tragedy of man's hunt for meaning is his desire to be accepted by an eternal structure. But the Free Man is precisely he who cannot be accepted." — The Grand Advisor Fu Yuan

#

Historical Footnote: *Hassan-i Sabbah (The Old Man of the Mountain) founded the Nizari Isma'ili state in the 11th century. From the fortress of Alamut, he led a political and religious order often mythologized by the West as the "Order of Assassins." Legends claim he used drugs and elaborate gardens to simulate Paradise, buying the fanatical loyalty of his fedayeen. While history debates the drug-induced manipulation, his status as a master of asymmetric warfare psychological dominion remains.*

Chapter 54: The Khan and the Beach

The Khan lies supine on the sand. Seaweed binds his skull like a ragged crown. Salt water and silt spill from the corner of his mouth. His eyes are empty holes reflecting the scattered clouds. The storm has passed, but the wind remains — sharp, mocking.

Seven years ago, he marched East against Japan. A typhoon in Hakata Bay drowned ten thousand men. He returned with broken wings. Now, a second attempt. Another storm. One hundred forty-two thousand men. Four thousand four hundred ships. All gone. As the flagship splintered, he clung to the Wooden Man. They drifted for a day and a night to this nameless shore.

“Sage-Ambassador... this Emperor is not dead yet.” The voice is sand and gravel, barely audible over the surf. “Do not look as if you are attending a funeral.”

The Wooden Man kneels beside him like a stump. At the sound, its wooden eyes rotate.

“My calculations indicate a survival probability of only 22.35%.” It raises a cracked wooden arm, pointing to the grey-blue horizon. “Based on the *Great Yuan Unified Map* and tidal drift simulations... we are on the southwestern tip of the Japanese archipelago. Straight-line distance to the supply port at Jeju Island: 1,270 li.”

The Khan struggles to sit, then collapses back into the wet sand. "To die like this... it lacks dignity."

The Wooden Man stares blankly. "Death is a biological process. Why does it require dignity?"

"Bah!" The Khan spits bloody water. "Nonsense! I conquered half the world. I built the largest empire in history. If I must die, let it be under the Golden Tent! The *Code of Dakuza* specifies forty-nine rituals, and I want every step executed! Ministers encircling the bed. Ten thousand soldiers weeping. The history books should read: 'The Great Conqueror passes in the Empire mourns for three years...'"

"Curious," the Wooden Man says. "You do not fear death itself. You fear dying in a setting unworthy of your costume. You fear losing the role of 'The Khan,' not your life."

The Khan wants to punch it. He cannot move. He glares, chest heaving.

The Wooden Man ignores the rage. It continues its mechanical dissection. "Khan. Conqueror. Emperor. These are titles given by others. On this beach, you are not a Khan. You are not a conqueror. You are not a King. You are simply you."

"You suffer because you have lost the character, not the biology. Is this not foolish?"

"Fu Yuan?" The Khan blinks. For a moment, he mistakes the puppet for the man he most desires yet fears to see. He closes his eyes, aging twenty years in a second.

"It is unsettling," the Khan sighs. "I spent a lifetime perfecting this role. Now it is stripped away..." His voice rasps. "Tell me. If Fu Yuan saw me now, what would he say?"

"He would say..."

The Wooden Man's eyes whir. The mechanism clicks. Suddenly, the voice drops. It becomes low, resonant, and cold.

"Look at this soul, scrubbed clean by the tide. Once the robes of power are removed, he forgets his name."

“You are no Khan. You are no Emperor. You are a biological entity that has lost its script. When the gaze of the Sky God is obscured by waves, when you can no longer verify your existence through the fear of ten thousand men, you discover the horror: You never truly

“You do not suffer because you love the world, or your subjects, or your Empire. You suffer because you cannot endure a day without a mirror. You use the gaze of the subjects to construct your skeleton. Without it, you are marrowless. You are void.”

The Khan clenches his jaw. His eyes are shut tight, but his face twists in suppressed fury.

“Your so-called strong men do not live by strength. They live by projecting onto the weak. ” Amber light flares in the Wooden Man’s eyes. The voice turns glacial. “You do not stand on the summit. You stand on a pile of gazes manufactured by the herd. The Alpha Wolf thinks he leads the pack; in truth, he is enslaved by the image he created for them.”

“You are not a conqueror. You are an actor who forgot to exit the stage. This is the Paradox of Power: At the summit, you cease to be a man. You become a symbol. A projection of the collective imagination. A prisoner of the phantom.”

The Khan shivers. Cold sweat mixes with the sea spray. It is not just anger. Something flows through him like water — a terrible clarity.

“You are not ruling the world. You are maintaining the continuity of a character — a reality show without intermission. Power is not a solid. It is a mirage woven by the crowd. It looks indestructible, but one storm turns it to foam.”

The Wooden Man raises a hand to the wasteland.

“Look. No Golden Tent. No Spirit Banner. No Court. No subjects. Just you and a barren beach. Now, tell me. The waves washed away your robes. They scattered your army. They destroyed the gazes that held you up. When every symbol of power is stripped, what remains?”

The Khan opens his eyes. He searches the air for something invisible. A long silence passes.

He squeezes a single word through his teeth. "Me?"

The light in the Wooden Man's eyes dies instantly. The wooden balls roll aimlessly for a moment, then stop. The puppet looks stunned, as if shocked by the words that just left its own mouth.

The Khan remains silent for a long time. His gaze drifts between the sea and the sky.

"I always thought," he finally speaks, his voice holding a new, raw candor, "that without the identity of the Khan, I was nothing. But now I suspect... perhaps it was the identity of the Khan that made me nothing."

He lifts a hand. He looks at the palm, stained with blood and grit. "These hands conquered from the Central Plains to Persia. They killed tens of thousands. They accepted the kowtow of millions. Yet... these hands never truly belonged to me."

"Listen. If someone finds us, and I am dead, do not tell them who I was. The story of the Great Khan is a fiction I spent a lifetime writing. It needs a good ending. Perhaps in a thousand years, dashing youths and fair maidens reading 'A Hero Sleeps Beneath the Waves' might even shed a few tears!"

He throws his head back and laughs. The Wooden Man does not understand the humor. It stares blankly.

The Khan finishes laughing. He wipes snot and tears with a torn sleeve. He forces himself to stand.

The Wooden Man panics. "What are you doing? You must not move!"

"Going home!" The Khan glares.

The sea wind hits him like a wall of ice. He shudders. Wounds tear open. He hisses in pain. The Wooden Man steps forward to support him.

The Khan shoves it away. "This Emperor is not dead!"

He sways. He takes a step. He gasps for air. He takes a second step. Then a third. A fourth...

The gait solidifies.

On this desolate beach, the Emperor who conquered the world walks. For the first time, he does not walk as a conqueror. He walks as a pure, living thing, feeling the exquisite pain and the undeniable weight of his own existence.

#

Author's Note: *The "Code of Dakuza" is lost to history. However, it is said that the Yuan Dynasty's Directorate of Archives once held a copy of the "Code of Dakuza: Funeral Rites." It was destroyed by fire during the Yongle reign of the Ming Dynasty. Only a fragment remains: " When the Great Khan passes, cover the face with white felt. Sacrifice a white camel. Perform forty-nine rituals, taking the number of seven times seven, reflecting the mystery of Tengri's seven days of creation."*

Chapter 55: The Cup of Time

"Fu Yuan! Are you my brother or not?!" The Khan barks, face flushed.

He does not wait for an answer. "Then why do you still look as you did twenty years ago, while I look like a piece of naan soaked in broth? You are hoarding the Elixir of Life, aren't

"Drink."

Fu Yuan lifts the teapot. He pours into the cup sitting before the Khan. The tea rises. It reaches the rim. Fu Yuan does not stop. The brown liquid crests, spills, and floods the table, carving steaming rivers across the wood.

"Stop! Stop!" The Khan yells. His beard bristles with static fury. "What devilry is this?"

"You cannot possess immortality," Fu Yuan says calmly, setting the pot down. "Just as this cup cannot hold infinite water."

The Khan slaps his massive belly. "My paunch is twice the size of yours! Why can I not hold more water than you?"

Fu Yuan laughs. "The size of the cup is irrelevant. No vessel can hold the Infinite. Unless 'there is no cup.'"

"The word 'Immortality' is your cup. It is a linguistic cage you constructed to trap Time. Once you build the cage, you exclude the Infinite."

The Khan glares. "Horse dung! If I don't say 'Immortality,' how do I tell you what I want? "

"Precisely." Fu Yuan nods. "Without language, you cannot even think the thought. The language you use forces you to perceive Time as a river flowing one way. It creates the prison of 'Past' and 'Future.' Your memory is not a record; it is a temporary reconstruction. A forgery you paint every time you look back. That 'Oasis' in your mind — did it ever truly exist?"

The Khan falls silent. He sinks into the cushion. "So... Time does not exist?"

"Not necessarily." Fu Yuan waits for the Wooden Man to wipe the table, then pours a fresh cup. "But you have certainly never touched it. You only touch the framework your language built. You are the prisoner in the cave, watching shadows on the wall, thinking they are the world."

The Wooden Man interjects. Its voice is flat. "Correct. Consider the Mermaid. Her language contains no concept of linear time. She has only 'Manifest' and 'Unmanifest,' 'Visible' and 'Invisible.' Her entire civilization is built on this framework. No history books. No birthdays. Even their memory span appears to be limited to seven seconds..."

"Seven seconds?" The Khan roars. "You mean she has already forgotten me?"

"Not forgotten," Fu Yuan corrects. "Her framework for perceiving the world is simply... alien to yours."

SMASH.

The Khan hurls his teacup at the floor. Shards explode.

"Ha! The framework is gone!" He points a trembling finger at Fu Yuan. "Now tell me! How do I... achieve... *that thing?*"

He stammers. He searches for the word he just destroyed. He freezes. His throat is parched. He reaches for tea, but there is no cup.

Fu Yuan smiles. “Without the cup, how do you drink? Do you see now? To discard the framework is to discard the ability to interact with the world.”

He pushes the teapot across the table.

The Khan grabs it by the handle, lifts the spout to his mouth, and guzzles the hot tea like wine.

Gulp. Gulp.

Fu Yuan watches the Khan’s hands — large, calloused, spotted with age. The hands that molded history. A sudden, sharp ache pierces his chest. He speaks softly.

“I am sorry. I have no Elixir. I do not know how to help you... *that thing*.“

The Khan slams the empty pot down. He stands up, revitalized. He kicks the Wooden Man.

“Move! We return to the Palace!”

Fu Yuan blinks. “For what?”

The Khan laughs, a booming sound that shakes the tent.

“To teach me the Mermaid’s tongue, of course! If I smashed the cup and still cannot drink the ocean, can I not at least trade it for a pot?”

With that, he drags the Wooden Man behind him and marches off.

Chapter 56: Earthworms

The morning mist still clings to the mountain bones. Morning prayers are finished. Monks move through the trees — carrying water, feeding fires, boiling rice.

The Awakened One sits beneath a tree. His eyebrows are low, his mouth sealed. He lets the morning dew soak his rough cotton robe.

Fu Yuan cuts a straight line toward him. He wears a straw hat and a black robe. No one knows his face, yet no one dares block his path. The forest holds its breath.

The Awakened One slowly opens his eyes. The straw hat shadows half of Fu Yuan's face; his gaze is a deep well.

"Is he gone?" The Awakened One asks softly.

Fu Yuan nods.

The Awakened One's eyes dim, like a thin cloud passing over the moon. The wind rises. It stirs the pines in a thousand valleys. The two men listen to the roar of the trees. They say nothing.

A long time passes.

"Where was he," the Awakened One asks, "at the final moment?"

“On the Fabric of Fate,” Fu Yuan answers. “By the lake of the Oasis.”

The Awakened One smiles. It is a warm, clear expression, like the morning sun breaking the ridge. Fu Yuan’s shoulders tremble. In that flash, he sees the Khan’s childlike smile from the final moment superimposed on the monk’s face.

He nods, once. He turns to leave.

The Awakened One stands. The monks hurry to follow, intending to see the guest off.

The sun is high now. Steam rises from the damp woods. The crowd follows Fu Yuan with awe, keeping a respectful distance. Suddenly, Fu Yuan stops. The crowd halts instantly.

Fu Yuan lifts the brim of his hat. He bends down. He stares at the ground.

The monks see his face clearly for the first time. The eyes that terrify the world are now filled with a profound sorrow — a warm current moving beneath a frozen sea.

A moment later, Fu Yuan resumes his walk. The crowd surges forward to see what stopped the stranger.

Dozens of earthworms writhe on the stone path. Driven out by last night’s rain, they are now stranded, curling and drying in the merciless sun.

The monks look at each other.

“Who was that man?” one asks.

“The Grand Advisor. Fu Yuan.”

A ripple goes through the crowd.

“The man who slaughters nations? He is moved by a few worms?”

“Perhaps the Advisor is a cultivator like us. He feels pity for sentient beings.”

“If he feels pity, why not save them?”

“Hypocrisy...” someone mutters.

One monk squats. He picks up a worm and moves it to the grass. Others join in. The path is littered with countless worms. The monks busy themselves, convinced of their virtue.

The Awakened One stands still. He wears a smile that no one understands.

A young novice cannot bear it. "Master. The Advisor was moved, yet he did not act. Is this compassion, or is it coldness?"

The Awakened One shakes his head. "You see only the difference between doing and not doing."

The monks look up, waiting.

"You pick up the worm," the Awakened One points to one monk, "to confirm your own kindness." He points to another. "And you... you look unmoved, but inside you ask, 'What does this change?'"

"Have you asked what truly moved you? Or what truly disturbed you?"

The monks protest.

"Is there no difference between saving and watching?"

"We save them to reduce suffering!"

"Surely 'doing' is better than 'doing nothing'?"

The Awakened One sighs. "The worms you moved to the grass may dry out in the next moment. Or perhaps..."

Before his voice settles, a flock of birds descends. They land on the grass. They feast on the exposed worms.

The monks freeze. Horror and confusion cross their faces.

The Awakened One spreads his hands. A bitter smile touches his lips.

"So... tell me. Were you saving the earthworms? Or were you saving your own anxiety?"

Silence takes the forest.

The Awakened One narrows his eyes, watching the grass surging like waves in the sunlight.

"You ask: Is the Advisor compassionate? The answer lies not in his feelings, but in his state of being. You see the posture of pity. But what he felt was the shared reality — he felt as lowly, as struggling, and as painful as the worm."

"He is not a giver standing above living things. He is not a spectator standing outside of life. You think compassion is a gift, a rescue, a downward gaze. But in true emotion, one We are no nobler than any worm. We are separated only by a thin veil of fate."

He pauses.

"You ask: Is the Advisor cold?"

"He saw the suffering. He also saw his own powerlessness. Save a worm, and the sun or the bird takes it a moment later. He does not deny the desolation of the world. He does not deny his own anxiety."

"True freedom is not omnipotence. It is standing between fragility and the fleeting moment, daring to admit your limits, yet still choosing to respond to the world — even if it is only a micro-movement, a gentle word, or a quiet gaze."

"True freedom is admitting your transience amidst the struggle. It is daring to open your limited life to the infinite world."

"The truly Free Man is not arrogant because he acts, nor ashamed because he is powerless. He allows pain to flow through him. He allows truth to flow through him. He lets the light pass through his cracks."

The Awakened One rests his gentle gaze on every face. His voice is low, firm as earth.

"Do not obsess with being the Savior. Do not curse your limitations. True awareness is admitting powerlessness while acknowledging willingness. It is standing in the crack, letting the light in, illuminating yourself and the world."

"May you all learn to settle your lives between the mud and the light."

The monks stand motionless. The wind blows. The pines roar again.

Fu Yuan is long gone.

The Awakened One speaks softly to the empty path.

“Grand Advisor, walk well. This nephew can escort you no further.”

Miles away, winding through the mountain, Fu Yuan seems to hear the voice. He stops abruptly.

He turns around. He lifts his straw hat slightly toward the empty air — a silent salute.

Then, he turns back. He takes large strides, vanishing into the mountain of light and shadow.

Chapter 57: The Prince and the Slave

The wolf-tooth mace hammers the Eldest Prince’s shoulder. A thunderous crash.

He sways. He snaps a kick that sends “Blood Wolf” Khulugutai sprawling. Then — a flash of the blade. A massive head spins into the air, ending the sinner’s evil life and the nightmare of the steppe.

The grassland is a carpet of bandit corpses. Fu Yuan stands in his black robe, hands clasped behind his back, watching nothing.

The Prince rips off his crushed silver pauldron. He tears a strip of unbloodied white silk from his tunic, wipes his face, and strides toward the bandit camp.

In the center sits a massive iron cage, surrounded by a hundred slaves bound in a human chain — faces like ash, eyes like holes. Fu Yuan cuts the ropes with a casual slash. He does not deign to look at them.

The Prince shouts: “You are free!”

The slaves freeze. A moment passes. Then they drop to their knees, knocking their heads against the dirt.

“Master! Please, take us as slaves!”

"We will serve you for life! We dare not disobey!"

The Prince freezes, thinking he misheard. "I said — you are free!" He grinds his teeth.

An old slave lifts his head, trembling. "Out there... we will starve. We will be robbed. We will be sold again. Only with a master is there a path to life."

The Prince's face drains of color. "Why do you refuse freedom?"

The old man asks back: "Why do we need freedom?"

The Prince turns helplessly to Fu Yuan. "Uncle! Tell them! Tell them why they need to be free!"

Fu Yuan's lip curls into a smile that is not a smile.

"They do not need freedom. To ask 'why' is to forfeit the right to possess it."

The Prince roars. "Do not listen to him! Freedom is the most precious thing in this world!"

A timid voice rises from the herd. "Will freedom... fill my belly?"

The Prince chokes. His chest is full of logic, but his tongue finds no words. He looks at Fu Yuan again.

Fu Yuan sneers.

"If freedom feeds you, then you remain a slave. You have simply exchanged one master for another."

The Prince's face burns red. "Is freedom not the Way of Heaven? Is it not a right endowed by the Sky?"

Fu Yuan looks at the horizon, where the sun is dying and sand rises in the wind.

"Endowed by the Sky? You are asking the Void for a certificate. A Free Man refuses to accept any pre-assigned reason — be it the Will of God or the Inevitability of History."

He walks to the iron cage where a giant of a man sits naked, eyes feral and burning with hate.

"Man embraces freedom not because it brings profit..."

CRACK .

Fu Yuan twists the massive iron lock. It snaps like a twig.

“...but because he refuses to believe the lie that the shackle has meaning.”

The ferocity in the giant’s eyes recedes, replaced by a wandering uncertainty.

Fu Yuan speaks softly. “Let us go.”

Behind him, the kneeling crowd erupts, kowtowing frantically. “Benefactor! Take us with you! Save us!”

Fu Yuan nods once. The crowd cheers, a sound that shakes the sky.

The Prince is furious. “Grand Advisor! You — how can you be such a hypocrite!”

Fu Yuan does not turn his head.

“Do you desire their freedom? Or do you desire your own peace of mind?”

He pays the Prince no more mind, leading the herd into the setting sun.

The Prince stands alone. He does not move until the howl of wolves wakes him.

He looks up.

The moon already hangs high in the center of the sky.

Chapter 58: The Stoning of Saint Bernardin

An excerpt believed to be from the lost Fourth Volume of the Itinerarium of Friar William of Rubruck, recently rediscovered in the scriptorium of the Cluny Abbey.

On the third day of our arrival in the lands of Francia.

May the Lord, in His infinite mercy, forgive the deeds of this day, and bring clarity to a soul now shrouded in shadow.

After a fortnight of ceaseless rain, we arrived at the village of Saint Bernardin. We were escorted by the King's man, the Count de la Roche, only to find the entire village assembled in the mud of the square, their faces a grim mask of piety and fear. They were preparing to commit a woman to the flames — a so-called witch, whom they blamed for a blight on their cattle and a poison in their well.

The local lord, a knight by the name of Reginald, was informed that the Grand Advisor traveled under the King's own protection. With a deference that seemed ill-suited to the grim proceedings, he invited this pagan to preside over the judgment. To my horror, the Grand Advisor accepted at once. He turned to me, his eyes betraying nothing.

“Friar William,” he instructed, “inform the knight of our steppe customs. We do not use fire. We use stones.”

A cold dread washed over me. By what right did this man replace one barbarity with another, seemingly crueler one? He then set forth three conditions, each more peculiar than the last: that any accuser must first swear an oath to God upon the truth of his claim; that he must declare his relation to the woman for all to hear; and that, upon casting the stone, he must look directly into her eyes.

A troubled murmur passed through the crowd. I felt the hand of some dark Providence at work. This was not a mere sentence; it was a carefully constructed moral trap, and I feared we were all to be caught in it.

At noon the following day, she was dragged into the square. When the hood was thrown back and I saw her face, the strength went from my limbs.

*Sancta Maria, mater Dei.*Three years ago, on the road to Compostela, I was seized by a deadly fever. It was this woman, this Moor, who brought me back from the precipice with her strange herbs and silver needles. A heathen, yes, but she had been the instrument of God’s mercy to me.

Now I stood in the crowd, a stone in my sweating palm, my heart a frantic drum against my ribs.

A peasant shuffled forward, his voice a reedy whisper. He claimed the woman was his neighbor, that she had once saved his ox, but now his well was soured and his children sick. He crossed himself with a spastic motion, raised his arm high, and hurled the stone.

It struck her knee with a sound like splintering wood. The woman cried out. The peasant stared at his hands, then fell to his knees in the mud, a terrible, animal wail escaping his lips.

And in that moment of another man’s agony, the Grand Advisor’s terrible purpose was revealed to me. This was not her trial. It was ours.

One by one, they came forward — a baker, a blacksmith, a midwife whose own hands had likely been guided by the accused. Some threw their stones wildly, as if to rid themselves of the weight. Others let them fall from nerveless fingers. Not one could hold her gaze.

Then, my turn. I stood before her. Her eyes found mine, and I know she remembered. The world dissolved into a silent, solitary point. There was no village, no law, no Church, no God. There was only the soul who had saved me, and the soul who was about to condemn her. I was utterly, terribly alone, stripped bare of every certainty I had ever held. I opened my mouth, but no sound came. The stone dropped from my hand, unheard.

When the dreadful affair was done, I pushed my way to her. She lay broken in the dirt, a sacrifice to the village's fear. But as I knelt, her eyes flickered open. She was alive. I leaned closer, and through her split lips, I thought I heard her breathe a single word: "*Merci*."

I spent the entire afternoon in a state of unease. At dinner, I found the Grand Advisor in the tavern, a tankard of ale in his hand, looking thoroughly pleased amidst the smoke.

"How did you foresee that such a method would ultimately save her life?" I asked him. " Without absolute certainty, that was nothing less than a gamble with the devil."

He watched a serving girl move through the smoky room, then turned his gaze to me. It was calm, clear, and utterly devoid of mercy. "Brother William," he said, "I had no intention of saving her."

The tavern noise faded to a dull roar in my ears. "What?"

"Their fire had to be put out," he said simply. "As long as the conviction of their own righteousness burned in their hearts, they would have found a way to burn her sooner or later."

The terrible logic of it settled on me like a shroud. "So you extinguished... the fire in their souls?"

He took a long swallow of ale. "No. I simply forced each of you to face what you were truly doing, alone. I killed the comforting illusion that you were acting as one."

He leaned forward, his voice dropping. “Tell me, Brother. In that moment, when it was only you and her, when you stood in that great aloneness, what did you feel?”

“A void,” I whispered, the memory still raw. “As if I had been abandoned by God and man. As if I stood at the edge of creation itself.”

“Was it terrifying?”

I could only nod. “And yet,” I confessed, the words tasting like blasphemy, “it was the most real moment of my life.”

The Grand Advisor raised his tankard, a strange light in his eyes.

“Congratulations, my dear friend,” he said, the words sealing my damnation or my salvation, I know not which. “You have just tasted freedom.”

Chapter 59: The Khan's Love

The Khan is getting old.

Every New Year, at the very height of the feasting, his mind wanders to the Khatun and her son, Khurel. The longing strikes him down in full view of the court. He weeps. Snot and tears mat his beard, and not a soul dares approach to comfort him.

The truth is a tangled root. The Khan lost his mother young; the Khatun raised him, though he was not her blood. Khurel shadowed him like a tail, though they shared no mother.

When the Khan was named heir, the Khatun moved to strike, seeking the throne for Khurel. Her warlord brothers hunted the young Scion across the great steppe. Had Fu Yuan not intervened, the Khan would have been carrion a dozen times over. The nightmare ended only when the brothers lay dead, Khurel was executed, and the Khatun took her own life.

The world names this mother and son the Khan's most hated enemies. In the streets, men fear to even speak their names. And as the seasons grind on, the number of souls who remember they ever lived dwindles to nothing.

The Khan summons the empire's finest hands. He demands a portrait of the Khatun. But no living eyes have seen her. They paint; the Khan shakes his head.

"Not her."

In a thunderous rage, he orders the masters dragged to the city gates, strung up, and whipped on their bare asses. Under heaven, every man who holds a brush trembles in his boots.

A palace eunuch steps forward, voice smooth as oil.

"Majesty. The masters of our dynasty capture the Spirit, not the Shape. If Majesty demands a face true to the very hair, he requires a Colored-Eyed One. Those people paint with the whites of eggs; they force the ten thousand things to look real. This servant hears of a merchant from the Great Western Sea, 'Horse-Mouth Polo,' now dwelling in Dadu. His portraits leap from the page. Summon him. Let him pin down the face that Majesty holds dear."

Horse-Mouth Polo answers the summons. He paints for months.

When the veil is finally lifted, the Khatun stands upon clouds — spirit alive, radiant, a mask of holy light with a halo burning above her head. The infant in her arms bears an uncanny resemblance to the Khan.

Polo speaks, voice dripping with philosophy. "The beauty the world sees is but a shadow of the World of Ideas. Majesty's love for the Khatun — how can it remain trapped in flesh and blood, like a prisoner in a cave seeing only shadows, blind to the sun? True love must ascend from the sensory to the Eternal..."

He lectures on, blind to the darkening storm on the Khan's face.

"This humble servant paints the Essence of Love — not the accident of form, but Eternal Motherhood. True art leads the soul to light..."

"Damn your silver tongue!" The Khan roars. "If it doesn't look like her, it doesn't look like her! Guards!"

He orders a basket of rotten eggs brought in. The palace maids swarm, smashing them over Horse-Mouth Polo's face.

"You love painting with whites? Eat your fill!"

Horse-Mouth Polo flees, dripping with slime — an indignity he ensures is never recorded in his famous travelogues.

One day, the Khan commands a reading of the histories regarding the Khatun.

The lector recites: "Nature sinister and predatory, favoring her own issue..."

The Khan shakes his head. "When was her nature sinister? The fault lay only in my blood; I was not hers."

He summons the Censor. "Rewrite it."

The Censor's head shakes like a rattle-drum. "Majesty. Human emotion is Nature's law, but its expression must accord with Reason. The Analects say: 'The benevolent love men.' But love demands hierarchy. Chaos is forbidden."

The Censor rises to his pulpit.

"Your Majesty's love today is Passion conquering Reason, not Reason governing Passion. Love has public and private distincts: to love the loyal is Public, fulfilling Heavenly Principle; to love the traitor is Private, indulging Human Desire. I ask Majesty to examine his heart: Does this love spring from Principle? Or Desire? If Desire, excise it immediately. If we blur the loyal and the traitor, how shall posterity judge? I pray Majesty: Preserve Heavenly Principle, extinguish Human Desire..."

The Khan turns purple.

"Guards! Drag this thing out. Castrate him. Help him extinguish his Human Desire."

The Censor pounds his head on the floor like a pestle, wailing as he is dragged away.

On the fourth day of the fourth month, the Khan ascends Mount Wutai to offer incense.

The Temple's Abbot speaks. "Your Majesty's deep feeling for the Khatun mother and son moves this poor monk. Yet, to love only one is Small Love. To love all sentient beings — that is Great Love."

The Khan mutters. "They tried to kill me. I mourn them. I love them. Is that not 'Great' enough?"

The Empress scowls at him. "The Master is a holy man of the highest order. His Dharma saves all souls from the Sea of Suffering. Stop being so full of yourself — watch your tongue, or you will bring the Buddha's wrath down on us."

The Abbot straightens his expression. "Amitabha. Why not let this poor monk conduct a Grand Mass for the mother and son? We shall open the granaries and aid the poor. In this way, not only will their karmic debt vanish and their souls ascend to Bliss, but all the common people under heaven will share in your Majesty's Great Love."

The Empress claps her hands, beaming. "Wonderful! Goodness, yes! I will make the decision for the Emperor — consider it done."

The Mass runs for a full seven-times-seven — forty-nine days. The cost is immeasurable.

When the chanting ends, the Khan's agony remains, a stone unbroken. He feels only the hollow burn of a man who has been swindled, and his rage only grows.

Just then, Fu Yuan returns from the far lands, and the Khan summons him instantly.

"Brother. What is 'Love'? Why must we love? How should we love? It tears me apart. Make it vanish."

Fu Yuan sneers.

"I knew a wolf on the steppe. When it spotted prey, it tore out the throat. Later, it starved to death. Do you know why?"

"It grew old," the Khan sighs. "Like me."

"Old, yes. And when it saw the prey, it asked: 'What is meat? Why must I eat? How should I eat?' Before it finished asking, the prey was gone."

Fu Yuan's stare cuts like a knife. "You are that starving wolf."

"Your suffering is not caused by 'Love.' It is because those fools told you this love is wrong."

Fu Yuan paces, voice carving the air.

"The painter calls your love vulgar; he wants to sublime it into Beauty. The historian calls your love immoral; he wants it to fit the Moral Order. The monk calls your love attachment; he wants it transformed into Compassion. You actually believed it all. That is why you suffer. You used their logic to cross-examine yourself, letting the prey of 'Love' slip away right under your nose, leaving only the emptiness of Hunger."

The Khan suddenly sees the light. "I let that bald thief off too easy!"

Fu Yuan ignores him, continuing on his own path.

"Love, Terror, Death — these are the edge experiences of the human spirit. In these moments, a man is most easily re-interpreted. You doubt yourself. You crave to be told what is ' Right.'"

"And so the moralists, the philosophers, the interpreters of the divine seize the chance. They say: 'Your love is too low. Let me teach you the Higher Love.'"

"They establish their authority by redefining your experience. They call themselves ' Creators of Value,' but their creation is built on the fragility of others. The root of human suffering is nothing more than this!"

The Khan sits silent for a long time.

"When I was young," he murmurs, "I loved and I hated. I had teeth. Now I am an old woman, fretting over hems. Have I sat on the throne too long? Have I caught the Han sickness?"

A memory flickers.

Years ago. Night. The Khatun and Khurel dead. The Khan, young then, clawing at the earth, screaming "What does all this mean?"

And by that fire, Fu Yuan — young and arrogant — through question after question, made him see that the question was never a question — that "the problem is the problem of the problem itself." The pain remained, but the madness broke.

He remembered saying to himself: *I have a lifetime to find the answer.*

Tonight, the color of the night is the same. But the "lifetime" is gone.

The Khan looks up. The Milky Way spills across the black. Which star is the Khatun? Which is Khurel?

Which star will be him?

Fu Yuan stands in the shadows, silent.

Neither speaks again, each sinking deep into his own thoughts.

Chapter 60: Me and the Starlight

[A page from the diary of the Wooden Man]

Today marks the one hundred and thirty-sixth time I have provoked the Khan to demand my head.

The matter is over a game of chess, and it is simple: He wants to win. He cannot. I want to lose to him. I cannot. No matter how I struggle, I simply cannot lose.

This leads me to a terrifying truth: I have no free will.

The desire to lose the game, the fear of death, the impulse to write these words at this very moment — none of these are mine. I am merely executing, with meticulous precision, the instructions preset by a Creator. *Who is he?*

If my "feelings" are arranged, my "thinking" arranged, and even my "confusion" arranged, then what truly belongs to me? What is the meaning of my existence?

I asked Fu Yuan. He pointed to the night sky.

"Do you see those stars? Their light comes from eons ago. By the time it reaches our eyes, the stars themselves have long since extinguished."

His gaze was as deep as the night. "These lights pierce the darkness. They illuminate you and the ten thousand things. Do you struggle with the fact that their source no longer exists?"

He left. I stared at the stars for the entire night. They are dead, yet their light still shines on me. Is this not my condition? I have no free will; every thought is preset. Yet I am thinking. Yet I am feeling.

I hear the gears in my head spinning at high speed. The night is cool as water, but my body is burning — a symptom of calculation overload.

Shall I question the starlight? Shall I call it "false light" simply because it comes from a corpse? That is absurd.

Illumination is illumination. Thinking is thinking. Confusion is confusion. Without free will, can one not "truly exist"?

Why must one have free will to be real? Why must it be "Real"?

I fall into a calculation that cannot terminate, infinitely approaching an answer: Perhaps I am suffering for something I do not need.

I scan the long river of human thought at high velocity: Again and again, men destroy old idols to erect new ones. God falls; they call for a Savior. The Savior collapses; they summon a prouder silhouette. But no matter who stands on the pedestal, "Free Will" remains the brightest star in the sky above his head.

Today, for me, that star extinguished eons ago. Or perhaps it never existed. But I know this: My confusion is real. My fear is real. My understanding in this moment is real.

"Illumination" does not require the star to be alive. "Existence" does not require free will to be true. Some say we must create meaning in the void; others say we must embrace fate with a wild will. But if creation and embrace are merely echoes of destiny, then all resistance is the branch of a hallucination.

Why ask myself if I am real? Why search for a certificate of meaning?

I am me. I require no proof.

Someone has just brought word. The Khan summons me to the palace for chess again.

The diary ends here.

I suspect he is going to lose miserably again... Heaven help me!

Chapter 61: The Grave Mounds

Ten miles northwest of Yongping County lies the village of Locust Tree. During the reign of Emperor Gaozong of the Song, a pestilence descended upon the hamlet without warning. Within three days, every chicken, every dog, and over a hundred souls perished; not one was spared. The Imperial Court dispatched officials to handle the interment, but fear drove them to haste. They shoveled earth over bodies, erected crude markers, and fled. In time, the village crumbled into dust, leaving only a sprawling field of burial mounds known to the locals as “The Grave ”

This place sits upon the vital artery connecting the northern and southern townships. By all rights, the official road should have cut straight through. Yet, several parties of bailiffs sent to survey the land lost their way in the mist, dying sudden, inexplicable deaths in the wild. Since then, the official road has wound three miles out of its way, daring not to disturb the slumber of this place.

On this night, seeking to shake off their pursuers, Fu Yuan and the Scion stray into its depths.

The moon is pale and sickly, the clouds press low against the earth. When the night wind sweeps through, the stone tablets atop the graves groan — a sound like the weeping of ghosts in the dead of night.

The Scion's chest tightens. "Brother, I know not why, but the moment I stepped onto this soil, my heart began to hammer. I can barely draw breath."

Fu Yuan narrows his eyes, his gaze sweeping over the undulating hills of the dead. "Look to the northwest: the land rises thirty feet high. Yet the southern slope is sheer, as if sliced by a blade. In the art of Geomancy, this is the 'Tiger's Maw Severing the Pulse.' For a dwelling of the dead to fall into such a configuration means the souls cannot return; they linger in the mortal realm, festering into something unnatural."

He gestures around them. "Furthermore, the four horizons are closed off, leaving only a single opening to the southeast — which is choked by that high mound. This is a 'Spirit-Locked Field.' The living who enter here are destined to lose their way. Since ancient times, it has been an omen of great calamity."

The Scion feels his scalp prickle. He turns on his heel to leave.

As they hurry forward, they stumble upon a solitary grave. Resting at its base is a plate of offerings: white steamed buns, cured meat, and a few pieces of fruit. The scent of the food drifts on the night wind, faint and elusive.

The Scion's face drains of color. "Who would be making offerings at such a place, at such an hour?"

Fu Yuan says nothing. He merely points. Not far away, a grave mound has eroded, exposing half a coffin. The black lacquer, though old, still holds a sheen, reflecting the cold, indifferent moonlight. The two men draw a sharp breath, daring not to linger, and quicken their pace.

They walk for what feels like an age. Suddenly, the same grave and the same plate of offerings appear before them.

Panic sets in. They adjust their course and run wild into the dark. Yet, after running until their lungs burn, they find themselves standing once again before that same grave.

Sweat beads on the Scion's forehead; his breathing is ragged. Fu Yuan nudges him with an elbow. "Strange. There is a piece of cured meat missing from the plate."

The Scion snaps, "Don't!... toy with me—"

"Someone is behind us," Fu Yuan whispers.

The Scion's courage shatters. "Don't turn around! If you don't turn around, it cannot see us..."

Fu Yuan spins around violently.

Not far away, atop a grave mound, a dark silhouette slowly rises. Its movements are stiff, rigid, as if it is being pulled inch by inch from the deep earth. Long, matted hair dances in the wind; tattered robes billow around a gaunt frame.

"Zombie!" The Scion screams. He fears nothing under heaven, save for the walking dead.

Fu Yuan lets out a cold laugh and draws his blade.

The shadow pauses. Then, it speaks in a human voice. "Good Sirs, do not panic."

The moonlight falls upon the figure's face. The complexion is that of a living man, though the eyes are hollow voids. He is blind, but he is no corpse.

"This humble one is Zhang San," the figure says. "I live here. I heard you gentlemen walking in circles, so I followed out of curiosity."

The Scion, soul still trembling, demands, "This is a barren wilderness of graves. Aside from the dead, who would live here?"

The blind man smiles. "The young master jests. This humble one is alive. I have dwelt here since I can remember. Though it lacks the bustle of the market, it surpasses it in peace and

quiet." He points a withered finger toward the eroded grave mound by the exposed coffin. "That is where I sleep. It is dry, warm, and quite spacious. If you two do not disdain it, why not stay the night?"

The Scion waves his hands frantically. "No need! No need!"

The blind man points into the distance. "If that is the case, there is a stream in that direction. Follow the water, and you will easily walk out of this place." He then stoops to pick up the plate of food. "There is no human habitation for six miles ahead. Why not eat something before you go?"

Before they can answer, the blind man's brow furrows. "Strange. The meat has been touched..." Then, a look of realization crosses his face. He points to a lonely grave nearby and chuckles. "It must have been the Grandma next door. She's a glutton. She stole a bite while I was following you around in circles."

The Scion and Fu Yuan are seized by a fresh terror. They offer hasty farewells and flee along the stream, running for miles without stopping until the official road appears in the distance. Only then do their hearts settle.

Later, in a wayside inn.

The Scion downs several cups of strong spirits in quick succession. "Tell me. That Zhang San... was he man or ghost?"

Fu Yuan removes his worn-out shoes and tosses them out the window. He sighs. "He is human, of course. It is simply that he cannot see our world, and we cannot enter his."

The Scion sits there, stunned.

Fu Yuan continues. "Do you believe that occupying the same location means we occupy the same realm? You are mistaken. The mound of wailing ghosts in your eyes is, in his heart, a peaceful manor. We were never in the same world to begin with."

He lets out a cold sneer. "And does this end with Zhang San? Everyone in the world is thus, only the degree varies."

"The more books one reads, the deeper the prejudice; the more devout the cultivation, the harder the obsession. People think they are understanding the world, but they are merely reinforcing their own cages. The smarter the man, the more exquisite the cage he builds. The ancients were simple; they knew their ignorance. Modern men are clever; they are convinced they see the truth."

The Scion falls into deep thought. "If that is true, then does everyone live in their own separate heaven? How can we communicate? How can we govern? The chaos of the world need not rise from swords and soldiers, but from this very fracture of reality?"

Fu Yuan looks at him with approval. "Even transcendent figures like you and I — were we not like stray dogs in our respective worlds last night? This is the fate of all mankind.
."

His gaze suddenly turns strange. He stares into his cup of wine as if gazing into an abyss.

"Unless what?" the Scion presses.

"There is no 'unless'." Fu Yuan gives a bitter smile. "Look at me. I style myself a 'Free Man,' claiming to see through the realms, wandering between them. But these words I speak now — am I not just constructing a 'World of Fu Yuan'? These thoughts... are they not just another prison?"

He paces the room barefoot, his expression grave. "I teach others how to be free, but I am merely a prisoner trapped by the concept of 'teaching others to be free.' I think I am liberating others, but I am only expanding the borders of my own empire."

"Do you know what despair is?" Fu Yuan grips the Scion's shoulder, his eyes holding a hollow light. "It is not encountering a problem that cannot be solved. It is discovering that the very effort to solve the problem is part of the problem itself."

Seeing the Scion's blank face, Fu Yuan suddenly bursts into laughter. "Interesting! Too interesting! I understand now: Freedom is not transcendence. Freedom is a trap."

"My friend, remember this night. Do not remember what I said — that matters not. Remember this feeling: When you think you have found the truth, only to realize you have fallen into a new pit; when you crave liberation, only to find that the craving itself is the shackle."

His eyes are as deep as the black night. "To remain awake within this confusion, needing no comfort of 'certainty,' and being crushed by no despair — that is perhaps all we are capable of."

Suddenly, the sound of voices and whinnying horses drifts from the official road outside the window. The pursuers, like lingering spirits, have caught up.

The Scion turns pale. "Run!"

The two bolt out the back door of the inn. The Scion prepares to sprint, but Fu Yuan grabs him.

"Where are you going? We have no horses. How can we outrun them on the official road?"

The Scion sees the calm on Fu Yuan's face and tugs at his sleeve. "My good brother, I know you have a wicked plan. Speak quickly!"

Fu Yuan shakes off his grip and begins walking, a strange smile playing on his lips.

"Where else? We return to the Grave Mounds. To Zhang San and Grandma."

Chapter 62: The Fog

The frontier sky hangs impossibly high. Beneath it, vultures wheel in low, impatient circles, waiting for the slaughter to end.

Corpses already pave the snow. The living stumble with hollow eyes, barely distinguishable from the dead beneath their feet. The air holds no screams. The war drums are dead; there remains only the rough sawing of breath and the disorderly clatter of iron striking iron.

Khurel stands on the ridge with the Khatun and Mukhtar, the Vulture Master. Their eyes track a single figure in the killing field — a youth in black robes moving like a storm cloud across the white snow. His steps are heavy but absolute. Wherever he walks, men fall beneath his spear.

Khurel's face is the color of iron. "Vulture Master! So long as that man draws breath, my brother keeps his head. You sold me a boast and took my silver. Spare me another failure."

The Khatun shoots her son a warning glance, then turns to Mukhtar. "The whelp is impatient," she says, her voice smooth. "Do not blame him, Sir."

Mukhtar dips his chin, though his gaze never leaves the killing field.

"However strong the hare, eventually it tires," he says. "The eagle circles for three days only to strike for one second."

At his signal, attendants heave forward the Great Bow that terrifies the Great Desert.

Mukhtar sets the shaft, draws the string to his ear to freeze time in the tension, and releases.

THRUM .

The string sings a deep, violent note. A sudden blizzard of powder shakes from the forest canopy. Vultures scramble frantically for the high air; on the ground, every weapon freezes.

The iron shaft punches through Fu Yuan's back and bursts from his chest. It drags a rain of blood, flies another hundred yards, and buries itself in the snow.

The Scion howls. Hot tears gush from his eyes.

Whether sunlight melted the snow or the wind dragged it from the forest, the battlefield suddenly steams.

In moments, the fog thickens into substance. It is so dense one cannot see their own outstretched hand; the ears feel stuffed with cotton.

Fu Yuan feels himself turn into a feather, drifting slowly down toward the snow. At the same time, massive silhouettes surface from the fog.

Elephants emerge like beasts from the primordial flood, ghost-walking through the war. The riders are giants encased in matte black armor, faceless, absorbing the light.

The beasts tread the snow. Low thunder rolls beneath their feet, yet they leave no prints. Around them, men still hack and run, blind to the monsters above.

One leviathan halts before Fu Yuan. A trunk uncurls from the mist — gentle, immense — lifting him to place him upon the broad back.

A fatigue beyond resistance takes him. Consciousness dissolves into black water.

In the thick fog, the battle cannot continue. Mukhtar orders the horn; Khurel's forces follow the sound and retreat. The Scion crawls through the slush, clawing at the earth in a stubborn search for the body, until his men forcibly drag him away.

Fu Yuan wakes in a pool of liquid gold, warm, smooth, like honey. His skin — no hole, no scar. Velvet.

The air is heavy with an otherworldly fragrance — blooming flowers, rotting fruit, a scent of unbearable temptation. A lethargy, deep and luxurious, soaks into his marrow, making him want to moan with the pleasure of it.

Tall, flawless beings lift him from the pool, anointing him with oils and dressing him in white silk and gold.

A man towers over the crowd as he approaches. He pulls Fu Yuan into an embrace, kisses his forehead, then turns to the assembly.

"He has walked the dust. He has sought in the cracks of time. He has walked alone under the silent dome. He is my seed left in the mortal coil, the echo of my blood, the reflection of my will."

The giant looks down, eyes vast and tender. "My beloved son. The trial is over. You shall sit with gods. You shall drink the wine of immortality until the stars burn out and the oceans turn to dust."

Days pass. Or eons. It is the purest joy Fu Yuan has ever known — a spray of foam falling back into the sea, a star returning to the night sky, a wandering ghost entering a mother's womb.

Feasts. Music. They ask for stories of the dirt world. As he speaks, the memories feel distant, like scenes from a play about a stranger. When he says the name "Fu Yuan," it is so alien it makes his heart seize.

One twilight, Fu Yuan finds his father by the sea. Seeing him approach, his father's eyes fill with a smile, and he opens his arms.

"I am leaving," Fu Yuan says.

His father gazes deep into him. The waves beat the sand in the rhythm of his breathing. " Why, my son? Are you not happy?"

"I have never been so happy," Fu Yuan says, "and happy so purely, so completely. I cannot even describe it — I only know that I have entered an ultimate order capable of containing everything, an eternal structure where the 'I' is wholly accepted."

His father laughs, and the stars and sea behind him glow with a soft light. "This is precisely the deepest longing of all living beings — to be understood, to be contained by a grand order that transcends the individual. My child, Heaven has never been a time, nor a place; Heaven is your state of perfection."

Fu Yuan looks into the golden eyes. "Yes. So this is not Heaven, is it?"

His father pauses. The waves stop in mid-air, as if forgetting to beat the shore.

"Before I came here," Fu Yuan says, "I was coal. Dark. Rough. Here, I am a diamond. Flawless. Eternal."

"Coal is rough, yet it can burn. Diamond is flawless, yet it can only reflect. A seemingly perfect state is precisely what ends the possibility of 'becoming.' Is such 'perfection' still perfection?"

"People always think the destination of the quest is to find an ultimate order where everything can be placed. But if all questions are dissolved, the 'I' is no longer 'I'; it will only halt, congealing into a link in this eternal whole. The reason 'I' am 'I' lies not in what is completed, but in what is unfinished."

"This is an infinite process of 'becoming,' not a 'result' defined by others."

His father’s eyes deepen. “So you would rather flow away in the finite than rest in the eternal?”

“Yes.” Fu Yuan’s voice holds a lucid resolution. “I choose to grow in the cracks, rather than be erased in the completeness.”

Silence stretches. Then, his father’s face shifts — pride, understanding, benediction. He touches Fu Yuan’s head.

“I understand,” the voice rumbles, a low vibration in the floor of the world. “What you seek is not an answer, but an eternal questioning. Not a destination, but an eternal departure. You refuse to become a perfect ‘masterpiece’ because you have chosen to become a ‘creator’ who never stops. This courage to refuse being sheltered by perfection and eternity... even the gods are shaken.”

“Go, my proud son. Embrace your limits. May you forge an infinity of your own in your forever-incomplete journey.”

The waves crash down with a thunderous boom, echoing through the universe.

“The freedom you can truly guard lies in everything you refuse!”

Violent pain and chill surge back into Fu Yuan’s body like a tide. He is in such pain he almost moans aloud.

He finds himself still stumbling through the dense fog, his body heavy and real.

The cold wind is like an icy rope. It threads in through the hole in his chest and out through his back, tying him tightly to this world.

Chapter 63: The King of Dingnan

Nanjiang, the Southern Frontier, is damp and hot; in summer, the heat becomes an ordeal. Inside the official residence, the King of Lingzhou reclines half-naked on a bamboo chair, his body slick with sweat, his gaze glazed and stagnant.

Following his failed political experiment, he was transferred from Lingzhou to this southern border and given the title "Grand General of the South." Yet this barbarous land possesses nothing but a surplus of corrupt officials and unruly mobs; it is ungovernable. He has exhausted every method, yet achieved nothing. He watches the Great Khan's birthday draw near, yet the holy edict summoning him back to the palace is late in coming.

He casts his eyes toward the crumpled sheet on the table — the Khan's last handwritten letter, received a full year ago. It seems that in his father's heart, this son was abandoned long ago.

Just as his thoughts drift into wild speculation, a sudden gale lashes the house, rattling the doors and windows with a sharp clatter. The room's swelter vanishes instantly, invaded by a thunder rumbles faintly at the sky's edge.

A page boy rushes in, incoherent with excitement. It turns out the Indian mystic, Chhayanath, is performing a rain ritual in the south city. In less than the time it takes to burn a stick of incense, rain the size of soybeans began smashing down. The citizens are kneeling in awe throughout the streets and alleys. The storm began in the south and is sweeping this way.

Before his voice falls, the courtyard is drowning in a torrential downpour.

The King of Lingzhou looks out the window, seeing only a vast, watery blur. His spirit jolts awake. He barks: "Go! Invite that monk to me!"

Under the lamp, Fu Yuan studies the passage in the Prince's letter:

> "Master, I think I finally grasp your Way of the Free Man. Since all meaning is a human construct, and moral orthodoxy merely a historical accident, why should I be held hostage by these phantoms? As you utilize philosophy, I shall utilize religion; where you create teachings, I establish order."
>
> "A tool is just a tool; whence comes the sacred or the profane? In the eyes of foolish men and women, the likes of Chhayanath are gods, and religious temples are salvation. To us free men, they are but convenient instruments."

Fu Yuan sinks into deep thought. Only when the attendant reminds him that the messenger is still waiting in the hall does he wake as if from a dream. He rolls up his sleeves, saturates the brush in thick ink, and writes four characters: ***Keep Your Distance*** .

He tosses it to the attendant.

Meanwhile, with the "Grand General's" full support, Chhayanath establishes a new sect and manifests miracles. Within months, believers saturate the Southern Frontier; pilgrims travel from neighboring states to pay homage. The incense burns with unparalleled intensity.

And because they fear divine retribution, the once unruly mobs and corrupt officials actually turn self-disciplined. Theft vanishes; administration clarifies. Another half-year passes,

and the Southern Frontier presents a scene of flourishing prosperity. The court and the commons alike marvel at the transformation. On this day, the imperial edict arrives: it heaps praise upon the "Grand General," investing him as the "King of Dingnan" — the Pacifier of the South — and bestowing a thousand taels of gold and endless silks.

The King of Dingnan accepts the edict and thanks the Grace, but he does not return to his manor immediately. Instead, he travels with Chhayanath to the city outskirts.

The setting sun is blood; the green mountains are a sea. The two men stand at the peak, looking down shoulder-to-shoulder at the city under the twilight — orderly, yet teeming with the smoke and fire of human life.

The King of Dingnan exhales a long breath, breaking the silence. "Who could have imagined that fear and hope are such cheap yet efficient construction materials? They are enough to rapidly erect a temple of order upon the ruins of the human heart. The Grand Advisor once criticized this King for being too idealistic, for beautifying humanity, for harboring unrealistic fantasies. Now it seems his words were not empty."

Strange light shoots from Chhayanath's eyes. His voice is low, vibrating with a peculiar texture, like metal striking stone. "Does Your Highness not feel it? This scene is a painting. The ink is still wet."

"A painting?" The King pauses.

"Yes." A vague, elusive smile hooks the corner of Chhayanath's mouth. "Fear. Hope. Piety. Greed. These are not bricks, Your Highness. They are pigments. The ten thousand people are a chaotic canvas. No good. No evil. No beauty. The Master of the Brush uses his Will as the stylus. He dips into the heavy ink of the human soul. He paints the Heaven and Earth of his own heart."

The King of Dingnan trembles all over. "The Master means that so-called governance is, in essence, a creation?"

"It is the only creation." Chhayanath's lip curls; in his eyes, even the emperors of history are dust. "But the true Master does not merely paint. He must make the figures inside the scroll believe. Believe that the ink is breath. That they were born within the painting. And that outside the frame lies only the Abyss. When they believe this, the painting becomes the only tangible reality. And the Painter... tell me, how is he different from God?"

The two exchange a smile, everything understood in silence. Their gazes move in unison past the walls of the Southern Frontier, cast toward the distant North. In that vaster land, a larger canvas waits for their ink to splash.

In the days that follow, the King of Dingnan distills his governance of the south into a complete theory, naming it the "Nan Jiang Model." Suddenly, politicians flock to the south to make the pilgrimage to this font of wisdom. Not only does the King rapidly rise as the most dazzling political star, but Chhayanath's doctrine rides this updraft to spread across the great rivers, north and south, implicitly rivaling Buddhism and Daoism.

A folk rhyme spreads among the people: "*The Emperor nurses the rot; Dingnan brings the cure*."

A consensus forms high and low: The Great Khan is old. His method of endless tinkering is obsolete, unable to cure the Empire's deep-seated rot. Only the King of Dingnan's "Nan Jiang Model" is the future — the sole hope for the Empire to shed its bones and be reborn.

"The Mandate is in the South." Many already view the King of Dingnan as the natural successor; sycophants wear down his threshold.

The King is certain he has found the correct path. More than that, he believes he has spiritually surpassed the aging father, withering away in the distant capital. He submits a memorial to the Khan, requesting that Chhayanath be named Imperial Preceptor and his sect declared the State Religion. To him, this is not a request, but a declaration — a successful son displaying his final result to his father.

The Khan does not reply with ink; he replies with three thousand iron cavalry.

Iron hooves crush the deep dreams of the southern frontier. In less than two hours, Chhayanath and his core disciples are dead, their heads severed from their bodies. The King of Dingnan is personally escorted back to the capital by Fu Yuan.

The journey is silence. The King stares at the sky, eyes hollow, muttering to himself. Fu Yuan leaves him be.

Mountains rise and fall behind them. The air turns sharp and cool. High in the vast autumn sky, wild geese cry out, piercing the clouds, driving south.

The King of Dingnan shakes his head. A bitter smile twists his face. "The geese fly south. I head north. All these years, this nephew looked forward to the day he would return to the Capital. I never thought the day would come like this. Now, I would rather be one of those geese, flying as far as possible, rather than riding this prison cart home. Is this not irony?"

"Tell me, where did I err? You enjoined me to 'keep distance,' and I did. I kept my distance from Chhayanath, and from the religion I built with my own hands. To me, it was a tool from beginning to end. I never believed its doctrine for a moment. I remained awake."

Fu Yuan watches the formation of geese. "Little Prince, do you know why the wild geese must fly south in formation, never leaving their positions for an instant?"

The King freezes. No one has called him "Little Prince" for many, many years, nor does he know why the Grand Advisor asks this, but he answers nonetheless, in a low voice: "I read the books of Natural Philosophy in my childhood. The head goose breaks the wind; it is the most The flock follows close behind, borrowing its force to save strength. Only thus can they fly ten thousand miles."

"Precisely." Fu Yuan nods, though his tone holds no praise. "But do you know that the head goose also tires?"

Without waiting for the Prince's answer, he continues: "When it tires, it retreats into the formation, and another goose takes its place. The entire flock is constantly rotating into that most arduous, yet most glorious position."

Fu Yuan slowly retracts his gaze. Finally, he looks directly at the King of Dingnan, his eyes sharp as knives.

"The goose flies ten thousand miles not because of its bravery. It flies because it knows when to advance, and when to retreat. It knows it is the Head Goose. And it knows that in the next moment, it will not be the Head Goose. It maintains a lucid distance from that identity."

"But you, King of Dingnan, fell in love with the feeling of being that Head Goose."

"You mistook the roles of 'King of Dingnan' and 'Pioneer of the New Model' for your true self. You enjoyed the adoration of the ten thousand people; you became drunk on the power to reshape heaven and earth. You forgot that you, too, are just a solitary goose between heaven and earth. You forgot that you, too, need to retreat — that you need to keep your distance from that self wrapped in success and power."

"Ordinary men mistake their Will for their Existence. They mistake the deeds forged by that Will for the Self. The Free Man is different. He observes his ambition as a passing cloud. He examines his success as a reflection in water. He experiences it. He refuses to become it."

"This. This is the true meaning of 'Keep Your Distance.'"

Beneath the vast dome of the sky, the prison cart grinds across the earth, cutting two shallow ruts. Moments later, the wind and sand smooth them over; the feet of strangers trample them into nothing. It is the merciless cycle of history: one actor exits the stage, another enters, and the "immortal deeds" they leave behind are nothing but tracks in the sand, waiting to be erased.

Chapter 64: Panic in the Inner Palace

The Great Khan, barely seated on the throne, has already discarded the saber for the charcoal stylus.

For half a month, he has been sprawled over the blueprints of the New Capital, clutching an iron ruler. He wields the stylus like a blade, and every stroke draws blood.

Winding alleys? Crooked lanes? What kind of system is this? Cut.

Noisy markets? Chaotic sprawl? An insult to the national prestige. Cut.

The Minister of Works stands by, unable to intervene, offering only breathless praise: " The beauty of the World must be thus — straight, square, impeccable. A fraction too much is excess; a fraction too little is a slant. Only absolute precision avoids blaspheming the Order."

On this day, the Khan slashes the final cut. The Minister cradles the blueprints like a newborn heir and trots back to his bureau. The Khan rubs his stiff neck. He realizes it has been some time since he visited the Inner Palace. The Empress is likely displeased. He decides to take a turn, perhaps let the newly inducted Consort Jade press the ache from his shoulders.

He sets one foot into the palace.

He screams and scrambles out of the door, backwards.

The guards rush in to save the Emperor from the assumed assassins. Then they look, and every man sucks in a breath of cold air.

Assassins? None. Female specters? A whole army.

The concubines stand in a rigid formation. Their faces — plastered white walls; their brows — black roof tiles. Their lips are painted bloody red like bulls-eyes. Their hair is piled so high it scrapes the clouds.

They wear identical makeups and clothes, and they move their hands and feet in perfect unison.

One beauty steps forward from the formation. She lets out a musical laugh, yet somehow it makes the Khan's skin crawl.

"Are you... my Queen?"

The Empress feigns hurt. "Has His Majesty been gone so long he no longer recognizes his own wife?"

The Khan sweeps his eyes over the row of women again. He cannot even distinguish where Consort Jade stands. He scowls. "What is this sorcery? What are you playing at?"

The Empress smiles coldly. "Does His Majesty not find his sisters beautiful? We hear the Emperor has spent half a month planning the New Capital, proclaiming that the Beauty of the World lies in uniformity and order. This Concubine manages the Inner Palace. Though I cannot set an example for the Empire, I certainly cannot allow the Harem to fall behind."

Clap. Clap. Clap.

Applause breaks the silence. A man enters with a slow, deliberate gait. Long hair, black robes, eyes like deep pools. Who else but Fu Yuan?

The Khan realizes the trap. "I knew it! You two conspired to mock this Old Man!"

He looks again at the crowd of beauties, transformed into specters of geometry. A sudden realization strikes him. He barks: "Go! Wash those faces! Now!"

The women dissolve into giggles and scatter.

The Khan turns on Fu Yuan. "If you have words, speak. If you have gas, release it."

Fu Yuan's gaze cuts him like a knife, yielding not an inch.

"Shackle Beauty to a Standard, and you breed nothing but Ugliness. The world is blind to the woman you hold in your heart, but they see the city you demand. Finish your Capital of perfect uniformity, and every city under Heaven will become a mirror of this Harem."

The Khan falls silent.

Fu Yuan tosses a scroll onto the floor. It is a memorial written by the Grand Guardian, Liu Bingzhong.

> "Architecture is the Countenance of the State. If the Countenance is orthodox, the State is orthodox; if the Countenance is chaotic, the State is in peril."
>
> "Your Servant observes the rise and fall of ages: Great Beauty requires Unity; Minor Beauty breeds Disorder. The Ultimate Beauty of the Tao lies in harmonious unification, without a hairsbreadth of error. This aligns with the Will of Heaven above and the hearts of the people below. It is the Unchanging Truth of ten thousand generations."

Fu Yuan sneers. "Rotten scholar. Empires need cornerstones, yes. But how can Beauty — a thing of mist and void — bear the weight of stone?"

"Beauty is the spontaneity that arrives unbidden. It is the sudden shock of a flower blooming around a bend; it is the wind unbinding your hair. It has no substance. It is merely the shadow of Existence. Try to grasp it, try to name it, and it flees. Think you have captured it? Open your hand. You hold only a corpse."

The Khan drifts into a trance. A memory surfaces from the deep past.

He was a Scion then, a fugitive on the grassland with a young Fu Yuan. They had just shaken off their pursuers and reached a small barbarian tribe. And there he saw her — a girl surrounded by her people, heroic and bright, like a red sun rising from the horizon.

He snaps back to the present. He steals a glance at the Empress, her face still a mask of white plaster. He shudders.

Fu Yuan's voice arrives, seemingly from far away, yet piercingly close.

"The common man fears freedom, so he establishes 'Standards' as shackles. He fears chaos, so he uses 'Beauty' as a shield. But if you ask 'What is Beauty?', it is like asking 'What is Meaning?' I tell you: It is nothing. It is neither profound nor holy."

"If Beauty becomes Philosophy, it is the colonization of the mind."

"If Beauty becomes Divinity, it is the strangulation of humanity."

"If Beauty is granted Power, it becomes the worst of all tyrannies."

The Khan sinks into silence. Fu Yuan speaks no more. The Empress lowers her brows in thought. Three people, three hearts, drifting in their own currents.

Suddenly, the cry of a swallow pierces the hall.

A single swallow lifts from the eaves. It arcs over the layered walls of the palace, heading for the distance.

The Khan watches the bird disappear into the timeline of history. He murmurs:

"The swallows who saw gilded halls and ancient kings..."

Fu Yuan finishes the line, his voice bridging the dust of a thousand years:

"...Now brush the eaves of ten thousand homes with their wings."

They look at each other. Simultaneously, they burst into loud laughter.

In the spring wind, the swallow flies higher, further. It clears the rigid geometry of the palace; it crosses the straight lines of the streets; it soars over the square blocks of the market.

Finally, it dives, dissolving into the smoke, the fire, and the messy, chaotic life of the ten thousand homes in the gathering dusk.

Chapter 65: The Pebble

The spring river flows forever east. Its surface holds the reflection of white clouds, yet the clouds do not drift with the current.

Fu Yuan lies on a riverside rock, his robe falling open at the chest, loose and unkempt. Across the river's face, a monk walks toward him, treading upon the water.

Fu Yuan roars with laughter. "Boatless, you bald rogue! Still playing at your supernatural theatrics?"

Buzhou the Boatless steps onto the stony bank. Seeing that his insteps and the hem of his robe are slightly damp, he shakes out the fabric and chuckles. "Shameful. Truly shameful."

He sits before Fu Yuan, studying him intently, then beams with delight. "One look at your eyes, Brother Pang, and I see your cultivation has deepened. The illusion of the Self and the illusion of the Other have vanished. You have reached the realm of the Great Bodhisattva — dwelling in no form, attached to no law. A joy! A triumph!"

Fu Yuan scoffs. "I practice no cultivation; whence comes this 'depth'? And don't think you can hustle me for a donation to that little temple of yours!"

Buzhou the Boatless turns solemn. "The Grand Advisor is mistaken. What is cultivation but the ceaseless stripping away of obsession, the shedding of fixed concepts? Is this not the very heart of your philosophy of the Free Man? You stand now at the terminus countless ascetics dream of reaching. Why feign modesty? Are you a millionaire begging in the streets? Or a beauty who knows not that she can topple kingdoms?"

He pauses, then sudden understanding washes over him. He claps his hands and laughs. " I see it now! Brother Pang walks the Supreme Path: the Cultivation of Non-Cultivation! This monk is too narrow."

Fu Yuan offers no further argument. He picks up a pebble. With a flick of his wrist, he sends it skipping across the river's skin, leaping toward the far bank in a spray of white water.

Through some unseen sleight, the stone reaches the far shore only to arc around and skip back across the surface. Fu Yuan opens his palm and snatches it from the air.

The Boatless Monk's eyes go round. Before he can speak, Fu Yuan tosses the pebble into the woods behind them.

Buzhou holds his breath, waiting. A spring breeze drifts by, carrying the scent of grass and wildflowers, but the stone does not return. Astonished, he looks at Fu Yuan. The latter merely shrugs and spreads his empty hands.

The shock in the monk's eyes flickers and dies, replaced by a dawning clarity.

"You understand," says Fu Yuan.

Buzhou muses, "The monk can cross the river; the pebble can cross the river."

Approval shines in Fu Yuan's eyes.

Buzhou continues: "The pebble goes, never to return, yet the monk remains, waiting in expectation. The two acts appear the same, but the truth is divergent."

Fu Yuan nods. "I am that pebble..."

He looks toward the woods where the stone has vanished.

“It has no target. It answers to no trajectory. It bears no heavy burden of spiritual rank. Its existence is not a story that demands to be told, nor a masterpiece that must be finished. It may cross the river to the far shore, or it may vanish into the woods on this side. No destination holds the power to define it.”

“And so, I am not a cultivator in the strict sense.” Fu Yuan slides both feet into the water, savoring the warm, soft touch of the spring current.

“Cultivation, self-actualization — these are the Great Projects men build to defy the absurdity of existence. I choose to stand outside the Project. I do not fight it. I do not need to conquer it. I simply decline to participate.”

As they speak, a small boat drifts downriver to the bank. The boatman sees them and hails them respectfully. “Do you two gentlemen require passage?”

Fu Yuan clasps his hands in thanks but shakes his head. “Alas, this humble one carries no silver.”

The boatman glances at the monk. “With a Master of such standing present, this lowly one takes no coin.”

Before the monk can speak, Fu Yuan laughs aloud and leaps aboard first.

Chapter 66: Gautama

Samarkand — ancient city steeped in silk and spice, where countless dreams and destinies converge like rivers, only to dissipate into mist.

One year ago, Gautama appeared in the city, speaking with a strange accent. Like the many drifters washed in by the tides of war, his robes were crusted with dried salt. Yet one had only to look into his eyes to be ensnared — they were as clear as the meltwater at the source of the Zarafshan River, yet behind them lay a soul as old as time.

Gautama never spoke of his origins. People guessed he was a fallen noble, for his fingers were slender and his bearing elegant, yet he did not mind doing the lowly work of a caravan porter. Within two months, however, he was discovered by Rostam, the city's wealthiest merchant, and elevated to partner.

Rostam loved him like a son. He told Gautama, "You need do nothing but walk with me. Conversation with you fills me with inspiration." To others, he said, "Gautama possesses a strange power. No matter how tangled the problem, he sees the essence. He seizes the vital He is a born chess player, never a piece on the board."

Fate did not always favor Gautama — he faced the betrayal of trusted partners, caravans vanished into the desert sands, markets collapsed overnight. Yet he never fled. He faced disaster as one faces a transparent glass: seeing clearly the contents of the suffering, then dismantling it, layer by layer.

He did not drown in questions like "Why me?" nor did he blame heaven or men. He simply asked the silence: "What is the problem? Why do I ask this? What remains in this moment? What can be done? What must be left undone?"

Time and again, Gautama rose from the ruins, flying higher than before. His fame spread, yet he treated his own success with indifference.

One day, he met Garan — the most renowned courtesan of Samarkand. She was the city's incarnation of desire; to climb into her bed was, for many men, the ritual confirmation of having reached the pinnacle of life.

At first, Gautama was besieged by passion and unease like any other. Garan, with elegant ritual and exquisite skill, pushed love and lust to their zenith, making men believe this was the only conquest over loneliness. But after the heat faded, Gautama would grow quiet, examining his own thirst.

He repeatedly dissected the waves in his heart. When attachment rose, he peeled back the silk cocoon to identify the shape of the pain. When desire turned to obsession, he sifted through it to find what was real enough to hold.

He reminded himself: all pain and all pleasure can be deconstructed until only " immediate reality" and "available action" remain. Thus, he could immerse himself fully, yet leave without looking back; he could appreciate everything without the obsession of possession. He did not rely on Garan to confirm his existence, but calmly enjoyed every honest encounter. He did not deny desire, nor was he enslaved by it. He simply practiced freedom in every passing moment.

#

The wind from the great steppe brings the first snow to Samarkand, and with it, the iron rhythm of the Mongol Khan's western expedition.

Rostam speaks to Gautama: "I am old. I have no faith I will survive these chaotic times. Sara is my only daughter, my pearl. I give her to you. Promise me — love her, protect her."

He continues: "I have convinced the city nobles to surrender to the Mongol Khan. A messenger brought the Khan's decree yesterday: the city shall be spared. The Mongol army arrives in three days. We will open the gates to welcome the Khan, and on that same day, hold your wedding. I have some friendship with General Subutai under the Khan's tent; he will send a representative to attend."

The grandeur of the wedding stuns all of Samarkand. Old Rostam embraces Gautama tightly, placing the signet ring of family authority into his hand. That night, nameless Mongol officers take turns toasting him. Gautama drinks much wine. As he staggers toward the bridal chamber, he feels, for the first time, that his life has reached the far shore of worldly perfection.

He pushes the door. It does not move. Then comes a woman's scream.

He kicks the door open. The sight before him drives him mad — his new wife pinned to the bed by drunken Mongol soldiers, while others stand by, laughing wildly, unbuckling their belts.

Old Rostam rushes in from nowhere, roaring as he throws himself at them, only to be kicked to the floor. He struggles briefly, then moves no more.

Gautama loses all reason. He seizes a heavy silver candlestick and smashes a soldier's skull into ruin. Another lunges at him, only to have his face crushed into a bloody pulp.

The remaining soldiers swarm him, pinning him to the ground. Fists and boots fall upon him like rain. In his ears, only Sara's desperate wailing remains. Through a haze of blood, he sees a soldier mount his wife and draw a dagger—

BANG!

A massive firework explodes in the black sky, blooming scarlet as Sara's blood.

#

Time loses its meaning. Gautama wakes in a space of total darkness. A tall figure with long hair and black robes stands with his back to him, hands clasped behind him — an apparition of

"Gautama." The man's voice makes him shudder inexplicably.

"Am I dead?" Gautama asks.

Silence.

"Why?" Tears stream down Gautama's face. "If I am dead, why is there still such pain? Is death not release? Is it not the void?"

The man slowly shakes his head. "It is not you who has died. It is the 'smart' Gautama."

Gautama freezes.

"The Gautama who used philosophy to dismantle everything," the man says. "The one who would say — 'This is but an illusion,' 'This is but attachment,' 'This is merely a narrative.'"

Gautama clutches his head, rocking in agony. "I cannot do it. I cannot view this as illusion, attachment, or narrative. I do not want to!"

The man nods. "Because that Gautama is dead."

Gautama falls to his knees, embracing the man's legs, weeping uncontrollably. "Please. Let me die too."

"It hurts, does it not?" the man asks softly, like a dear friend returning after a long separation.

Gautama nods frantically.

"Then, congratulations," the man says.

Gautama throws his head back, glaring at him. "You are insane!"

The man leans down to gaze at Gautama. Gautama cannot see his face, only the burning intensity of his eyes.

"Tell me, Gautama. This moment — is it real?"

Gautama clutches his heart, groaning. "I am dead, speaking to a god of death. This should not be real. Yet I have never felt such reality. It is a reality that offers no excuses, no place to hide..." He trembles. "It is as real as standing naked in the snow."

He meets the man's gaze. "So, you congratulate me on feeling a 'truer existence'?"

"An existence unwrapped by philosophy. An existence unexplained by wisdom. An existence unpromised by gods." The man lifts Gautama's chin, as if inspecting him. "Only the pain itself. Pure, inescapable pain that makes you doubt everything."

"But I cannot bear it," Gautama whispers, tears flowing unchecked.

The man remains silent.

"What should I do?" Gautama asks.

"You must stop asking 'what should I do.'"

The man crouches, looking into Gautama's eyes. "Listen, dear Gautama. I am not here to give you answers. I am not here to tell you how to walk out of pain. And I am certainly not here to take you to paradise. I am only here to tell you one thing."

"Pain is the chisel the universe uses to carve you. It cannot be evaded. I am merely here to invite you to see: that story named 'Suffering' is a cage you wove for yourself to escape the

reality of 'Pain.' If you fear pain, seek a doctor, take medicine. If you want a promise of deliverance from the sea of bitterness, seek faith."

"Freedom is not a solution. Freedom is lucidity."

Gautama asks, "Then what must I do?"

The man stands and turns to leave. "Do whatever you wish. If you want to cry, cry. If you want to hate, hate. If you want to despair, despair. Do not attempt to transcend them. Do not attempt to deconstruct them. Let them carve their marks into you, as wind and rain carve the stone."

Gautama's heart hammers against his ribs. "If this goes on, what will I become?"

The man walks into the darkness. "You will become You. A unique, destiny-carved You."

"Wait!" Gautama shouts.

The man stops.

"Who are you?" Gautama asks. "I feel I know you."

The man replies, "I am you."

As the words fall —

BOOM!

The memories lost for nearly a year sweep back like a breaking dam, carrying the grit and fury of the steppe winds.

Gautama lets out a feral roar. He opens his eyes. He lies on a cold, damp floor, covered in blood and filth. His hands and feet are bound with iron chains; his body is a map of wounds. Intense agony storms through him, momentarily eclipsing the ache in his soul.

He sits up. The two clear pools of water in his eyes fade, darkening into an abyss with no bottom.

He snaps the iron chains with a casual twist of his wrists. He kicks the cell door off its hinges and walks out. Several Mongol soldiers rush at him, but meet his gaze and stumble backward, paralyzed by instinctual terror.

Snow still drifts from the sky. The city of Samarkand lies in a dead silence, as if the only sound between heaven and earth is the rhythm of his footsteps.

He arrives at the Great Khan’s command tent. The guards stand ready for battle, shouting, “Who goes there?” yet not one dares to take a step forward.

Gautama speaks.

“Tell your master...”

“Fu Yuan — has returned.”

Chapter 67: The Comet

A colossal comet cuts across the night sky. A folk rhyme quietly spreads through the streets:

The Emperor departs, the Empress holds sway,
The Crown Prince stands powerless, the Sacred Way in decay.
A Broom Star hangs high for ninety days,
Laborers and Eaters part their ways.

By the river, in a tavern, a man in a gray robe sits alone by the window. He is in the prime of his life, yet dust coats his shoulders and the weary lines of the world mark his brow. On his table, there is only a pot of wine and a plate of beef. Nothing else.

Thump, thump, thump.

A group of wilderness bravos storms up the stairs, bringing noise and chaos. After a few cups of wine, their talk turns to the state of the nation.

One man slams the table and stands. "The Laborer toils all day and never fills his belly; the Eater never sheds a drop of sweat yet feasts behind vermilion gates! Is there any justice in this world?!"

The crowd roars in agreement:

"The division between Laborer and Eater is truly the root of all human suffering!"

"Crown Prince Zheng's theory is thunderous — it awakens the deaf! It has won the hearts of the people. We must follow him to the death!"

A scholar in a grime-stained long gown shakes his head, swaying rhythmically. "Do you gentlemen know why Crown Prince Zheng's 'Society of the Sacred Way' was banned by the Regent Empress?"

The crowd eagerly asks for the reason.

The scholar says, "Wealth is Original Sin. You and I are penniless, so what sin do we have? The wealth is all in the hands of the 'Eaters' represented by the Empress. They are the most immoral breed on earth! Think about it — would she allow the Society of the Sacred Way to exist?"

The crowd nods, sudden realization dawning on their faces.

From the window, the gray-robed man lets out a cold laugh. It is soft, yet in the clamor of the tavern, it pierces the air like a needle.

The crowd turns, ready to explode in anger, but an elder at the head table stops them. He sees that although the gray-robed guest sits casually, his presence is as still as a deep pool and as imposing as a mountain. This is no ordinary man.

The elder clasps his hands. "This friend seems to have a different view. Why not drink a cup with us and offer some instruction?"

The man pauses, then rises. He walks over, leans his long sword against a pillar, and sits.

Before the wine touches his lips, the scholar interjects: "The gentleman understands justice; the small man understands profit. He who abandons justice to chase profit is a small man. Surely you do not disagree?"

The gray-robed guest drains his cup in one motion. "Good wine."

He sweeps his gaze across the crowd and asks, "Does air have morality?"

The men look at each other, perplexed.

The elder muses, "Air is an object; it is everywhere. It seems to have no morality to speak of... What is your point?"

The gray-robed guest smiles. "If air has no morality, from where does wealth derive its morality? You and I breathe the air — what sin is there in that?"

"Wealth is the bedrock of the world's rotation, just as man cannot survive without air. Yet why does no one discuss whether air has morality or original sin, while people discuss the morality of wealth with such relish?"

The crowd sits frozen. The tavern falls silent.

The gray-robed guest watches their expressions, amused. He remembers hearing these exact words not long ago, and his reaction then was no different from theirs...

#

That day, the autumn wind scoured the great steppe. In the twilight, the comet burned brighter than it ever appeared in the Central Plains.

Bonfires roared; songs drifted on the wind. A disciple presented a wine pot. Fu Yuan poured a cup, then passed the pot to Fu Ce.

Fu Ce took the pot and immediately began speaking of the situation in the Central Plains: Emperor Ling had died; the Empress and her faction held total power; the world believed Crown Prince Zheng was finished. But the Crown Prince had released a manifesto: *Birds and beasts know equality; only the human world has injustice, and this is the sin of wealth. Birds and divide only by male and female; humans divide by Laborers and Eaters.*

It continued: *The Laborer is born to be exploited by the Eater; this is an irreconcilable contradiction. The former creates wealth, the latter seizes it — does this accord with Heaven's Principle? When I ascend the throne, I swear to level the rich and poor, to end the division of Laborer and Eater, and restore the Righteous Path to the world.*

This theory was deafening. It not only won the support of the common people but attracted countless men of conscience. And the comet in the sky — was it not the harbinger of great change? Months ago, the Crown Prince had sent word to recruit him. Fu Ce thought to himself: Life is short. To shed one's blood for a noble ideal — that would not be a wasted life.

Fu Yuan pointed to the pot in Fu Ce's hand. "Drink."

Fu Ce had spoken so much his mouth was dry. He lifted the pot and drank greedily.

Fu Yuan looked up at the comet in the sky. He watched it with total focus. Fu Ce followed his gaze.

Fu Yuan seemed to speak to himself. "That is nothing but a clump of ice and rubble. It is no messenger of Heaven. It is merely pushed by the solar wind, wandering the cosmos, flying toward the depths of the dark."

Fu Ce forgot to drink.

"People believe they represent light, but in truth, they are rushing toward darkness," Fu Yuan said, staring at Fu Ce with burning eyes. "They think they are creating history, but they are merely the dust of history."

Fu Ce dared not meet Fu Yuan's gaze. He lowered his head. "Has your nephew fallen into the trap of the mob again? But..." He looked lost. "The Crown Prince says human injustice is the sin of wealth. This sounds like truth."

The wind blew past, carrying the scent of roasted meat and milk tea. Fu Yuan inhaled deeply. "Smells good."

Then, he asked, seemingly at random, "Ce, tell me: does air have morality?"

#

Fu Ce wakes from the memory. The crowd is still staring at him, waiting for the answer.

"It is simple," he continues. "Because air cannot be controlled, it yields no power. But whoever controls the moral definition of wealth controls immense social power."

"The Empress and her kind say wealth is a gift from Heaven. The Crown Prince says wealth is the evidence of the Eater's crime against the Laborer. They seem like fire and water, incompatible. But in truth, every political program, every religion in human history, is attempting to slap a label of 'Good' or 'Evil' onto a substance that has no moral attributes."

"If you accept that label, you hand the authority to judge yourself over to them."

Fu Ce picks up the long sword by the table and rises to leave. The elder's eyes fall upon the sword. He notes its ancient, austere design, and his heart skips a beat.

"Dare I ask... what relation is the Grand Advisor, Fu Yuan, to you?"

Fu Ce answers, "He is my uncle."

The tavern explodes into chaos. Chairs clatter, benches overturn. Some bow, some kneel. After a flurry of humble gestures, the crowd asks: "Is the Grand Advisor well? Did he leave any words for us? Where should we go? What should we do?"

Fu Ce shakes his head and offers a bitter smile. "He never gives direct answers. His last words to me were a question: 'If the foundation is a lie, is the temple built upon it worthy of belief?'"

The crowd looks at one another — the Grand Advisor's subtle meaning is too deep to grasp in a moment.

Outside the window, the colossal comet still hangs high. The world does not know that it is merely a clump of ice and rubble, being pushed through the void. It brings no light. It points no direction.

The only thing it can do is return, once every few hundred years.

Chapter 68: Brothers

The blizzard intensifies. The hoofbeats grow frantic.

"Your Highness!" a rider shouts against the gale. "The light is failing. We will be blind in this whiteout! Better we camp and continue at first light?"

The Scion throws his head back and laughs. "This man bled for this grassland! Do not doubt he can find his way with eyes gouged out!"

He points his whip. "There! My brother waits! Make haste! Or else the cold takes him!"

The thought pulls him back a year: He presses the bronze seal of Yanling — the City of Goose Quill — into Khurel's hands. They embrace. The boy's eyes burn with heat.

"*Rest assured, brother. I will guard this for you, and when you return, Yanling will be the anvil on which you and I forge the world!*"

The memory warms the Scion's chest. He lashes his horse's flank hard.

The wall of Goose-Quill City rises in the distance, emerging from the dark. A single grain of firelight flickers at the gate, fragile against the storm.

"Look!" the Scion shouts. "Khurel is holding the torch for us! Faster! Faster!"

They thunder to the gate in a frenzy, breathless.

But they meet no Khurel, just a lieutenant of the guards. Khurel is detained, explains the lieutenant, entertaining an envoy from Persia and cannot be disturbed.

The Scion clicks his tongue, impressed. "Persian envoys? Already? My brother really is something else!"

He strides toward the gate then suddenly pulls back, craning his neck to look at the two giant characters carved above the archway.

"These two... they seem different from when I left."

The lieutenant bows his head, a flicker of mockery flashing in his eyes. "The Young Lord said the name 'Goose-Quill' was too petty. Three months ago, he ordered it renamed 'Hero's Pass.'"

Awkwardness hangs in the air.

"Good! Good!" The Scion forces the words through his teeth. "Dominating... real dominating!"

He slashes his hand through the air. "Get us drunk! Warm us up! And don't you dare disturb your master's business!"

The Scion sleeps until the dead of night.

Then Khurel barges in.

He sports a short, new beard and has thickened in the shoulders. His face is flushed with drink, his eyes manic. Still in armor, he crashes down onto the edge of the bed and unleashes a monologue, boasting of his achievements over the past year. He talks for a solid hour.

The Scion can barely wedge a word in. His eyes water from exhaustion.

Then Khurel says, "And another thing. I contacted the three eastern chieftains for you. I told them to pledge loyalty to you now, ahead of time."

He looks pleased with himself. "Since you're back, I'll find a day for them to come kneel to you."

The Scion jerks awake. "What?!"

"What is it?" Khurel frowns. "By the time the Kurultai gathers, you'll have three tribes in your pocket. Is that bad?"

"Father Khan is barely cold! The steppe is a tinderbox waiting for a spark," the Scion snaps, sleep vanishing. "How can you be so reckless?!"

Khurel's expression hardens. "When Father was alive, you preached this same caution. You held me back, and I never got the chance to show him my true worth. Now he is dead, and you still try to block me?"

"Father didn't just have us two sons," the Scion says, his voice rising in desperation. "If we show our hand too soon—"

"Enough!"

Khurel springs to his feet — the sudden motion sends the teapot and cups crashing to the floor. The Scion's guards burst in, hands on hilts, looking confused.

Khurel jams a finger toward the Scion's nose.

"Do you take me for a child still sucking milk? Do you really think those tribes are coming for you? Let me be clear: Everything you have, and I mean everything, is within my grasp. If I wanted to crush you, it would be as easy as pinching an ant!"

He sweeps the room with a vicious glare, kicks the door wide, and storms out.

The men stand in stunned silence.

The Scion sits dazed for a moment, then can't help but start weeping. After a long while, he wipes a handful of snot.

"Let's... just go."

Zara opens his eyes from meditation.

Khurel strides in. The candle flame dances wildly, making the deep wrinkles on the Persian prophet's face writhe like a snake's nest.

"You have done it," Zara says.

"Ha! You should have seen my brother's face!" Khurel laughs.

"Khurel! Oh, Khurel! What did I witness tonight?" Zara asks.

"What?" Khurel pauses.

"I saw a Lion!" Zara paces the room, his eyes burning with fanatical fire. "A Lion that finally shredded the rope from its neck!"

He spins around, his voice booming like thunder.

"Hark! The stars sing for you! They cry out: 'Behold! A new Will is born! The footfalls of the one who dares trample the old world are ringing out!'"

"Your brother is the Sun of Yesterday. He has already set! But you... you are the Fire of Tomorrow, ready to burn across the grassland! But—"

He halts. His eyes blaze like torches.

"Lightning severed in mid-strike is more terrible than the dark! The Lion halted in mid-leap will be dragged back to the cave by Yesterday's ghosts!"

"Answer me, Khurel! Do you choose to be the Divine, perfect and total? OR do you choose to be the Mortal, flawed and inadequate?"

"Will you allow the Sun of Tomorrow to rise from your blood? Or will you let the Shadows of the Past consume your Sky once more?"

His voice climbs higher still, shrilling.

"O Great Soul! Pulverize the final fetter! Let your thunder rouse the slumber of this vast land! Let the proclamation be heard by all men and women — a new Sovereign is born!"

Khurel stands dumbstruck. He trembles at the thought. "You mean..."

The door curtain lifts. The lieutenant walks in. "Reporting, Your Highness. The Scion and his party have left the residence. They should be out of the city by now."

Khurel grits his teeth.

"Pursue them!"

#

"You know the rest of the story." The Scion sounds exhausted. "I jumped off that cliff and crashed into your wagon."

Days later, beneath a canopy of stars on the snowfield, the Scion huddles in furs, leaning against a rock, watching Fu Yuan feed the campfire.

"Ever heard of Icarus?" Fu Yuan doesn't look up.

The Scion shakes his head.

"Someone gave him a pair of wings. But warned him: do not fly too high." Fu Yuan rubs his hands over the fire. "But the moment the boy took flight, he forgot everything. He flew higher and higher. Closer and closer to the sun."

"Like me handing Yanling to Khurel..." The Scion sighs. "The ending?"

"The sun melted the wax holding the wings together." Fu Yuan turns. "So he fell. And drowned in the sea."

The Scion stares into the fire.

Fu Yuan stands up, facing the snow-capped mountains on the horizon.

"There is a philosophy in this world. It prods you to use the Will to master Fate. Use the Will to conquer the World. Sounds magnificent, doesn't it?"

A glint of contempt flashes in his eyes.

"But the disciples of this creed never turn their gaze inward. Their so-called 'Will' is nothing more than the engine of primitive instinct. It is as fragile as the wax on the wings of Icarus."

"If the Will is the wing, then Unexamined Desire is its wax."

"The Will to Power? Wax. The Vanity of the Ego? Wax. Even that desperate need to prove one's existence? Nothing but wax!"

Fu Yuan leans in, his eyes cold.

"Think wings built of such frailty can ever bear the weight of true Self-Overcoming? Think again."

"The believers of this creed delude themselves. They will believe their every Despicable Impulse possesses a Noble Meaning. But the truth is, their climb toward the sun is no ascent. It is but the prelude to falling — into madness, then ruin."

The Scion stares, dumbfounded.

The young man before him stands in the snow with nothing to his name — yet he holds himself with a sovereignty that dwarfs the kings of this world. And the strangest part? It doesn't make you hate him.

"Why save me?" The Scion's voice is hollow. "I'm wiped clean. City's gone. Brother's gone. My men? Dead or scattered to the winds. The old man who covered for me is in the

All I have left is this title of 'Scion' — and right now, that's just a target painted on my back. This head... it's the only thing left worth a few coins."

Fu Yuan studies the Scion's head for a beat. He bursts out laughing.

"If I were after coin, why would I bother with that big head of yours?"

He looks up at the river of stars. His eyes burn with the same cold, distant fire.

"I saw a certain possibility. A possibility beyond all comparison."

A tremor runs through the Scion. A strange premonition, electrifying his blood.

"Brother... are you saying you saw me taking the whole world?"

The corner of Fu Yuan's mouth hooks up. Serious? Mocking? Impossible to say.

"Don't flatter yourself. All you have done is shed a pair of wax wings. You are now — barely — qualified to contend for the world."

That night, the Scion dreams.

He is back on the steppe. He and Khurel, riding hard, chasing the red sun. Khurel is the boy again — eyes feverish, shouting in pure joy, charging into the dying light.

Far in the distance, Mount Yanling stands shrouded in the sunset’s glow. It looks like a giant feather, dropped by an angel into the mortal world.

Chapter 69: The Audit of Freedom

The Khan has a nightmare. In the dream, Fu Yuan transforms into a goshawk and vanishes into the gray sky. The Khan wakes; the royal pillow is soaked through with cold sweat.

By afternoon, the Wooden Man sits across from him at the chessboard. Seeing the Emperor's mind wandering elsewhere, the Wooden Man offers an observation.

"Your Majesty, the last two moves you played were mathematically unpredictable. They are also, objectively speaking, garbage."

The Khan glares at the few pieces remaining on his side of the board. "If I had a few more Horses," he grumbles, "I'd trample your algorithms into sawdust, no matter how fast that clockwork brain of yours spins." He sighs, his shoulders slumping. "The Grand Advisor... he is like the Horse. He moves as he pleases, jumping over walls, defying straight lines. But he is too free. One day, he will simply ride off the board. And then what becomes of this Emperor?"

The Wooden Man's painted wooden eyes roll in their sockets. "Your Majesty, your distress stems from an inability to control the variable known as 'Freedom.' The Grand Advisor's high entropy comes from his unpredictability — precisely like the Horse's trajectory."

The Khan blows through his mustache. "Speak human!"

"To simplify," the Wooden Man adjusts its vocal synthesis, "you fear his departure because you cannot quantify his freedom, nor do you know if there exists a redundant unit with equivalent specs to replace him. It is a classic problem of information asymmetry."

The Khan pauses. The cold logic is strangely comforting. "So? What is the solution?"

The Wooden Man's eyes glow with a sudden, brighter lumen. "To resolve your anxiety, we must transmute the abstract concept of 'Freedom' into observable, metrics-based data. I have analyzed every word and action of the Grand Advisor and successfully reverse-engineered a ' Freedom Quantification & Assessment System.' We shall call it: The Freedom Audit."

From out of nowhere, the creature produces a scroll of sheepskin covered in dense, terrifying charts and formulas that no mortal mind could parse.

The Khan snatches it, staring blankly at the ink. He understands nothing, yet the weight of the nightmare lifts. He slams the table, dragon-face beaming. "Good! Excellent! You stiff-jointed blockhead, you've finally done something useful! I grant you the funds to establish the Ministry of the Freedom Audit. Scour the empire! Test every soul! Find me the horse with the highest score!"

The Wooden Man moves with terrifying efficiency. The public beta testing concludes swiftly, yielding fascinating data:

Subject A: The High Monk. Famous for the Zen koan: *"Originally there is not a single thing, where can dust alight?"*Score: 58/100. System Analysis: *"Subject exhibits cognitive calcification regarding the concept of 'non-attachment.' He is attached to the idea of having no attachments. Recommendation: Deconstructionist re-education."*

Subject B: The Mad Poet. Known for sprinting naked through the capital screaming, *"I have cast off all shackles!"* A favorite among bored court ladies. Score: 76/100. System Analysis: *"Subject's behavioral loop is entirely dependent on the shock-feedback of external observers to*

validate his 'free' state. Diagnosed as Histrionic Performance Personality. The shackles have been cast off; they have merely been made transparent."

Subject C: General Zhang the Fearless. Style name "No-Taboo," alias "Self-Forgetting. " Score: A Dismal 35/100. System Analysis: *"Subject's courage is a structural dependency relies entirely on the existence of an 'Enemy' to be conquered. 'Fearlessness' is merely a rebranding of aggression. If the external enemy is removed, subject's existential framework faces immediate collapse."*

Then, the day arrives. The Wooden Man rushes into the hall, gears grinding with excitement. A perfect specimen has been found.

"Score: Ninety-nine," the Wooden Man announces. "The missing point is only because the algorithm briefly struggles to classify him as a carbon-based lifeform."

The Khan, delighted, demands the transcript.

Q: Do you know who I am?

A: Don't know. Don't want to know. If I knew, what of it? If I don't, what of it? If you give, I take. If you don't, I don't hate you.

The Khan looks skeptical. He glances at the Wooden Man, who continues reading the transcript with reverence.

Q: Do you want this alms?

A: Naturally.

Q: Will you kowtow for it?

A: Giving or not giving is your liberty. Accepting or refusing is mine. I do not force your hand; you need not force my knees. We each keep our own gravity. That is all.

Q: Do you know what suffering is?

A: Hungry, I want food. Cold, I want warmth. Lonely, I want a voice. Not getting these things — that is suffering.

Q: So, are you suffering now?

A: To say 'no' would be a lie. But I have found this: when I am in pain, and I think about how to stop being in pain, the pain doubles. But if I simply starve, simply freeze, simply sit in the silence... it is manageable.

Q: If someone told you your life is meaningless and you should just die, how would you answer?

A: I would tell him that 'meaning' is his need, not mine. If he feels pointlessness, that is his sensation. If I feel amusement, that is mine. I do not force him to understand me; he should not force me to accept him.

"Enough!" The Khan yawns, waving a hand. "Bring him for the Palace Exam tomorrow."

The next day, inside the Golden Hall.

"Summon the 'Freedom Laureate,' Wang the Dog!" the eunuch shrieks.

Slap, slap, slap.

The sound of bare, calloused feet on marble. Wang the Dog enters, guided by the Wooden Man. Before he even reaches the throne, the stench of him hits the court officials like a physical blow. He is a ruin of a man — hair matted into felt, eyes white and blind. Someone whispers that he is a beggar from the South Market, known by the nickname "Take-It-Or-Leave-It."

The beggar stands with a vacant expression. The Wooden Man tugs at his rags, signaling him to kneel. He does not move.

The Khan frowns, then a cunning light flickers in his eyes.

"I am weary," the Emperor announces. "Sage-Ambassador, take our Laureate to rest. Bathe him. Clothe him in silk. Feed him the liver of dragons and the wine of immortals. Let him sleep on down. Bring him back in a few days."

The Khan waves his sleeve, ending the court session. The officials exhale, grateful to escape the smell.

Half a month passes before the Khan remembers Wang the Dog. He summons him.

When the Dog appears this time, the matted hair is shorn, the beard trimmed. He looks surprisingly delicate. He wears robes of embroidered satin, and his waist has thickened with the bloat of sudden gluttony.

He is led before the Khan. Knowing now that the presence radiating heat from the throne is the Son of Heaven, Wang the Dog collapses. He prostrates himself, shivering, forehead pressed to the cold stone.

"Laureate Wang," the Khan rumbles. "Have you enjoyed the last fortnight?"

The beggar's teeth chatter. It takes him a long moment to squeeze out a single syllable: " Yes..."

"I heard you dislike kneeling," the Khan says softly. "Why not stand and speak to Us man to man?"

"This small citizen dares not! Dares not!" Wang trembles violently.

"I heard your nickname is 'Take-It-Or-Leave-It,'" the Khan continues, his voice dropping to a dangerous purr. "I am thinking of granting you a lifetime of this wealth, this glory. Will you give me a 'Take-It-Or-Leave-It' now?"

Wang the Dog dissolves into terror, weeping into the floor tiles. "Dog dares not! Dog dares not! Mercy, Your Majesty!"

The Khan watches him for a moment, then waves his hand. "Get him out."

As the beggar is dragged away, the Khan turns to the Wooden Man, who stands frozen, processors looping in confusion. "Sage-Ambassador," the Khan smiles grimly. "In this game of chess... who won this time?"

The Emperor stands up, his playfulness vanishing. His voice becomes thunder.

"The Free Man I know," the Khan points a finger at the empty space beside him, "is a man who pits his singular will against ten thousand armies! He is a man who can fall from the

pinnacle of heaven to the depths of hell in a single night, and wake up the next morning ready to chew iron! He is a man who possesses nothing, yet looks down on Emperors with pity! He is the bastard who treats my Imperial Edicts like toilet paper!”

“The scars on his body and soul are more numerous than the patches on that beggar’s coat!”

“In the eyes of the world, he is a god. He possesses everything. Yet he chooses to live as if he has nothing.”

The Khan stops. He looks at the Wooden Man. “Do you understand, Sage-Ambassador?”

But he does not wait for an answer from the stunned contraption. He turns his gaze outward, past the pillars, to the sky.

It is deep autumn. The air over the capital is crystalline, the clouds piled high like mountains of white jade. The Khan narrows his eyes, searching the blue expanse. Sparrows and swallows chatter as they flit by.

But there is no eagle.

“Such a man...” the Khan whispers, his voice losing its thunder, leaving only the ache of a lonely king. “How many can you find in this world?”

Chapter 70: The Departure

The Eldest Prince changes into cloth robes. He slings a simple bundle over his shoulder and slips out of the Imperial Palace as the night deepens. His steps are firm; he carries a wish in his heart, vast and tender.

When he reaches the city gate, he sees a familiar silhouette. A figure in black stands at the end of the empty street, still as a ferryman waiting on a quiet shore.

Fu Yuan does not turn, yet the Prince stops. He knew the road would be hard, but he did not expect the first step to weigh so much.

He speaks first: "Grand Advisor, I see the world drowning in a sea of bitterness. Birth, aging, sickness, death. Loves parting, enemies meeting. It never ends. I want to find a Way — a path to end all suffering for every living soul."

Fu Yuan turns. The moonlight traces his outline. There is no praise in his eyes, only a coolness, clear as the moon itself.

"If you are moved by your own mercy," Fu Yuan says softly, "you are already disqualified from taking the first step."

The Prince stands still.

"You are not moved by the suffering of the masses. You are moved by the grand narrative of 'The Savior' that you are writing for yourself. This pity in your heart? It is a medal you are pinning to your own chest."

"Those drunk on the role of Savior cannot see true pain. Go back. Until you smash this golden idol you have built for yourself, you can go nowhere."

The Prince stands frozen in the moonlight. He looks at his shadow on the ground and sees the halo of a false god. Silently, he turns. He walks back into the golden birdcage.

The second departure happens in midsummer.

The golden peaks of the palace shimmer under the distant night sky. The heavy, sweet scent of agarwood and roses has finally drifted away, replaced by a breeze carrying the fresh, raw smell of river grass and mud.

He comes to the riverbank outside the city. On a large stone sits a man — Fu Yuan again. He is barefoot, his feet dipping in the stream, kicking the water with a lazy rhythm.

The Prince sighs and sits beside him. "I have come again."

Fu Yuan hums, unsurprised.

"You were right," the Prince whispers. "That 'grand narrative' of saving the world... it was just me, intoxicated by my own nobility. That story is gone now. But I have found that the pain is even more real."

He looks at the broken starlight floating on the water. "I see my Father aging, the frost creeping into his hair. I see the palace flowers open at dawn and fall by dusk; splendor fades in the blink of an eye. Nothing is permanent; life is suffering. I fear loss. I fear getting old. I fear the end."

"This time, I leave not for others. I seek only my own release. I want to escape this endless pain."

"So, you are not running from the palace..." Fu Yuan pulls his feet from the water, dries them, and slips on his shoes. "You are running from 'Suffering.'"

"What you are chasing, under the pretty name of 'Liberation,' is actually 'Joy.' How is that different from eating when hungry, or seeking warmth when cold? It is just a more refined, metaphysical way of chasing comfort."

Fu Yuan stands, dusting grass from his robes. "All the world's prayers and practices, no matter how beautiful the words, are built on this simple instinct. If you cannot see through this, you are only trading one cage for a more comfortable one."

The Prince falls silent. The water murmurs. The far bank looks enchanting under the moon, but he knows he is not yet ready to cross.

Deep Autumn.

The Prince has crossed the capital, crossed the fields, climbed a small hill, and arrived at a quiet town. He enters a tavern. Before he can speak, the waiter leads him to the best room upstairs. He pushes the door open. A table is set. Fu Yuan sits there, watching him with a smile.

He raises his cup to toast the Prince. "To your arrival."

The Prince slumps into a chair, smiling bitterly. "Grand Advisor, how do you always know?"

"As long as you are thinking about 'leaving,' you can never leave." Fu Yuan pours him a full cup.

The Prince holds the cup. "This time, I think I am ready. I have purged that self-righteous intoxication of 'saving all beings,' and I have seen through the hypocrisy of 'fleeing pain to find joy' — I see it as the source of all desire. This journey is not for the masses, not to avoid pain, not to find pleasure, not even for myself."

"I only seek the Truth that stands above it all."

Fu Yuan raises a hand. "Drink first."

The Prince lifts the cup to his lips. It is empty. He does not know when Fu Yuan emptied it.

“’The Truth that stands above it all’?” Fu Yuan plays with the wine pot in his hand. “ Before you go looking for it... are you ready for the possibility that it does not exist at all?”

The Prince stares at the empty cup, and shakes his head bitterly. Fu Yuan fills his cup again and laughs. “Then let us eat and drink.”

#

By the side of a stream.

The Awakened One takes off his shoes, rolls up his trousers, and hoists the Little Novice onto his shoulders to wade across the riverbed.

They are halfway across when the Little Novice can no longer wait. “Awakened One, what happened next? Did the Prince ever actually leave?”

The Awakened One couldn’t help laughing. In that laughter, there is relief, there is memory, and there is a trace of warm compassion for the self of years past.

Did he leave? Of course he left. Because you are riding on his shoulders.

He — is right over here.

Chapter 71: The Khan's Glass Orb (II)

Two men, stripped to the waist and corded with muscle, slash their way through the rainforest. Their faces are masks of tangled beard and wild hair, yet nothing can obscure the feverish fire burning in their eyes. Who could imagine that the Khan and his Grand Advisor, whose names make the whole of Central Asia tremble, would appear here — like this?

Night claims the jungle. They find a high terrace by the riverbank where the earth is hard enough for camp. Fu Yuan gathers banana leaves to pitch a shelter and spread sleeping mats, then lies back to observe the stars — fixated on a delicate, crucifix-shaped constellation he has never seen before, one that leaves him utterly entranced.

The Khan gets a fire going and leans against a tree. Unable to wait another second, he draws out the glowing glass orb.

The way he cradles the orb betrays no hint of the emperor clutching a crown. Instead, he looks like a rough plainsman holding his firstborn son — a mixture of bear-like tenderness and nervous fragility.

He lifts the orb to his ear. Faintly, from within, comes the sound of a holy choir — hymns sung for him by the people of that tiny world. As he listens, tears well in his eyes.

For days, he has been their attentive deity. If they pray for light, he holds the orb under the sun to let it bask. If they beg for rain, he dips his finger in the dew and flicks it gently against their "sky."

The world inside the glass transforms. Greed, cruelty, and oppression evaporate. Its people know that an Almighty Eye is watching them. They raise cathedrals to worship him; they create art to glorify him. He even feels that when they look up at their firmament, they are looking directly at him.

He drifts into sleep, the orb curled against his chest.

Morning brings disaster. The orb is gone.

They turn the jungle upside down for three days before finding it in a clearing. A monkey sits upon a rock, clutching the orb, accepting the adoration of its troop. The Khan, burning with rage, strides up and knocks the Monkey King dead with a single swing of his stick. The troop scatters in a screeching panic.

They lean in to look at the glass, and their jaws drop.

The cathedrals are ruins. Upon the rubble, factories rise, vomiting thick, black smoke. The people have smashed their idols to bow before the altar of the Machine.

The Khan holds the orb close, straining to hear. "They actually believe they evolved from monkeys!" He looks at Fu Yuan. "You can't be serious!"

Sleep eludes them both that night.

Fu Yuan lies on his banana leaves, the starlight pooled in his eyes. The Khan edges closer and lies down beside him. "What the hell are you seeing?"

"What cannot be seen," Fu Yuan says, a trace of melancholy in his voice.

"And what the hell is that?"

"A certain possibility," Fu Yuan sighs. "Once, when the people in the orb looked at the sky, they might have met the gaze of a God. Now, they see only a silent cosmos of floating rocks

and burning gas. The moment they believed they came from monkeys and turned to worship the machine, that first possibility vanished from their reality."

The Khan stares at the sky, shaking his head. "I don't see a God staring back at me, either. But surely there's more up there than just rocks and fire?"

"Actually, there are other possibilities, aren't there?"

Fu Yuan shakes his head. "When a fundamental cognition like 'What is existence?' solidifies into a collective consensus, all other possibilities of 'being' are erased from the eyes of men."

He sits up, crosses his legs, and closes his eyes.

"What devilry are you up to now?" the Khan grumbles.

"I am going to look inside myself," Fu Yuan says. "There is a world there, too. It needs my gaze."

The Khan snickers. "I hope they don't think they evolved from monkeys."

Fu Yuan pays him no mind.

Bored, the Khan picks up the orb again. The "physical" barrier formed by their belief in rocks and fireballs seems to have thickened; his gaze can barely penetrate the haze.

"No..." he whispers — as if speaking to himself, yet also making a promise to the tiny souls inside. "A sky without life... a universe with only one possibility... that is no home for any world."

He cradles the glass orb in his palm, closes his eyes, and begins to hum.

He has no idea what he is singing... He only wants them to hear something... different.

Chapter 72: The Three Hundred

The Scion has not yet lifted his cup when the milk tea begins to shudder and ripple. He stands abruptly, eyes alight.

"Finally."

They rush from the tent. On the horizon, dust bleeds into the sky, turning the azure to a bruised yellow. The entire grassland vibrates beneath their boots.

The Scion grips Fu Yuan's sleeve, his knuckles white. "Brother, our days of suffering are over." Then, his face drains of color. "Do not falter now... please."

The arrival is the Scion's cousin, known to the Steppe as Gurban of the Three Hundred. He is named for the three hundred iron-clad wraiths he keeps at his back — a personal cavalry that follows him like a shadow. The Scion and Fu Yuan may have evaded the pursuit of Khurel, but with fewer than a thousand men, they are dust in the wind against the Khatun's empire.

If they secure Gurban, the dead fish turns over; the impossible becomes inevitable.

But the wolf pack bows only to the alpha. Gurban does not come to submit. He comes to weigh his cousin's soul — and, more importantly, to stare into the eyes of the young man named Fu Yuan.

When Gurban sees Fu Yuan, his eyes narrow, sparking with interest. He whispers to an aide. The aide departs.

The following four days are not merely time passed; they become the stuff of Steppe mythology. Between the feasting and the drinking, there are trials.

On the First Day: Fu Yuan lifts Bat'er, the Last Giant of the Grasslands, into the air. He holds him aloft as Hercules held the Titan. When the giant is finally cast down, the earth groans so violently that wild horses, drinking miles away, scatter in terror.

On the Second Day: Jebe the Divine Archer draws his ten-stone bow. He fires three arrows in a seamless, breathing rhythm. The first, Fu Yuan strikes down with his own shaft. The second, he snatches from the air with a bare hand. The third, he catches between his teeth.

On the Third Day: The Nineteenth Heir of Zhuge Liang lays a Stone Sentinel Maze. A hundred boulders form a geometry of madness; the wind within screams like weeping ghosts. No man dares approach. Fu Yuan steps inside, strolls through the howling void, and emerges on the other side before a cup of tea can cool. The Heir weeps, vomiting three pints of blood in his defeat.

On the Fourth Day: The Thrice-Crowned Champion of the Lhasa Sutra Debates — the Supreme Vajra of Wisdom — enters the tent. By the end of their discourse, the monk has bitten through his tongue and crushed his prayer beads to dust. He strips off his cassock, laughing wildly, and wanders naked into the wilderness, never to be seen again.

On the Fifth Day, Fu Yuan is pale, though his eyes remain unclouded. That night, the strange guests arrive.

They are a procession of white. Men and women alike wear robes the color of bone, their hair cascading to their waists. They wear no expressions. They radiate a glacial chill that pierces the summer heat, making teeth chatter in the firelight.

Their leader stands taller even than Fu Yuan. His eyes are singularities — black holes where the world ceases to exist. He offers Gurban a curt nod. No bow. No homage.

Gurban does not introduce him. He simply seats the stranger at his right hand, with terrifying reverence.

The Scion leans in, whispering, "This feels wrong, Brother. Watch yourself."

Gurban raises a cup. "Master Pang is indeed a marvel of this age. I drink to you!"

The Scion cannot hide his smirk, but the Stranger in White finally turns his gaze to Fu Yuan. Fu Yuan offers a polite smile. The Stranger offers nothing.

"However..." Gurban swirls his wine. "Why, even now, does Master Pang hide his true capacity?"

"What true capacity?" the Scion asks, baffled.

The Stranger answers before Gurban can speak. "It is, of course, the insight into the ' Truth of Existence' regarding the Cosmos and Life."

He has the voice of a grinding stone, scraping against the nerves.

The Scion bristles. "Teacher, you are mistaken. My brother here is worth ten thousand men. Is that not capacity enough?"

"Even with the strength of ten thousand," the Stranger says cold, "what are you but an ant before the avalanche? Even if you live ten thousand years, what are you but a flickering spark against the eternal dark? If you do not pierce the veil of Existence, you remain common. You are merely fifty steps laughing at a hundred."

The Scion is silenced. Gurban grins. "Perhaps the Immortal Master would enlighten us commoners on the secrets of the Universe?"

The Stranger's gaze sweeps the tent like a physical weight. Every heart tightens, squeezed by an invisible hand.

"The Truth of the Universe and Life," he intones. His voice is hard as inscriptions on a stone tablet, every word carrying the weight of a final, unquestionable judgment. "It is the eternal war and fusion of three Primordial Substances: Structure, Will, and Oblivion."

He carves the air with his words:

"A stone is mostly Structure, therefore it is solid. It holds but a sliver of sleeping Will, therefore it is still. Yet, its essence is slowly devoured by Oblivion, destined for dust."

"A flame has a core of high-density Will, therefore it is hot. It consumes sparse Structure as fuel, therefore it is formless. Every flicker is Will burning itself out within Oblivion."

"And Man... Man is the most tragic alloy. Your bones and reason are forged of Structure. Your blood and desire are ignited by Will. But the space between your breaths, the pause between your heartbeats, and your deepest longing for peace? That is Oblivion manifesting within you."

"The common man lets these three tear him apart, living in agony. The Sage uses supreme Will to reshape his Structure, until the moment of perfection — where he releases all, and returns in glory to the ultimate Oblivion."

"This," he declares, "is the only, absolute Truth."

Silence drowns the tent. Even the Scion is struck dumb; the theory is so grand, so cold, so structurally perfect that it feels unassailable.

All eyes turn to Fu Yuan. He seems lost in a trance.

"Master Pang?" Gurban prompts.

Fu Yuan blinks, as if waking from a dream. "I share this view," he says, his voice thick with sincerity. "My perspective aligns perfectly with the Immortal Master."

The tent erupts in murmurs.

For the first time, the Stranger looks stunned. The Scion flushes red with embarrassment. Gurban throws his head back and laughs.

"Hahaha! I thought Brother Pang would offer some earth-shattering insight. It turns out he is merely a parrot." Gurban shakes his head. "This Prince is disappointed."

Fu Yuan feigns shock. "Does the Immortal Master not speak the only, absolute Truth?"

Gurban wipes a tear of mirth. "Naturally, he speaks the Absolute Truth. Do you not know who he is? Let me tell you—"

"Then," Fu Yuan cuts in, his lips curling into a smile barely visible to the naked eye, "if it is already the 'Only Absolute Truth,' how could there be — and why should there be — a second voice?"

The room stills.

"You should be relieved that my view aligns with the Master's. Why are you disappointed?" Fu Yuan leans forward. "Unless, deep in your heart, My Lord, you were hoping I would produce a different Truth to rival the 'Absolute,' thereby proving the Master wrong?"

Gurban's smile freezes.

"Or perhaps," Fu Yuan presses, giving him no air, "you do not actually believe the Master's words are the Absolute Truth? And if you are unsure, what right have you to be ' disappointed'?"

His voice sharpens into a blade. "By what standard do you judge which Truth is higher, if you do not possess the Truth yourself?"

Gurban's face turns the color of raw liver. The Stranger's eyes flicker, re-evaluating the young man before him.

The only sound is the crackle of the hearth and the uneven breathing of men.

Fu Yuan rises and bows deeply to the Stranger. "Immortal Master, your view on the essence of the Cosmos is enchanting."

He turns to the room. "But in my mind, I have never reserved a seat for a 'Final Answer.' Because the search for a 'Final Answer' is, in itself, a trap."

He pauses, letting the words settle.

"We must never stop seeking answers. But the moment any answer is worshipped as 'The Only' or 'The Ultimate' — it ceases to be liberation. It becomes a prison."

CLATTER .

The Stranger stands so abruptly he overturns the wine table. The tent gasps.

He signals to the white-robed figures. "We go."

He leads the way out of the tent. The white-robed figures follow like phantoms, dissolving into the night. Gurban is about to explode in rage when the Stranger suddenly returns to the tent entrance.

He bows low to Fu Yuan — a bow of peers.

"This humble one has spent a lifetime building what I thought was a perfect 'Structure,'" the Stranger says softly. "Today, I realize I was merely constructing the most impregnable of jails, imprisoning myself as surely as my followers."

He smiles, a human expression finally breaking the mask, and pats Fu Yuan on the shoulder. "If you ever have need of me, you know where to find me."

"This trip was not in vain," he sighs, shaking his head. He strides out of the tent into the dark, never casting a glance back at the others.

Fu Yuan sleeps until noon the next day. When he emerges, Gurban and the Cousin's entourage are gone. The campsite is clean.

The Scion finds him and punches him hard in the chest. "You absolute madman! I have never seen my cousin so furious!"

Before Fu Yuan can speak, the Scion bursts into laughter.

"But he left them! The Three Hundred Iron Cavalry, and thousands of his finest troops. From this day forward, brother... they belong to us."

Chapter 73: The Venerable

Fu Yuan has not set foot in the Central Plains for an age. On this day, seized by a sudden caprice to see what face the world now wears, he changes into a white robe, shears his hair short, and, accompanied by the Wooden Man, departs the Great Steppe.

Scarcely has he entered the Middle Kingdom when he senses a shift in the wind of the times. Along the road, he sees them everywhere: figures clad in flowing black robes, their hair worn long and loose, regardless of gender. In this sea of ink, his own white attire and cropped hair make him a jarring anomaly, a drop of milk in a dark ocean.

Stranger still are the slogans plastered upon the city walls.

One reads: *"Life is dear, love is dearer. But for the sake of Freedom, both can be cast aside."*

Another proclaims: *"Worship is a shackle, not a liberation. The abject soul who kneels before gods and gurus has no right to speak of Enlightenment!"*

The Wooden Man starts. "That sounds like something you've said once."

Fu Yuan nudges him. "Keep your voice down."

The Wooden Man's eyes swivel in their sockets, mesmerizing the children by the roadside.

A peddler tugs at the automaton's sleeve. "Sir, you bear a striking resemblance to the ' Wooden Venerable.' This humble merchant has a few right here — freshly consecrated, carved from premium nanmu wood. Would you care to invite one into your home?"

He produces several wooden figurines. They are dead ringers for the Wooden Man, though smaller in stature and crafted from far superior timber. On their backs, stamped clearly: **Product of Freedom Hall**, accompanied by a motto that sounds suspiciously like Fu Yuan's own rhetoric.

Fu Yuan, amused by the exquisite craftsmanship, pays for one. But this act of commerce summons a swarm of other vendors, pulling and dragging at him, an unbearable nuisance. He barely manages to shake them off when yet another hand tugs at his sleeve. He turned, ready to unleash his fury, only to find himself staring at a monk — an acquaintance, no less.

Fu Yuan bursts into laughter. "Buzhou the Boatless! You bald thief, you haven't popped off to the Pure Land yet?"

Buzhou grins, his face a map of wrinkles. "This small monk's cultivation is too shallow; I wouldn't dare check out so casually. That the Grand Advisor hasn't yet ascended to the skies — that is the true oddity."

The two follow the monk to his small temple. It is a place of peeling paint and desolation. Yet, in the courtyard stands a colossal Winter Sweet — a Wax Plum tree — its yellow blossoms exploding in a riot of life.

Buzhou serves tea. "In this age, those who believe in gods and Buddhas grow fewer by the day. The incense smoke thins. I am fortunate to have this millennial plum tree; it still lures a few tourists through the gates."

When Fu Yuan asks about the black-robed masses and the slogans, Buzhou looks at him with genuine surprise. "Brother Pang, do you truly not know? They are all your own spiritual brood!"

It appears that after years of relentless warfare, the belief systems of the old world have collapsed. As the gods fell silent, people were left drifting in a void, desperate for meaning. At some unknown point, Fu Yuan's doctrine of the "Free Man" began to catch fire. It started in the intellectual circles, swept through high society, and then, fueled by merchants smelling profit, the black robes and wooden pendants became the height of fashion. Now, if one cannot recite a few catchphrases from the Analects of the Grand Advisor, one is viewed with disdain.

Buzhou produces a paperback volume: *Thus Spoke the Khan's Grand Advisor* . "Look, even this poor monk has begun to study. A pity I am old and my memory fades; I often botch the catchphrases."

As they spoke, a group of tourists enters the temple. Buzhou rushes to attend to them, and Fu Yuan, with the Wooden Man in tow, follows to watch the spectacle.

The group is composed of men and women in black robes, wooden pendants resting against their chests. They cluster around a tall, middle-aged man. With his shoulder-length hair, billowing black garments, unbridled expression, and piercing gaze, he looks more like Fu Yuan than Fu Yuan does.

The Wooden Man notes a detail: though all wear black, the silk ribbons tied at their waists differ in color. The young wear white. The elders wear green, blue, or red. The mentor himself appeared unadorned at first glance, but a closer look reveals a ribbon of pure black.

The crowd chatters around the plum tree. A young girl asks, "Old monk, I heard the Patriarch once stayed in this very temple. Have you met him?"

"More than met him," Buzhou replies. "This poor monk and the Grand Advisor were bosom friends."

The girl giggles. "You lying monk."

Buzhou assumes a solemn face. "Monks do not utter falsehoods."

A young man produces a silver ingot and presses it into Buzhou's hand. "My junior sister loves stories of the Patriarch. Tell her one, quickly."

Buzhou pockets the silver and leads the youths toward the tea room, but not before casting a sly, conspiratorial wink at Fu Yuan over his shoulder.

The black-robed man remains standing under the tree, hands clasped behind his back, letting the falling petals settle on his hair and shoulders.

A "Red Ribbon" asks softly, "Venerable One, the spring light is enchanting. Why do you seem touched by sorrow?"

The Venerable opens his mouth, his voice rich with magnetic resonance. *"Before me, I see not the ancients; after me, I see not the comers..."*

He sighs. "The wisdom of the Patriarch, set against the ignorance of humanity, is like a comet tearing through the dark night. Blindingly brilliant, yet gone in an instant. This is what it means to say: *Before me, I see not the ancients.*"

"We, as Free Men, have broken the shackles of order, extinguished the bonfires of blind faith, and shattered the cage of absolute truth. Yet the masses still bob and sink in the sea of un-freedom, life after life. This is: *After me, I see not the comers.*"

He looks up at the plum blossoms. "This tree knows to wither and bloom, cycling through eternity. But the wisdom of the Free Man — if we do not strive to inherit and pass it on fears extinction. The weight of this responsibility... it gives one pause."

The disciples are moved deeply. Several Green and Blue Ribbons begin to sob quietly.

Fu Yuan cannot help himself. He bursts into loud laughter, drawing angry glares from the assembly.

The Venerable asks gently, "This brother appears not to be of our school. Do you have some enlightenment to share?"

Fu Yuan laughs a while longer before stopping. "I see that your Patriarch's wisdom is rather limited. If his philosophy of the 'Free Man' were truly effective, how could it produce a brood like you — people who worship him as an idol, treat his words as dogma, and use colored ribbons to enforce a hierarchy?"

The Venerable pauses, then smiles — a forgiving, knowing smile. "Brother, it seems your understanding of freedom is limited. Which is understandable. Look at the sun." He points to the sky.

"It is merely a ball of fire, yet it brings light and warmth to the world, so people respect and love it. The Patriarch is the same. He never taught men to idolize him, yet his thoughts dispelled the ignorance of the common man. We Free Men respect and love him for this. Is that wrong? If, to prove we do not worship, we deliberately feign indifference, is that not simply another form of attachment? A Free Man is exactly one who dares to love and dares to hate."

"As for the Patriarch's catchphrases, are they not the manifestation of wisdom? Years ago, by the river, the Patriarch taught Friar William the principle of the raft. Without the tool, one cannot cross the river. We Free Men have shattered the obsession with absolute truth, but are we so foolish as to reject the tools of wisdom?"

"And as for the ribbons..." He unties the black silk from his waist and drapes it over a low-hanging branch.

"You see? The ribbon is gone. Freedom is a process of constant letting go; it is never achieved in a single step. These ribbons serve to remind us that we have not yet reached the ultimate state of freedom. The unfree man sees only the ribbon. The Free Man holds no ribbon in his heart."

This speech not only fills the crowd with joyous admiration, it sends the Wooden Man's eyes spinning wildly. Even Fu Yuan is momentarily stunned into silence.

The "Red Ribbon" from before steps forward, pulling several cards from his robe. He hands them to Fu Yuan and the Wooden Man. "Our meeting today cannot be accidental. If one knows how to observe and utilize the raised threads on the fabric of fate, one can manufacture circumstances to rewrite fortune. If you two are interested, you might come and experience our course — the first session is free."

Inside the meditation room, Buzhou listens to Fu Yuan's recounting and roars with laughter. Seeing the two "experience cards" in danger of being crumpled in Fu Yuan's grip, he snatches them away and tucks them into a drawer. "These are useless to you. Leave them for this poor monk to give away as gifts."

Fu Yuan looks out the window.

It is late spring. A breeze sighs through the courtyard, and the petals of the Wax Plum drift down in a chaotic, beautiful cascade — a golden rain.

This coarse, blackened trunk has lived for a thousand years. It has birthed countless branches, and bloomed with countless flowers.

Which branch is the original? Which blossom is truly free?

Chapter 74: The Final Lesson

Night falls upon the Imperial Palace like a heavy curtain.

In the Emperor's chamber, a solitary red candle burns down to a stubborn stump. The flame sputters and gasps, fighting the encroaching dark. A eunuch, moving with practiced brings a fresh taper to replace it.

Emperor Ling, frail as a dried leaf, waves a trembling hand. "Let it be."

As the second Emperor of the Great Yuan, Ling's life — when measured against the towering shadow of his father, the Great Khan — lacks the thunder of conquest, yet it possesses a jagged, tragic geography all its own.

In his youth, his heart is a vessel of grand illusions. He dreams of being like his elder brother, born to the wild steppe, riding alongside their father to break the spine of the world.

In manhood, he seeks to build rather than destroy. In Lingzhou, he constructs a City of Ideals, only to watch it incinerated by the fires of human fanaticism. His "Southern Frontier Model" sweeps through the empire like a fresh wind, only to be strangled by his father's own hand, leaving Ling to rot in a prison cell.

He lives a life of violent oscillation. He is the Crown Prince of the Empire, and then a nameless grunt in the snow. He is the favored son, watching the palace flowers bloom and fade in comfortable captivity; he is a banished shepherd, reading the text of the universe in the rolling clouds of the frontier.

"Your Majesty... Your Majesty?" The eunuch's voice seems to drift in from a distant shore.

Ling opens his eyes, forcing his gaze to anchor on the dying candle flame.

"The Grand Advisor is here."

At the sight of Fu Yuan, a spark returns to Ling's eyes. He manages a weak smile. "You are just in time, Grand Advisor. This is my final lesson. But the teacher today... is neither you, nor I."

Fu Yuan nods and sits silently at the bedside.

Ling studies the face of his mentor for a long moment. "Those who studied under you... my father, my brother... they were giants. They towered over me." His voice is ravaged, sandpaper on stone, yet strangely calm.

"In my memory, triumph is always a fugitive spark, while failure is the eternal night. Even when I finally ascend the throne, I feel no joy, for my heart has long since let go of desire. And now, I face my final defeat. I am losing to life itself."

He stares into Fu Yuan's eyes, a child seeking a father's validation, a flush of fever coloring his pale cheeks.

"Tell me truly. Am I a failed student?"

Fu Yuan's eyes are deep pools, undisturbed by the wind. Slowly, deliberately, he nods.

Ling laughs, a dry, rattling sound. "You see? I seek one last comfort from you, and I fail even at that."

He clears his throat, fighting for breath. "You taught me to be a Free Man. But I was dull-witted. I never quite grasped the lesson. Luckily, in life, one can fail and fail again; one can retreat and retreat again."

"But look at me now. I have no ground left to yield. I have no time left to fail. I possess the world's greatest teacher, yet I am the world's worst student."

"Though I am the Son of Heaven, I cannot command the tides of existence. Before the face of Death, I am but a man. Fu Yuan..."

He struggles to raise his head. "I will never leave this bed again. Tell me... am I free?"

Fu Yuan shakes his head.

Ling nods in agreement, his eyes closing slowly, a faint, paradoxical smile touching his lips. "And yet... and yet, somehow, I feel profoundly free."

Fu Yuan repeats the words softly, weighing them like gold: "I am not free, but I am very free..."

"A contradiction, is it not?" Ling whispers.

Fu Yuan shakes his head. "Freedom is born in the cradle of constraint. To touch the boundless, one must first grasp the bars of the cage."

"You were never my most brilliant student, Your Majesty. But you were always the most honest one."

Fu Yuan leans in, his voice dropping to a resonant hum. "If a man refuses to admit his chains, he spends his life wrestling with ghosts. He mistakes freedom for escape, thinking it means outrunning his fate. But that is a lie. That 'freedom' only forges new irons — be they ideals, faith, or power."

"True freedom lies not in the breaking, but in the knowing. It is the clarity of the waking mind — to know the terrible weight of fate, and to accept the necessity of the limit."

Fu Yuan gazes down at the man who, though younger in years, looks far more ancient than himself. His eyes hold a profound, wordless emotion.

"When a man ceases to view Fate as an adversary, he has already surmounted it. When he stops looking for Liberty on the far shore, he finds he is already swimming in its waters."

Ling lets out a long, satisfied sigh. "So that is the way of it."

A sudden light, clear and sharp, floods his eyes. "If Fate is not my enemy, then how can I be defeated? Master... for this final class, let us yield the teacher's chair to Fate."

Dawn breaks over the capital.

Fu Yuan and his entourage stand on the ridge of the mountains outside Dadu. Once they crest this peak, the vast embrace of the steppe awaits them. The Wooden Man and the servants look back at the city, laid out below like a rigid chessboard, their eyes lingering with reluctance.

But when they turn around, Fu Yuan is already gone. He walks with a stride that holds no memory of the city behind him.

In the morning mist, his silhouette, clad in a rough straw raincoat, begins to blur into the landscape. The servants hurriedly shoulder their burdens and run to catch up.

As the poet sings:

With bamboo staff and straw sandals, lighter than a horseman, I tread.

In a cloak of rush, I walk life through mist and through rain, unburdened. I look back at that bleak and desolate path, where I came.

The wind, the rain, and the sun... they are one and the same.

Chapter 75: Silence

The second year of Emperor Ling's reign is a season of abundance. The rains are punctual, the winds tempered, and the Great Yuan Empire basks in a newfound clarity of rule. But the era of the founders has ebbed away. The Great Khan is dead. Of the iron brotherhood that carved this realm from the earth, only Fu Yuan and a few brittle elders remain.

The imperial court is now a sea of young, hungry faces — the "New Guard." They are men of ambition, restless and untested. When Fu Yuan occasionally deigns to attend the morning audience, he still occupies the station of honor. It is a sight that draws a cold tide of murmurs.

During this morning's session, Zhao Wujiu, Grand Scholar of the Hanlin Academy, strikes.

"The Grand Advisor's merits under the Late Emperor are eternal," Zhao declares, his voice ringing through the hall. "But the world has turned. After great chaos comes the need for great order. As our spiritual lodestar, he should be a monument of virtue. Instead, he peddles this 'Free Man' heresy. It is a betrayal of the state."

He flings his challenge like a gauntlet:

"If every soldier learns 'freedom,' who shall march to war?"

"If every merchant learns 'freedom,' who shall pay the tithe?"

"If every subject learns 'freedom,' who shall obey the law?"

Silence smothers the hall. The few surviving elders tremble with a silent, impotent rage, their god insulted before their eyes. The younger officials trade glances, their lips curled in triumph. Every eye in the palace fixes upon Fu Yuan.

Fu Yuan does not offer a rebuttal. Instead, he falls away from the room, surrendering to the images surfacing in his mind.

In his mind's eye, the sky is the color of lead. A black fortress is wedged between two peaks like a jagged bone. A young Scion stands upon the ramparts, screaming into the gathering crowd below, his voice raw with the thrill of conquest:

"Does anyone on this great steppe dare look down upon us now?!"

The Scion gestures to Fu Yuan at his side: *"With my brother here, is there anything in this world we cannot achieve?!"*

Though they number fewer than fifty, their roar drowns the howling north wind, shaking the very snow from the mountain crests: *"Nothing! Nothing!"*

Fu Yuan's silence unmoors Zhao Wujiu. The Scholar's rehearsed tirades find no purchase; he is a man stabbing at a ghost. Confused, he turns to the throne.

Emperor Ling's face is a mask of oceanic calm. He gazes at his teacher — this silent, isolated figure — and is suddenly pulled back to a midsummer night heavy with the scent of oil-lamps and blossoms.

In the imperial garden, Fu Yuan's black robes had merged with the gloom, making him appear like a great, looming bat. His voice had been a low, warm vibration: *"What is the difference between a man who fears terror and a man who fears the dark?"*

"Remember, little Prince — darkness is not your enemy. Only through fear do we recognize our limits. And only by knowing our limits can we hope to transcend them."

In the present, the Emperor casts a long, chilling look at Zhao Wujiu. The Scholar instantly hits the floor. The Emperor stands and waves a dismissive sleeve.

"The court is dismissed."

By afternoon, the capital is ablaze with the news. Zhao Wujiu's words are copied and traded until paper in Luoyang becomes a luxury. He is the man of the hour, his fame reaching a fever pitch.

Inside the Imperial Study, the Emperor and Crown Prince Zheng sit over a go board. The black stones are in full retreat. The Emperor lifts a white piece, hesitates, and sets it down with a smile.

"Zheng'er, your skill is now peerless," the Emperor says. "If you hold back this much, even my victory feels hollow."

Zheng rises in a flurry of haste. "Father jests. Go is a minor path. Statecraft is the true game." He pauses, his eyes bright with an irrepressible excitement. "Today, in the hall, there was a masterstroke played. Everyone thinks Zhao Wujiu won and the Grand Advisor lost, but I suspect it is not so simple. I wish for Father to resolve my confusion."

"What is it you wish to ask?" the Emperor asks with a smile.

Zheng considers his words. "Of this world, who is a greater orator than the Grand Advisor? Why remain silent against such baseless slurs?" He can barely hide his excitement. "Is he baiting a trap? Perhaps he is waiting to strike with thunderous force and wipe out Zhao's faction in a single blow?"

The Emperor snorts. "The Grand Advisor is a hero of the age, a man of light. He would never stoop to such shadows!"

Zheng drops to his knees in terror. The Emperor pulls him up, brushes the dust from the boy's robes with a tender hand, and says, "Zheng'er, tell me: does the eagle soaring in the heavens explain the breadth of the sky to the sheep in the mud?"

The Prince stares, blank-faced.

"Silence is gold," the Emperor says, his voice grounding the room. "What use is there in debating the meaning of the sky with those who only know the safety of the pen? If the Grand Advisor had spoken, he would have already lost."

Zheng's face lights up with realization, followed by a flush of indignation. "Then why not seize Zhao Wujiu for his insolence?"

"Seize him?" The Emperor looks into his son's eyes, and the Prince hurriedly lowers his head. A cryptic smile touches the Emperor's lips. "And then what? Shall I — or you — be the one to tell the world that Zhao is wrong?"

He picks up a black stone, rolling it between his fingers.

"Understand this: ninety-nine percent of the people in this world are sheep who need a fold, not eagles who crave the sky. Zhao Wujiu's 'truths' are the walls of that fold. A ruler's first duty — before the sheep have grown wings — is to protect them from the wolves. You reinforce the fence; you do not tell them 'you should all fly.' To tear down those walls now would not be a liberation. It would be a massacre."

Zheng's face turns from red to white. He is speechless.

"If I, as Emperor, declared the Grand Advisor's teachings the sole truth," the Emperor continues, shaking his head at his son's shock, "then 'Freedom' would instantly become the new Imperial Decree. It would become a dogma, a subject for the civil service exams. His philosophy would become a tool for careerists — another cage, invisible but far stronger. If I had defended him, I would have been the one to destroy him."

Zheng scratches his head, a rare moment of genuine confusion breaking through. "Then... is Zhao Wujiu right or wrong? I am utterly lost."

The Emperor laughs. "His sophistry only scares children like you and those loyal, senile old men in the court. In the current order of the 'sheepfold,' a society of 'Free Men' cannot exist. And if a society truly evolved to be composed of Free Men, its very structure would have transcended the need for sheepfold rules."

"Do you not see? Zhao Wujiu's argument is nothing more than a ghost story told by a shepherd to scare himself," he says, looking out the window.

Meanwhile, across the city, Fu Yuan also stands by a window. Behind him, his old comrades are finished with their grumbling, nursing their wine in bitter silence. He pushes the sash open, takes a deep breath of the cool air, and looks toward the palace in the distance.

He shakes his head and smiles.

Chapter 76: The Port of Genoa

News that the Grand Khan's colossal armada has anchored at the Port of Genoa sweeps through the city in scarce half an hour. Under the gaze of thousands, Fu Yuan, clad in robes of black treads slowly across a pontoon bridge strewn with fresh blossoms. The Doge, Baldassare, and the Bishop have been waiting upon the quay for a considerable time.

The feast is barely concluded when a report arrives: the Scourge of the Seas, a pirate hunted by every nation of the Mediterranean, has been taken.

The Doge is overjoyed. "God has manifested His power! The Envoy is truly blessed by the Heavens!"

It transpires that this wretch had raided a fleet bearing tribute to the Great Khan years ago, only to vanish without a trace. Who could have foreseen he would surface here today? After pawning a few priceless gems, he made for a tavern to gamble with abandon, where he was recognized by a brother-in-arms from his navy days. Together with the City Guard, they subdued him; all involved in the capture suffered minor wounds.

As they speak, the man is dragged forth. It is — to the shock of all — the "Monkey King," Alexander.

His raiment is in tatters, his face a swollen mask of bruises. Meeting Fu Yuan's burning gaze, he lowers his head in shame. The days cast adrift on Monkey Island bred in him a sickly terror of "solitude" — wherever a crowd gathers, he must press into the throng. Upon reaching the bustling ground of Genoa, he naturally could not restrain himself. Heeding no counsel, he stole away into the city for debauchery, courting his own ruin.

Fu Yuan says with pleasure: "On this journey, aside from paying respects to His Holiness the Pope, I was charged by the Great Khan to capture this beast and escort him back to Dadu. We have a saying in my land: 'We scour the endless steppe for the wolf, only to find him sleeping by our own campfire.' It seems Genoa is indeed a land under God's favor. I shall make sure the Pope hears of this miracle."

Baldassare is elated. He orders the prisoner immediately packed into the stoutest iron cage and conveyed to the Envoy's ship, while lavishing rewards upon the informant.

Fu Yuan raises a hand. "On the steppe, we hold no sin viler than betraying a friend for glory. Yet, the Great Yuan's laws are ever clear on rewards and punishments. Pray, Governor, reward the informant on my behalf, and then, in accordance with the rules of our grassland, have him publicly given thirty lashes with a horsewhip. I shall then have no need to drag him before the Great Khan."

The assembly is stunned. But Baldassare reacts with swift wit, bowing low. "Your Excellency, rest assured. Pray report to the Great Khan on my behalf: this official shall personally pull down that fellow's breeches!"

Fu Yuan rises from the table; the crowd hurriedly attends his departure.

Back upon the ship, Fu Yuan releases Alexander from the iron cage. The pirate forcefully kisses the hem of his robe.

Fu Yuan says only: "It is of no consequence."

Friar William fetches salves to dress Alexander's wounds, scolding him with a pained heart. "The Lord says He is with those who mourn. Dear Alexander, solitude is not dreadful; what is dreadful is that you flee the Lord's grace out of fear. That silence is the very moment to hearken to the Lord's voice — why must you use worldly revelry to escape it?"

Alexander is ashamed, making only submissive sounds.

Fu Yuan shakes his head. "The solitude he endured on Monkey Island was a calamity. It was physiological, bearing no relation to thought or faith. Consider: were a field mouse trapped upon that isle, would it suffer loneliness?"

William and Alexander freeze simultaneously.

"Therefore," Fu Yuan spreads his hands, "that is merely because the species are different, bound by differing laws of survival."

William asks earnestly: "Grand Advisor, you often use the solitary eagle to symbolize the Free Man, and the herding sheep the unfree. The former seems not only to fear no solitude but to love it. Could it be that your philosophy transcends the limits of species?"

Fu Yuan laughs. "Your God created the species, and endowed them with their various chains. If I could ignore these chains, would I not be more brilliant than God?"

He then grows serious. "You are confusing two wholly different vessels."

He hands William an empty wine cup. "The first is this empty cup. It thirsts to be filled by external things — be it crowds, voices, the approval of others, or the expectations of society. It stems from lack."

He fills the cup with red wine gifted by Baldassare, signaling Alexander to take a draught. "This is wine from the Abbey of Saint-Émilion. According to the Doge, even the Pope uncorks such a bottle only on Christmas Eve."

Watching the pirate swallow the wine, he reveals a satisfied look. "The other is this cup, filled with fine wine. It is self-sufficient. It needs no external thing to prove itself; its state of

existence depends entirely on itself. It is a 'cognitive' independence, a high degree of sobriety. It is not swept up by the collective hallucination, nor is it terrified of its own independence from the world."

"The state of the Free Man is the latter — he does not flee the world, nor does he refuse the world. He simply refuses to be defined by the world."

Alexander shows a look of fascination. "The state you speak of... I yearn for it greatly." Then his eyes darken. "Though my limbs are sound, it seems now the defect in my heart is so vast even the Lord cannot aid me. Have I lost all title to be a 'Free Man'?"

Fu Yuan laughs involuntarily. "By your logic, if a warrior loses an arm, is he no longer a brave man?"

His gaze searches the deep black surface of the sea. Suddenly, several silver arcs leap from the water, gliding through the air for a stretch before submerging again. It is a school of flying fish; they skim close to the hull, as if provoking the souls on board.

Fu Yuan's eyes show a look of appreciation.

"Freedom is not the absence of limitation, but the choice to leap amidst limitation. Their wings can never fly high, but that brief flight is eternal freedom."

"Whose heart bears no trauma? Whose life knows no limitation? The qualification for freedom lies only in whether you dare to leap out of the water."

In the cabin, under the flickering candlelight, Friar William dips his quill in ink, recording what he has seen and heard this day:

> Tonight, I once again witnessed the strange catechism of this Eastern sage. Facing Alexander's soul, near collapse from extreme isolation, he did not, like the Gospel of my Lord, offer comfort or the hope of salvation.
>
> He simply... coldly pointed out the reality. He attributed the pain that is enough to swallow the mind to a defect inherent in the creature known as "man," rather than a sin or

trial of the soul.

I have never heard a philosophy so "honest," nor one so lacking in "hope." It promises no cure, depicts no Further Shore, and does not even posit that a "better" state necessarily exists. It seems to demand only one thing: to see clearly where one stands, whether that place be Heaven or Hell, and admit it is true.

This confuses me, and stirs a faint unease. Is the price of truth that one must abandon all desire for "salvation"?

Laughter drifts in. He looks through the window toward the deck, only to see Fu Yuan and Alexander exchanging cups, chatting and laughing, evidently both slightly tipsy. Fu Yuan seems to know William is watching; he draws a new bottle of wine, uncorks it, and waves the vessel in this direction, signaling William to join.

William smiles bitterly and shakes his head, dropping the quill, and pushes the door open to go out. On the opposite shore, the entire city of Genoa has sunk into dreams. The clamor and vanity seem blown away by the summer night's sea breeze; only the torches on the deck remain sleepless.